

Lectures on Søren Kierkegaard

[Forelæsninger om Søren Kierkegaard]

University of Copenhagen, 1858–59

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The Lectures

[ed. 1.1] Lectures on the Relation of Modern Philosophy to Christianity. (**Autumn Semester 1858.**)

[ed. note]

Lecture 1

As the purpose of the lecture course it was stated: to arrive, through the historical-critical investigation, at a *present-day* problem: the relation between faith and knowledge, religion and philosophy, as it is posed in our day in the question of the possibility of a *science of faith*. But this problem, which coincides with the problem of the relation of the religious, and specifically of the *Christian*-religious, to reason and thinking, leads on to a more comprehensive problem: the relation of the Christian to those spheres of spiritual life which *simultaneously with* Christianity have developed into distinctive forms, which as a rule are designated by the predicate “*Christian*”, (thus: *Christian state*, *Christian ethics*, *Christian art* etc.)

In other words, the problem to which we are led is to be posed thus: is Christianity a power [ed. 1.2] embracing and pervading the whole of spiritual life, which takes up into itself all the forms of spiritual life, or is Christianity something particular, which stands only *alongside* other forms of spiritual life without being able to enter into an organic unity with them; — and in that case: is the task this: to make a choice between Christianity and what stands outside Christianity; — or: is it possible, with the consciousness of the discrepancy and the heterogeneity, to assign each of the two a separate sphere in the [73] human spirit? The answering of this question leads, if not to a reconciliation of faith and knowledge, yet to a clarification of the actual relation between them, to an annihilation of illusions that prevent a firm and self-conscious choice.

I emphasized, as the reason why I had chosen the historical-critical form for the lecture course instead of contenting myself with conceptual developments, *partly* this, that the determination of the Christian had in our day become so uncertain through its being mixed up with the humane that it was necessary to go back to the [ed. 1.3] times when the factors that are now unclearly mixed appeared in their original sharpness, and from there to follow the struggle between them in order to become conscious of the distinctive features of both; — *partly* this, that I wished to seek the objective testimony

of history for what I set forth, and to let the conceptual development come into being successively by way of the historical presentation. —

After these introductory remarks I went on to set out *the plan for the lecture course* (following the enclosed outline, which was carried out more precisely orally [*ed.* see below]). Anticipating the result of a critique of our age's philosophizing attempts at restoration, I showed how their failure must lead to the consciousness that the reconciliation between Christianity and philosophy had at least *not yet* succeeded, and through this consciousness to the setting up of a formula that was to secure to each a separate domain, but in such a way that the religious stood highest. (*Kierkegaard*). With the critique of this formula, then, the historical task would be accomplished, and a result could then be drawn which, if not mediating, would at any rate be clarifying and a safeguard against self-deception.

[*ed. note*]

[*ed.* 1] Lectures on: *the relation of modern philosophy to the Christian, and the attempts to give a "Christian philosophy"*

Introduction.

[74]

1. The general essence of philosophy and of religion.
 2. Philosophy and Christianity.
 3. The various conceptions of the relation of the Christian to concrete natural and moral actuality.
 4. The relation between Christianity and philosophy as it appeared historically in the period of patristics and scholasticism. — The "Christian philosophy" of that time.
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The Philosophy of the Modern Age.

I. *The transitional period:*

1. Polemic against scholasticism.
2. Attacks on Christianity.
3. Reaction. Catholic philosophy.
4. Christian mysticism and theosophy.

II. *The period from Bacon and Descartes to our time.*

1. General characterization of the period. Its designation as the period of the dissolution of the Middle Ages. — The double series of systems. The unlikeness and the likeness in their relation to the principle of Christianity.

2. The *realistic* line of development. — Stages in its relation to the Christian: defensive accommodation — indifferentism[ed. 2], — naturalism, — conscious hypocrisy, — open attack (materialism — atheism.)

3. *the idealistic line of development*. — The possibility of a double relation to Christianity, given by the idealistic principle.

a) *The relation of opposition* — α) conscious opposition to historically formed Christianity: Spinoza, the philosophy of identity, Schopenhauer. — β) Opposition to Christianity, concealed under a reinterpretation of it: the philosophy of the Enlightenment. — Kant, — Fichte; — Hegel.

b) *The relation of agreement*: α) formal agreement: Descartes, β) limitation of the [75] philosophical by the theological interest: Geulincx, Malebranche (NB. *Pascal*); — γ) attempts at mediation: Leibnitz; — δ) attempts at restoration: the philosophy of faith, Schleiermacher, Steffens, Fr. Baader, Schelling's philosophy of revelation, post-Hegelian philosophy. — Critique of these attempts.

4. General result. Consciousness of the discrepancy. *Feuerbach*. Kierkegaard's formula for the separation. Critique of it. — The task of philosophy.

[ed. 1.4] Lecture 2. Introduction

1. *The general (essence) relation of philosophy and religion*.⁴

Since the more determinate concept of religion and of philosophy is to emerge from the analysis of the historical phenomena, namely of the phenomenon that is specifically designated "*Christian philosophy*" (patristic and scholastic philosophy), what remains for the introduction is only to indicate what is generally characteristic of both, *in connection with the common idea*.

As the most abstract determination of religion it may be taken that it is *the human being's relation to the divine*. But this leads at once to the necessity of a closer determination: is it a relation *in thought* or is it an *existential* relation? At this point the relation between thought and existence is still left undecided, and since the question has been raised with particular regard to the determination of the mutual relation of religion and philosophy, while the domain of philosophy is indisputably that of thought, and moreover everything [ed. 1.5] that is to exist for the human being, for human consciousness, must be brought into the forms of consciousness, hence into the forms of thought in the widest sense,

⁴[ed. note]

the answer is provisionally restricted to this: that the religious relation is a relation of consciousness, without its being ruled out thereby that it can also be something other and more.

Religion is thus conceived provisionally as *cognition* of God, and of the definition of the old Protestant dogmatics: *religio est modus cognoscendi colendique Deum*, only the first half is provisionally taken, so that religion and philosophy are accordingly set over against each other as *forms of the cognition of the divine*. The justification for such a provisional restriction lies not only in what was indicated above, but also in the basic [76] religious category: *revelation*, which expresses that religion, as a divinely communicated *truth*, enters into relation with the receptive human *consciousness*, and through this into relation with human *knowledge*.

When religion and philosophy thus meet in being a relation to the divine through consciousness, and when it is assumed to be possible that the divine is accessible to philosophy, which, if the opposite[ed. 1.6] were assumed, would cease to exist, since philosophical knowledge would cease to deserve that name if the highest and concluding, that which in the last instance grounds all knowledge, were excluded from it, then the next task is to determine what separates them within that likeness. We can find a starting point for the solution in the common idea of philosophy. To the name of philosophy consciousness most immediately attaches the vaguer idea of a *thinking consideration of the thing*. But when what lies in this idea is developed more determinately, we are carried a long way forward. In considering things thinkingly, we apply the laws and forms of thought to them, and since these prove to be universal and universally valid, thinking does not stop at the partial, but seeks the all-embracing connection, seeks to comprehend the wholeness of things, existence as totality. And as it advances in this comprehending and finds the forms of thought to be the essentialities of things, it finds *itself* again in things, and in the comprehended whole its own self-unfolding. Philosophy thus becomes *the systematic unfolding of logical thought as the ideal image of existence*; or in other words, it is *the reason that through objectivity*[ed. 1.7] *has been confirmed*. But in this determination lies a consequence that becomes important for the relation of philosophy to religion. Philosophy is thought unfolded *by the very energy of thought*, a *result*, then, not something *immediately* given. Immediate consciousness is consciousness held fast in *sense impressions* or in *feeling*, which has not yet freely acquired itself in the form of universality. The consciousness striving from the unfreedom of immediacy toward the freedom of thought is *intuiting*, *representing* consciousness; in it thinking begins to stir, but thought has not yet found its own form. And since this form constitutes philosophy,

[77] philosophy becomes something *acquired*, and as such the property only of those who themselves produce it, — the property of *individuals*.

In contrast to this stands *religion*, as addressing itself to *all* human beings at whatever level of consciousness: the *form* of religion — of the content there is as yet no question at this point — must therefore be one that is accessible to all; it cannot be the acquired — and self-acquired — form of thought, — it must be that of feeling and of *representation*, the latter especially insofar as the religious content becomes the *object* of consciousness. Provisionally, then, [ed. 1.8] the difference between philosophy and religion — within the domain of cognition — is determined by the difference between *thought* and *representation*.

Through this difference in form, however, the problem of the relation is carried a step further. Since the form of thought is that of *universality*, of the *concept*, the absolute is conceived by philosophy as *idea*; the unconditioned content is conceived in a form that is adequate to it; the inner movement of the concept becomes the expression of the movement in itself of the absolutely concrete content. The life-process of the absolute idea is seen sub specie æterni as an *eternal* process, in which the basic forms of existence become moments that have their ideal subsistence in the whole. And the eternal ideal process, which is conceived in the thought-form of universality, is eo ipso conceived in the form of *necessity*, but a necessity which, as one with the self-unfolding of the absolute, is eternally transfigured into *freedom*.

As distinct from this, the absolute, when it is conceived in the form of *representation*, is determined — provisionally at least *formally* — by the peculiarity of that form. As the psychological middle term between sensation and [ed. 2.1] concept, representation has in it a moment of both: it combines the receptive dependence of sensation with the freedom of the concept, its singularity with the universality of the concept. What I represent to myself is detached from the immediately given external, transferred from outer space into the inner space of consciousness; it has begun to be separated from the contingencies of the external particular, but as to its content it is still determined by them. The consequence of this is that what is taken up into representation is affected by the form of sensuousness, and since the absolute is to be conceived through it, its universal essence must be intuited in a *sensuous image*, its eternal, ideal movement within itself, [78] through which it has its content, as a *process in time*, whose individual moments fall apart *before* and *after* one another: the forms of the *image*, of *myth* and of *history* become inseparable from the absolute.

Here the question now arises: *does this difference in form entail a similar difference in*

content? is it not the same absolute content that passes through both forms, untouched by their difference? This question of the mutual relation of form and content, which, as a question of the relation of the two categories[*ed. 2.2*] to each other, must find its answer in logic, and in its more concrete form, with particular regard to religion and philosophy, can find it only through the development of the historically given, can nevertheless already be answered here in general, by way of indication. It is already evident here that a spiritual content can be clothed in a form inadequate to the content without being transformed for consciousness only when it *has been* present for consciousness in the adequate form. The form then becomes a clothing: *symbol, allegory*. But in the development of humanity the form of religion always precedes philosophy: the absolute is present as an object of *faith* before it is present as an object of *knowledge*. When it takes on the representational form of religion, it has therefore not been present in any other form for consciousness; the form is therefore not merely external, inessential form, clothing; but it is for consciousness the *only* form for the content, and so it counts as the true and *adequate* form. The content thus cannot remain untouched by the peculiarity of the form; it is for consciousness only as *formed* content, and a separation from the form becomes impossible at the original [*ed. 2.3*] religious standpoint. A further separation takes place only through an awakening *reflection*, and at the religious standpoint such a reflection comes forward only in relation to *other*, subordinate religious standpoints. In relation to its own content the religious consciousness is by the nature of the case uncritical: it finds itself again in the content *so formed*.

Now, when this relation between content and form points to the essential influence of the latter on the former, then by the same token a *real difference of content* between philosophy and religion has been made at least probable. The object of both is indeed “the absolute”, but the absolute as such is as yet only an abstract concept, which first receives its closer development through the form by which it is determined.

In the difference of content despite the object’s sameness of name lies a *double* [79] *consequence*. *Partly*, it points to the essentially different standpoint of philosophy and religion; *partly*, there lies in it the possibility of a conflict. Since what is named in the same way, the absolute, what is posited as the highest, is determined differently in the two domains, the difference cannot confine itself merely to the difference⁵ between the two forms of *cognition* of it, [*ed. 2.4*] but their difference, as a difference in the forms of cognition of the highest, seems bound to stand in connection with a difference in *the whole standpoint* (view of life) and in the driving *interest*. On this point too the difference

⁵NB. 1.5. A contradiction with that must be avoided.

can only be indicated provisionally, insofar as it lies in what has already been developed. Since the form of philosophy is thought, but thought in its universality, its universal validity and objectivity, lets the individual vanish, in philosophy the accent falls on *the matter*, the objective. The thinking individual immerses itself in its object, gives itself up to it, and even if, in dissolving the essence of the object into thought, it finds itself again in the object, it is not itself as this single individual, but the objective thought that at once constitutes the essence of the object and of the individual. In philosophy I thus relate myself *disinterestedly, theoretically*; I relate myself *freely* to the object, letting it subsist in its freedom. The relation must turn out otherwise where *representation* is the form of cognition. Since representation is burdened with the form of the sensuous, it is burdened with *unfreedom* / contingency, subjectivity / ,⁶ but to theoretical unfreedom there must correspond a *practical* one. In my relation to the object, theoretical freedom is the condition for my being free myself and letting the object subsist freely in its objectivity. When I am theoretically unfree, [ed. 2.5] I am in practical respects both unfree myself and unable to treat the object according to its objective peculiarity. To the theoretical standpoint which, while striving toward the freedom of thought, still has the unfreedom of sensation within it, there corresponds a practical one in which the will is determined by *desire* and *passion*. What impels here becomes *the individual's* [80] *desire*, its *need* and wishes; and this desire influences the conception of the object. Not *the nature of the matter* but *the heart's need* becomes the decisive thing here,⁷ and while the inadequate theoretical form conditioned an unfree practical relation, this in turn conditions the incongruence of the theoretical conception with the nature of the matter.

As the *second* consequence of the difference of content, *the possibility of a conflict* between the two domains was indicated. This conflict we shall follow in its various forms through the whole lecture course; at this point only the essential possibilities are to be touched on briefly.

When the difference of content becomes known, either religion can hold it fast in its interest, or philosophy in its own. *Religion* can, by declaring its content to be *divine revelation*, set it in opposition to human knowledge. The opposition then becomes one between the infinite and the finite, between divine wisdom [ed. 2.6] and human cleverness, between the Holy Spirit and the human spirit darkened and confused by sin. Where the discrepancy appears, religion uses its language of authority; it denies the ability and the right of finite human thought to grasp the infinite, it requires faith in what darkened reason cannot comprehend, and at most lets reason keep some latitude in the domain of

⁶this must be developed more precisely.

⁷(NB. The miracle, prayer).

the worldly and within the bounds of the formal.

Against this requirement of supremacy on the part of religion, *thinking* that knows of the discrepancy can now come forward with a similar requirement: reducing the religious doctrines to the forms of representation and of imagination, while as the form of truth there steps forward *incorruptible* reason, the organ of divine truth, it vindicates for itself the judgment about the true and the possession of the true, and that not only in the *theoretical* domain, but also, insofar as it maintains the impossibility of ethical action without a rational cognition as its foundation, — in the *practical*. It requires not only that it rule in the theoretical, but that true theoretical cognition shall pervade the whole of human life and become the principle of all the forms of moral life. [ed. 2.7] Against religion's separation of the domain of the divine and of the human, of the infinite and of [81] the finite, it sets the dialectical proof of the inseparability of the two domains.

Through the struggle between these two opposites one may arrive either at an acknowledgment of the hegemony of the one, or at the attempt to delimit the domains of both against each other, so that the relation becomes an apparently neutral one, yet with a supremacy for the religious. These various possibilities will be developed in what follows.

After this provisional development of the relation between philosophy and religion in general, the next task is to determine the relation between philosophy and the particular religion with which these lectures are to be concerned: *the Christian*.

[ed. 2.8] 2. *Philosophy and the Christian religion*.

It might seem that what was developed in the preceding⁸ section about the relation of philosophy to religion must *immediately* be able to find its application to *Christianity*, since this after all falls together with the other religions under the *species* concept religion. But here there appears the possibility, which has been asserted by *Hegel*, that Christianity, although it is united with the other religions in a common genus concept, can be essentially different from them, and thus come to stand in a different relation to reason and philosophy than they do. The “historical” religions preceding Christianity would then express the essence of religion only *partially*, would develop only one-sidedly particular moments of its concept, and precisely in this would lie the fact that they were in disagreement with philosophy, did not fulfill its requirements. Christianity, by

⁸The development must be formulated more precisely.

contrast, as the absolute “revealed” (manifest) religion, would realize the concept of religion, be the adequate expression of it, and eo ipso agree in content with philosophy.⁹

In what has been developed in the foregoing about the form of religion, and about [82] the relation of this form to the content, this possibility has [ed. 3.1] already been judged. The form of representation is posited as the characteristic one, not for a single imperfect form of religion, but for *religion itself*, and it was indicated how the form must affect the content. This implies that, even if a single historically emergent form of religion exhausted the essence of religion, it would nonetheless fall under that determination which holds precisely of religion *as religion*.

And Hegel will not be able to escape this conclusion either, since he precisely holds fast to that distinction between representation and thought, and since, with regard to the relation between form and content, he holds fast in his Logic to their *essential* relation, and where in his philosophy of religion he lets the content be indifferent to changes of form, he does this only by taking the content in a similar indeterminacy as when he lets the name of *religion* cover the *whole* sphere of absolute spirit, and thus also *philosophy*.

Were one to take the identity of philosophy with Christianity seriously, one would not escape *consequences* either that the Christian consciousness would not acknowledge. For were that identity carried through, then the *historical*, which is the foundation of Christianity and the point of departure of the Christian consciousness, [ed. 3.2] would become a merely vanishing garb for an *eternal* process; it would become image, *myth*, not self-valid reality. And at the same time the *transcendence* of the divine as *personal* would vanish: nature and finite spirit would become moments in the very life-process of the absolute; moments that were eternally posited and eternally sublated as ideal.

The premises of philosophy itself and the religious consciousness thus lead to the same result: the rejection of an identification of Christianity with philosophy, and the applicability of what holds for religion to Christianity as well.

But this has here been reached essentially by way of *reasoning*; it must be corroborated by investigating *historically what Christianity is*; which, however, can take place in the introduction only in general outline, and therefore in such a way that the result stands as a hypothesis until the investigation of the concrete historical relations corroborates it. —

[83] [ed. 3.3] Lecture 3

The Christian view of life and the relation of the Christian to concrete natural and

⁹since religion has its root in the thinking nature of the human being.

spiritual actuality. —

If, in answering the question *what Christianity is?* we were to keep to the conception of our time and to the phenomena that now appear in the domain of religious life, then the latter would present a difficulty for analysis on account of the unclarity of their composition, and the time's conception of the Christian would prove so little certain that *two fundamentally different views* stand opposed to each other.

On the *one* side Christianity is held fast in its heterogeneity with everything worldly and with what is accessible to reason. Its center, *the God-man*, is the absolutely incomprehensible, the *paradoxical*, to whose acknowledgment in faith it is not the inferences of reason but the despair of the consciousness of sin that brings one. One does not arrive there *by* thought, but *in spite of* thought and through a break with it: faith grasps the incomprehensible, and in holding it fast with the passion of inwardness, it guards precisely its incomprehensibility against every attempt of thought [ed. 3.4] to appropriate it. And just as Christian *faith* is posited only as having issued from the break with thought, so the Christian *life*, which springs forth from this faith, is posited as having issued from a break with worldliness. Christianity is the religion of *suffering*; its spirit is “*to die away*” from the world; only through this death does it show the way to life. And this *negative* relation to the world is not confined to a single time, as e.g. to Christianity's first historical appearance; as little as the absolute paradox of faith ever becomes more comprehensible with time, so little does the life that rests in it ever become homogeneous with the life of the world. Christianity, which, in demanding death, the death of selfhood and the renunciation of everything worldly outside and within the individual, arouses the resistance of selfishness and worldliness, must constantly stand equally hostile toward “*the world*”; it must at all times be reviled, scorned, hated, persecuted. And where history shows a peaceful relation, that is precisely a sign that Christianity has lost its distinctive character, that it is corrupted by a mixture with the heterogeneous, that it has lowered the ideal requirement, denied itself. In the “*Christendom*” of our time this conception [84] therefore does not recognize [ed. 3.5] *Christianity*; it sees in it only a deception continued through many centuries and carefully concealed; in the *Church* protected by the state only a distorted image of Christianity, whose preachers live *off* Christianity instead of living *for* it. It doubtfully raises the question: *whether Christianity is still to be found on earth*, and in going through the history of the Church, with its ideal before its eyes, right back to its earliest period, it carries this doubt with it right back to that period, and asks doubtfully: have there really *ever* been Christians? has Christianity's ideal requirement *ever* been fully met? And this question is consistent; for can the religion whose principle

is *not* to live in the world, to be dead to the world, really find its perfect expression in the world?

In opposition to this conception of Christianity stands *another*, which extends the name of the Christian to all the forms of spiritual life that have developed *simultaneously with and under the influence of* Christianity. It does not see Christianity in opposition to our time, but as *its animating principle*; it speaks of *a Christian world*, a *Christian state*, a *Christian ethics*, a *Christian art*, a *Christian science*, in a [ed. 3.6] word, it applies the name of Christianity to all forms of the *humane*. The sharp opposition between the principle of Christianity and that of the world it restricts, even if it constantly points to the *apostolic* as what orients, to Christianity's first period, in which the struggle against the forms of the old world had to lead to a *one-sided* opposition. From the moment when Christianity had become victorious, its task was not to be to separate itself from the world, to die away from it, but to *permeate it*; its power was to show itself precisely in this, that it could [ed. note] do this; and the possibility of permeating, as a principle of life, the heterogeneous is sought in this, that Christianity was a *new creation*, which acts *potentiatingly* back upon nature and upon the powers of spiritual life and its laws. Not flight from the world but immersion in the world, not struggle against it but peace with it and dominion over it then becomes Christianity's goal, and in the *Christian state* it has thus been reached, in such a way that precisely the state's acknowledgment of the [85] Christian, its favoring of it in the way of worldly goods, is a proof that the Christianity thus acknowledged is the true one. And this acknowledgment is also granted by *reason* [ed. 3.7] to Christianity. Even if the unregenerate, debased reason does not comprehend the mysteries of Christianity, yet the *believing* reason, potentiated by the new principle of life, is able to penetrate into their depths, and, even if it does not attain *logical* and *mathematical* clarity, it can nevertheless explore the *connection* of the articles of faith and *thereby their*¹⁰ *ground*, and develop a *science of faith*. Philosophy comprehends in Christ the unity of the divine and the human and acknowledges in this unity its own doctrine of the relation of absolute spirit to finite spirit. Christianity is thus reconciled with thought and with the world, for whose concrete forms it becomes the new animating principle of life.

If we now raise the question: *which of these conceptions is the true one*, then at this point it cannot be answered exhaustively, but the answer can only be *indicated* by an indirect proof, and this indication can be made *probable* by *historical* considerations.

If one assumed without further question the *latter* view to be the true one, so that the

¹⁰this presentation had best be kept somewhat ironic-pathetic.

question of what Christianity was were to be answered by analyzing the forms of spiritual life as [ed. 3.8] they have *now* taken shape, since it would then be found as their principle; then through a new question a *new requirement* would at once present itself. Is the unity between Christianity and the forms of spiritual life such that the former can issue from the purely human by a continuous development? — *or*: is it something new which, in entering history in a primitive manner, does not issue from what was historically earlier, even if the latter can *typologically* foreshadow it, but acts potentiatingly back, so that the unity we now find has been brought about through such a potentiation? For one who will not deny Christianity a supernatural origin, the *latter* answer becomes the one that must be preferred. But if it is preferred, then the requirement cannot be dismissed: *first*, to demonstrate the actual inner unity of the specifically Christian with the human, and *second*: to demonstrate in particulars the concrete, the so-called “*potentiation*” of the spiritual faculties and powers that Christianity is supposed to have brought about. Now if it does not succeed – and at least hitherto it has not succeeded – in demonstrating in [86] determinate forms such a¹¹ potentiation, when one compares the individual Christian state, art, science, etc. with those independent of Christianity; or if it succeeds only in demonstrating something specifically different from antiquity [ed. 4.1] as something that does not combine organically with what has issued from the human spirit, then in the latter case we are led back to the view that sets the Christian at variance with the world; in the former we are led to see the Christian as a *natural development* of the ground of the human spirit. But with this latter we would either immediately abandon the religious standpoint, or, if we still wished, by a vague conception, to hold fast to it, and let Christianity be something supernatural although *now*, after having been revealed, it joins together without a break with the purely human, then it would surely have to be asked, *partly*: whether a revelation would not be superfluous when it communicates only what the human spirit could develop¹² of itself; — (*partly*, whether then, with an analysis of what is now called *Christian*, a determination of the essence of Christianity could be found that secured for it a distinctiveness actually explaining its history?)¹³

The *first* of these questions the religious consciousness would naturally have to affirm at once; the *second* / last / would undoubtedly¹⁴ have to be answered in the negative. For a determination of Christianity that proceeded from its *homogeneity with the humane*

¹¹to be carried out ironically.

¹²partly whether such a revelation, revealing nothing, could be maintained as actual.

¹³[ed. note] confused! [ed. note] partly whether the history of Christianity can then be explained on the presupposition of such a joining together with something preceding, and whether it can secure for Christianity an essential distinctiveness.

¹⁴(The development here is somewhat confused).

would have to let the *historical* side of¹⁵ Christianity recede, and essentially bring out the *ideal* side. But [ed. 4.2] in this way it would, even if it could demonstrate a stronger [87] and more determinate appearance of the *universalistic* and *spiritualistic* element than in the¹⁶ philosophical systems that conclude the philosophy of antiquity, not be able to find a view of life that was *in principle* essentially different from what has arisen outside Christianity. Christianity¹⁷ would then enter the series of the historical forms of development of the human spirit; its appearance would not be *a break* in continuity, not a *new creation*; but as such it does, after all, indisputably proclaim itself, while at the same time declaring what historically preceded it to be untruth and sinfulness; whereby the possibility of a continuous development out of it is excluded. / The necessity of Christianity's struggles with the world would become inexplicable. / If that homogeneity were held fast, then all the Christian phenomena in which the break with the world appears most clearly would also have to be posited as one-sidednesses and exaggerations, and *that* would be brought out as the truly Christian in which the agreement with the purely humane appears most decisively.

When these considerations make it, provisionally at least, *probable* that the view which sets Christianity *at variance with the world* is the true one, then this will also find its corroboration by [ed. 4.3] considering the *historical circumstances* under which Christianity appeared, and the *phenomena* through which it, with its appearance, most decisively separated itself from the nature-bound view of life.

If we wish briefly to consider the main forms of spiritual life that formed the presupposition of Christianity, then it is above all the development of the *Greek* and the *Jewish* spirit that must be taken into account. The task of the *Greek* spirit had been to realize the idea of *beauty*, the task of its thought to find the concept of the *idea*, and, proceeding from this, to seek the beautiful, harmonious unity of form and material, spirit and matter. With the nature-life and view of nature of the Orient as its presupposition, it had raised itself from material as principle to form, the idea, had grasped this as the true and only [88] being, and now strove to find the formula for its relation to non-being, matter. But in the course of this search it had to become clear that the Greek spirit, precisely because it rested in the immediacy of beauty, could not carry through the sole being of the idea; it had to end in an unreconciled *dualism*, which led either to skepticism or to a failed

¹⁵would first have to disregard the historical starting point and fix the dividing line solely on the content of ideas.

¹⁶[ed. note] Christianity would then have to be brought together idealistically with the ideal content in the systems that conclude the philosophy of antiquity.

¹⁷(This point must be determined somewhat more precisely orally; it can find its proper development only in the analysis of the phenomenon of Christian philosophy.)

attempt, by raising itself above the foundation of the Greek spirit, nature, to find the solution of the problem in a spiritualistic sphere. But once the idea [ed. 4.4] had been posited as the highest, as the true being, the development could only go in the direction that it, when the consciousness of its incompatibility with matter became clear, is posited as the *only* being, matter as non-being, untrue, *evil*. The task, therefore, that was set by the problem left unsolved by the Greek spirit had to be this: to comprehend *spirit as the only being*, and thus to develop an *abstract-spiritualistic* view. Herein lies a probability that this task was Christianity's.

If we consider the other of the peoples of antiquity whose spiritual development immediately prepared Christianity: *the Jewish*, then we see a similar direction. The earlier Hebraism's secure resting in the present and this-worldly had gradually been transformed, *first* into faith in a *future* worldly messianic kingdom under a ruler of David's line, *then*, under foreign influence, into the development of the doctrine of a spirit-realm that is the prototype and truth of the earthly, and of the idea of a *supernatural* Messiah and a *resurrection* from the dead, and *finally* into an ascetic flight from actuality and into the hope of spirit's perfect *liberation from earthly matter*. Here too, then, there is a striving toward the *supernatural* as the only true, [ed. 4.5] and existence divides dualistically into a kingdom of the world and of matter, the kingdom of the dark powers, and a longingly awaited heavenly [ed. ?] kingdom in a nature-less actuality. From a starting point other than the Greek, the same goal had thus been approached here, and the same task set for a new religion.

When *Christianity* appeared historically where the Greek and the Palestinian views of life met, and at a time when both were developed in the same direction, it was to be expected that its view of life would be the complete expression of what those strove toward. And when one considers the points in Christianity that most decisively characterize it as [89] something new, then it is precisely such as point to an *abstract spiritualism*, which can relate itself only *negatively* to the natural. In the person of the *God-man* faith beholds the living unity of God and the human being, but the human in Christ is detached / , by the *miracle*, which marks *all* the main points of his life, / from the natural conditions of human life; the unity becomes a unity between God and *the nature-less human*, and the *believer's* unity with God through Christ is conditioned by *having died away* from the world, the natural; only as *nature-less spirit* does the human being have unity with God. For *the natural* is viewed as "*lying in evil*", as that which is corrupted [ed. 4.6] by sin, as that to which spirit is to relate itself only negatively. The natural (the natural faculties and powers) is granted no significance for itself; it does not become a material that is

to be formed by the Christian; it becomes only something that is to be cast away. The Christian is to *flee* the relations of natural life, which have no significance for him, but can only become defiling; he is to become *indifferent* to the moral relations resting on a natural ground; for these cannot in their concretion be placed in the positive relation to the abstractly spiritual (e.g. marriage, *political life*, *property*). The determination of the natural is: *in itself to be a nothing*; this is expressed in the dogma of *creation*, which rests on the view of the absolutely mighty nature-less spirit as that which in truth is, and on the view of nature as what has been called forth, by an incomprehensible act of the almighty arbitrariness, to a lived momentary existence. Over against the dogma of creation the concept of natural *laws* and natural *forces* vanishes, and in general that of a “*nature*” as distinct from a creatum. Nature has no being in itself; there can therefore be no talk of laws, which presuppose something substantially abiding; at every moment the divine power must call nature forth out of nothing through *preservation*, and at every moment the divine arbitrary *omnipotence*, which manifests itself through[*ed.* 4.7] the *miracle*, is free to let nature vanish; for it is by its essence something *superfluous*, and not merely that, but something that the Christian longingly wishes away, from whose limitation, which is felt only as oppressive bonds, he wishes himself free, a wish which the hope of *immortality expresses*; for in the Christian heaven every natural limitation is [90] removed, and the idea of immortality expresses precisely what for this life stands as an ideal, but an unattainable one. What the Christian wishes for here, but despairs of being able to attain, he transfers to a life beyond, where what here hinders and weighs down shall have vanished. — And in the same¹⁸ way as the Christian relates himself negatively to nature, he consistently relates himself negatively to *history*. It is not accidental that the first Christians awaited the *Parousia* as imminent: history was, after all, *concluded* with Christ’s coming; its continuation was, after all, necessary only as long as was needed for the peoples to gain knowledge of it. The decision was therefore thought so near that the generation then living would not yet have died out; it was still only a matter of the choice between Christ’s kingdom, which *was not of this world*, and the kingdom of the world, between life in the world and death from the world in baptism, through which the one believing in Christ (Christ’s resurrection) appropriated his life, and now no longer lived in the world, [*ed.* 4.8] but *spiritually*. There was no question of a transformation of the worldly; it is left standing as something indifferent, which did not touch the inner; Christianity was not to recreate the world, but to create a new life that was *not* of this world, and this new life was to be livable only through death

¹⁸(NB. “spiritual body”.)

from the world and everything that belonged to the world that was soon to cease. In his death Christ had died from the world; by his *resurrection* he had overcome death, vindicated his divine nature and *secured the victory of the kingdom of God* / of which the pre-Christian consciousness had to despair / ; he had by it made it possible for believers, by giving up their life in the flesh, in him who now lives πνευματικῶς, to live a new spiritual life by which they, in the midst of the world, are raised above the world. — And everything Christian is posited as / *incomprehensible* to the world, as “*foolishness*” to it; only to faith are the mysteries opened, which were inaccessible to *carnal reason*. The wisdom of the world and the wisdom of Christ were absolute opposites. /

We are thus led, through these prominent tenets of Christian doctrine, to side with the conception that characterizes Christianity by the *sharp opposition* between the divine and the *concretely* human, between spirit and nature; which designates an *abstract spiritualism*, which relates itself only negatively to the concrete forms of natural and spiritual [91] life, as its principle. But an *objection* could at once be made here, which must at least provisionally be met. One could point out that Christianity has, after all, *acknowledged* the forms of human life, that it has *entered into connections* with the concretely human[ed. 5.1], and not merely *made use of* the faculties and powers of the human spirit, but also sought to *appropriate* them. To this objection, which in what follows will be met more fully on many points, a provisional answer can already be given here. One can answer with the question: how would an abstract-spiritualistic view of life have to position itself in relation to the concrete forms of human life and to the powers of the human spirit, when the hope of an imminent final conclusion of history was disappointed, and the task now became: with a world-denying principle to live *in* the world, to seek an existence *in the midst of that* which it posited as the untrue? If one pursues this relation, it will easily be seen that the phenomena appealed to become explicable when one proceeds from the conception to which I have given preference, whereas the phenomena that most decisively characterize the classical period of Christianity stand as *incomprehensible* when one proceeds from the homogeneity of the Christian with the humane. —

[ed. note]

[ed. 44.2] (*Spring Semester 1859*)

[92]

Lecture 1

Survey of what was gone through in the previous semester, — summing up of the

results. — Preliminary orienting survey of what follows. — (The development is given according to the points indicated on the enclosed leaf.)

[ed. note]

[ed. 1] *Introductory lecture.* (8/2 59.) (Points.) 1.) *Statement of the relation between what was developed in the previous semester and what remains.* — The latter comprises nothing but phenomena that reach directly into the most recent time; it comprises at the [93] same time representatives of the most essential still-existing conceptions of the religious, and therefore forms a smaller, fairly self-contained whole of its own.

2.) *Retrospect on what has gone before; summing up of its preliminary result.* — The result has hitherto been essentially *negative*; it has been shown that there has *hitherto not* been an agreement between the philosophical systems and Christianity. What was put forward *hypothetically* in the Introduction concerning the relation of religion, and specifically of Christianity, to philosophy as a relation of divergence has found its confirmation negatively; but a *final* result, a *positive*, decisive and exhaustive determination of the relation, has been postponed to what follows. Yet there already exists a *material* from which a *preliminary* result can be extracted. (Here reference is made especially to the account of the character of Scholasticism, of the direction of the transitional period, of the unfolding of the realistic and the idealistic series. What has been given in the earlier lectures is concentrated: in the case of the realistic series the significance of the *nature-moment* is brought out, while the *one-sidedness* in its conception and the ground of the one-sidedness are at the same time pointed out; — in the case of the idealistic, there are brought out: the autonomy of *self-consciousness*, the influence of the *concept of nature*, the conception of the divine as a *rational being* [with preponderance of the theoretical or the practical standpoint], *pantheism*, the abandonment of the *concrete* dogmatic content or of the *historical side*.)

By summing this up, the question will [ed. 2] become answerable: whether the task set at the beginning of the lectures has been realized? Elements show themselves that dominate the spiritual life of modern times but that are foreign to Christianity, and these elements show themselves to be the proper life-principles of modern philosophy. *This* result, then, has been gained: that there is not merely a divergence present between Christianity and the individual systems of modern philosophy, but that what grounds this difference is something essential to the whole of modern times, a positive life-principle. A multitude of phenomena outside the domain of philosophy have been pointed out that have their root in this, and thus fall outside the Christian.

What has been developed is confirmed *further* still by the critique of the systems that come forward with the claim to agree with Christianity. It has been shown that [94] their endeavors to bring about an agreement have rested on an untenable foundation, and that what has prevented their carrying it through has been precisely the direction indicated above, characteristic of modern times.

3.) *Statement of the course of what follows.* — a) *The attempts at restoration.* Their relation to those already criticized (the philosophy of faith, Schleiermacher. — Steffens). — The *reactionary* character in them: *Fr. Baader* (reaction of the medieval direction in philosophy. — The concept of nature. — Theosophy.). — *Schelling*. (The consciousness of the deficiency in the preceding idealistic philosophy; — attempt, instead of taking up the empirical element demanded by this deficiency, [ed. 3] to take up an element of fantasy, by which philosophy,¹⁹ in spite of all endeavors toward a logical deduction, becomes theosophy.) — *Speculative dogmatics*. (its slight scientific value. — It will be treated briefly, since expositions of Hegel have already given the necessary foundation for conceiving it. — The contradiction in its elements. — In demonstrating this contradiction, the *opposite* of speculative dogmatics, the left side of the Hegelian school, will be discussed.). — b). *The consciousness of the divergence.* α) *Feuerbach* (problems that would come under treatment in the exposition²⁰ of his theory.). — β) *Kierkegaard* (relation to Feuerbach. — Demarcation of the domains of religion and philosophy. — The formula for the determination of the boundary. — Problems.).

Final result. — The religious and humane task of the future. —

NB: “*Mankind has never been without religion.*” — Application of this thesis to the determination of the final task. This becomes, on the presupposition that Christianity is no longer the dominant spiritual power, — not: to invent a new religion; for religions are not *invented*; — but: to *find* the religious elements in the spirit of modern times and [95] to see them in their connection and significance.

[ed. note]

[ed. note]

[ed. note]

[ed. 1] *Kierkegaard*. 1. The relation to what precedes (the attempts at restoration — Feuerbach.) General characterization of Kierkegaard’s standpoint and task. — Plan for the exposition of his theory.

¹⁹The historical connection of the “positive” philosophy with Schelling’s earlier philosophy.

²⁰cf. 30,5. 31,1.

Orienting remarks on his relation to speculative philosophy of religion, to ordinary theology, ordinary religiousness, and to Feuerbach.

2. Kierkegaard's personal development. — Childhood influences. — The Christian. — [96] Dialectic. — Study of theology. — Philosophy. — Aesthetics. — Relation to the political. — His authorship — His personality.

3. *Kierkegaard's writings*. — The unity in them. — The task. — Closer determination of it by the situation. — "The category of the authorship" — The movement. — The method. — "The single individual". — The pseudonymity. — Division of the writings into 3 groups. Characterization of these.

[ed. 2] *The categories of existence*.

General statement of the task and the problem. — The historical presupposition of Kierkegaard's standpoint.

The *objective* consideration. — Holy Scripture. — The Church. — The proof from world history. — The speculative truth. (NB. The human being as synthesis of the temporal and the eternal.)

Subjectivity, existing subjectivity in relation to the eternal. — The subjective thinker's interestedness in his thinking. — He places everything in becoming. — The double reflection. — The negative in cognition.

— The subject is "an *existing infinite spirit*." [ed. Cf. SKS 7, p. 81.] (NB. that the eternal *becomes*) — The expression for this — the negative form. — The infinite striving. — Unity of the comic and the pathetic.) — The impossibility of a system of existence. — The subject-object [ed. note]. — The existing thinker cannot be absorbed into the metaphysical.

Subjectivity as the task — The opposition between subjectivity and the objective determination of the matter. — Becoming a subject as the human being's highest task. — (NB. the world-historical and the ethical.)

Subjectivity as the truth.

[ed. Lecture 20 continued:]

[ed. 65.1] (*The separation of philosophy and religion*.) 2. S. Kierkegaard. a) By the problems to which the critique of Feuerbach's conception of religion has led us, we are led to the last formula for the determination of the relation of philosophy and religion that we have to examine: the formula that has been set up *by Kierkegaard*. / The critique [97] of the *attempts at restoration* had shown the untenability of their attempt to bring the view of life of Christianity and of modern philosophy into harmony. *Feuerbach* had, in extending the investigation to religion in general, separated religion's and philosophy's / domains in *the interest of philosophy*; Kierkegaard separates them in the interest of faith,

in order to assert it as the highest form of human existence, its most intensive expression, as *the form of truth in the actuality of existence*. Objective science is acknowledged in its significance; it is assigned its place in the sphere of human life, but a subordinate and limited place. / But from science's *impersonal* relation to the truth is distinguished the existing individual's *subjective relation* to the truth. The inwardness of appropriation as the truth for the existing individual, and the existing individual's / highest truth becomes that in which the *existing* individual has his *essential* interest, which he expresses in his life, that to which he relates himself in *infinite passion* out of his immersion in existence, and this truth is for Kierkegaard *Christianity*.

The task for Kierkegaard thus becomes this: first to assert the distinction between the truth of *life* and that of *science*, the *subjective* and the *objective* truth, and then, when it has been asserted, when the claim of *existence* upon the individual has been decisively made good in opposition to thought's flight from existence, to order the *spheres of existence* and the corresponding[*ed.* 65.2] *views of life*, and to point to Christianity as the highest, eternal, revealed / inaccessible to thought / truth, "to bring it forth in its supernatural greatness." [*ed.* cf. SKS 7, p. 66].

By this task his relation to the contemporary phenomena is determined. *Speculative philosophy of religion* had let religion be a step in the development of spirit that found its completion in philosophy, in speculative thought, which unfolded itself with logical necessity out of the lower form. Only in unity with thought did the content of faith find its true form; this unity was the higher truth; in it the content of faith was penetrated by thought, converted into the concept / and the true as *thought* was the truth. / In *Kierkegaard* the spheres are separated in another way: science becomes one thing, life another; the objective unfolding of thought in the form of objectivity, in the sphere of possibility according to the law of necessity, is divided from the *appropriation* of the truth in the individual in the form of subjectivity, in the sphere of actuality, according [98] to the law of freedom. The personal existence of the truth becomes the highest for the existing individual, and within the personal forms of existence the *religious* becomes the highest, and within the religious in turn what is absolutely inaccessible to thought, the *paradoxical*, Christianity's specific determination, the absolute. The task of thought here becomes not to penetrate with thought, not [*ed.* 65.3] to comprehend, but to hold fast to the paradox *as paradox*, to use thought to discover the opposite of thought, the absolutely unthinkable, so that one may then believe by *virtue of the absurd*.

Ordinary, unphilosophical theology immerses itself *objectively* in learned investigations; through these it wants to bring out what Christianity is as objective doctrine;

by way of history and criticism it wants to secure certainty about this; and during this striving, which by the nature of the case loses itself in an *infinite approximation*, it lets it be the presupposition that the investigator is a Christian, and that what matters is the *scientific result*, whose appropriation is supposed to follow of itself. For Kierkegaard *the infinite decision of existence* is the main thing: the approximation, by which precisely the decision is prevented, is the deception, *appropriation* the task, and the essential thing therefore not a *what* but a *how*. The question is not what Christianity historically is; but the question is: *how do I become a Christian*. The truth is *the inwardness of appropriation*, the truth is *subjectivity*.

/ *Ordinary, so-called religiousness*, which has unconsciously taken up a new age's view of life under the name of Christianity, lets Christianity melt together with the world, become commensurable with it. It lives in the determination of immediacy or in the relations of civic-moral life and calls this life a Christian life, Christian in and for itself or at any rate with an addition of a general religious *mood*, or through participation in worship, or through belonging to the Christian Church. It naturalizes Christianity, and in that it lets having become a Christian [ed. 65.4] have taken place in the child without a personal decision. Against this Kierkegaard sets the opposition between Christianity and the world, their essential dissimilarity, the impossibility of Christianity's being assimilated by the historical process, the necessity of suffering as its distinguishing mark [99] in the world, the necessity of the personality's most painful decision in order to become a Christian, the necessity of positing an absolute relation to the absolute that is not exhausted in the relative relations of actuality. /

[ed. 65.3 continued] In Feuerbach the spheres were separated, religion determined as the irrational, the right of thought asserted against faith, that of sensuousness, of immediate concrete actuality, against the fantastic idealization of the beyond. The moral necessity of atheism was stated, Christianity [ed. 65.4] posited as the untrue, which was to be abandoned. The opposition between Feuerbach and Kierkegaard in the conception of the truth of Christianity is therefore the greatest possible, and yet there is no one with whom Kierkegaard has more points of contact in determining what Christianity is. And this has not escaped him either, and he has, precisely on account of his conception of Christianity, not been able to wonder at it. If the individual's relation to Christianity is a relation of subjectivity, and more precisely one in which subjectivity is at its highest potentiation, in its most energetic *passion*, then besides the believer, who in passion holds fast to it as truth, only *he* can grasp its essence who *in passion rejects it*. The latter, standing outside Christianity, will be able to say decisively and sharply *what Christianity*

is; he will be able to depict it in such a way that the believer can acknowledge his depiction in each and every point. It is undoubtedly Feuerbach whom Kierkegaard has had in mind when, in Concluding Unscientific Postscript p. 473 [ed. SKS 7, p. 558], after having spoken of the confounding of the Christian by theology and by revivalism, he says, “on the other hand: a scoffer attacks Christianity and at the same time presents it so soundly that it is a pleasure to read him, so that one who is at a loss to get it rightly and definitely set forth must almost resort to him.” At this point, ahead of the exposition of Kierkegaard’s conception, I can indicate only by way of intimation[ed. 65.5] his points of contact with Feuerbach; they will become clearer in what follows. They agree in determining the content of religion as something *subjective*²¹ even if the kind of subjectivity is conceived differently; in designating religion’s²² standpoint as the *practical* [100] one; in having the category *the single individual* for the religious person²³ (Feuerbach *Sämmtliche Werke*. I, 92f.); in holding fast to the equal relation of the *incarnation* to all subsequent times (II, 190); in conceiving *the relation between Christianity and the world* as unchangeable (I, 62. note); in letting the Christian’s sympathy be *restricted to Christians*; and in denying a *world* with a being higher than the²⁴ human. These parallels could be increased still further, but I restrict myself to the most prominent. —

Lecture 21

b) *Kierkegaard’s personal development, studies and circumstances of life*. — This I touch on only briefly, partly because I lack the necessary material to give anything complete, partly because Kierkegaard’s personality must still be so fresh in memory. / I restrict myself to the points that become significant for the understanding of his standpoint and the peculiarity of his direction. / — His personal development is decisively influenced by his *childhood* impressions. From the influence of his father, a highly marked, naturally gifted and independently developed personality, who in living religious interest had attached himself to the party in the Church from which, in this country, the struggle against rationalism went out, — he had received the direction²⁵ toward *the Christian in a strict form*. [ed. 65.6] His study became theology, but / not in a professional way; it was really the forms of religious *life* that interested him, and with passion he occupied

²¹Absolute subjectivity (*Wesen des Christenthums* p. 125) – inwardness (*Wesen des Christenthums* p. 97)

²²Faith’s opposition to reason

²³Appropriation.

²⁴The Christians’ relation to nature – suffering as Christianity’s distinguishing mark (suffering is an object of imitation, redemption not.) – Dying away (*Wesen des Christenthums* 242) as the believer’s wish. – God is only for me when he is believed. – God = the absolute *τέλος*, eternal happiness. – God as susceptible of suffering. (Concluding Unscientific Postscript p. 306 [ed. SKS 7, p. 364f.])

²⁵NB. early development of the dialectical skill.

himself, especially in his youth, with / comprehensive *philosophical* and aesthetic studies. [101] Hegel's philosophy, then the dominant system, was made the object of a strenuous and passionate study, and from it he retained, despite all deviation from it, the idealistic conception, the strict dialectic, and the holding fast of *speculation* as the true philosophy. From Hegel he went back to the study of other philosophers, and it was above all the *German idealistic* philosophy from Kant, and the *Greeks*, particularly Plato and Aristotle, that²⁶ occupied him. With the more recent forms of philosophy that have arisen outside Germany, and with the oppositions that have appeared there against idealism, he seems to have been less familiar, and in the domain of philosophy *nature* became for him a foreign sphere. The natural sciences remained constantly indifferent to him.

Beside the study of philosophy, the aesthetic studies were those that filled the greater part of his time. Heiberg's activity as aesthetician had at that time awakened the liveliest interest in this science in Denmark, an interest that in the patriarchal time of absolutism filled everyone, as the political interest did later. For Heiberg as aesthetician Kierkegaard always retained reverence; from him, no doubt, came the incitement to [ed. 65.7] an extensive occupation with poets and theoretical aestheticians. There was in Kierkegaard the stuff of a great poet; he made this talent²⁷ *subservient* to another interest, but through it he penetrated deep into the secrets of poetry. The *Greeks* and *Shakespeare* became objects of his admiration; the *Romantics* of his liveliest interest. In Kierkegaard's first larger work, the dissertation on *irony*, the influence of Schlegel's Lucinde is recognizable, and a restrained echo of this influence is the *1st part of Either/Or*, where the life-principle of Romanticism is brought forth in existing individuality. But however much Kierkegaard immersed himself in aesthetic studies, the interest that stood out ever more definitely was not the merely theoretical one, but this: through the conception of the aesthetic to comprehend the peculiarity of a whole sphere of life, to pose *the problems by which the* [102] *aesthetic is brought into relation with personal life*, a whole series of problems which it is to his credit to have posed and clarified. — It was characteristic of Kierkegaard that his aesthetic interest was concentrated essentially on *poetry* and in part on *music*, and that *painting, sculpture* and *architecture* stood further from him.

From *political* life he kept himself aloof; his task was directed not outward but inward, and consistently, therefore, he took a polemical stance toward political endeavors [ed. 65.8] and maintained a strictly conservative tendency, grounded not only in his task but in the veneration for royal dignity implanted in him early, a veneration he held fast to, as he held fast in general to reverence for whatever had made a strong impression on

²⁶NB. Plutarch

²⁷(Reference to his writings, especially to the 1st part of *Either/Or*, *Fear and Trembling*, and *Stages*.)

him in his youth, whether in the religious or in the poetic domain.

After completing his university studies he at once began his *authorship*, an authorship laid out according to a comprehensive plan, with one sharply defined thought in view — as will be developed in what follows — and he carried it through, living, favored by outward independence, as a private man with only one task, to whose accomplishment he applied an energy of will whose equal will seldom be found, and, in the otium of an artistically ordered life, all the rich, manifold abilities with which he was endowed. His writings bear witness to the degree in which his spirit possessed, in unity, knowledge, dialectical power, poetic imagination, humor and pathos; those who knew him personally will be able to recall / the degree in which his thought had gained actuality in his personal life, that the ethical and the religious were *alive* in him, and that his life was a life of spirit. It was an earnestly struggling life, but the earnestness shielded itself with jest and irony, but through the jest the earnestness sounded for the initiated, through the irony the humanity. His life was a struggle for the ideal. /

Just as in his younger years, bold and combative, with the never-failing sharp weapons of dialectic, irony and wit, he had fought for *the ideals of poetry* against prose and [ed. 66.1] mediocrity, so it became his task in his older years to fight for *the ideal of religiousness* against the trivialization of religion. In this struggle, which will be described in what follows, he spent his last strength; he died young, only 42 years old, but he lived long enough to complete his work, to accomplish the task on which he staked his life. —

c) *Kierkegaard's Writings*. — It has already been touched on in the foregoing how one [103] thought, one task *carries* Kierkegaard's whole authorship. Through the whole series of his numerous writings there runs one dialectically laid-out and artistically executed plan, whose individual moments the individual writings realize, and this in such a way that the final goal stood definitely before his eyes from the very beginning, and that no single writing came to light before the next in the series was already finished. The goal at which the whole authorship aimed was *the Christian*;²⁸ even where the other views of life were brought forward, where the scene was another sphere of existence, there was a hidden striving toward it, and *therefore the authorship, viewed as a whole, is religious from first to last*, and Kierkegaard is right when he says that there corresponds to this authorship as its originator²⁹ *one who qua author has willed only one thing*. This one thing, then, is *the religious*, and more precisely *the Christian-religious*, and this not [ed. 66.2] as an object of theory but as *a task for existence*. "*Becoming a Christian*" is the problem, but

²⁸Cf. the Preface to Two Discourses at the Communion on Fridays, [ed. SKS 12, p. 281].

²⁹NB. "One unnamed, whose name will one day be named" (the Dedication of Two Discourses at the Communion on Fridays, SKS 12, p. 279.)

since this problem is posed in *Christendom*, where one thus is a Christian, the situation puts everything into reflection. The author's task is then more precisely determined thus: "Without authority to make³⁰ aware of the religious, the Christian"; the movement is not: to reflect oneself into Christianity, but: to reflect oneself out of something else in order to become a Christian more and more simply!; the religious is put wholly and entirely into reflection, but in such a way that it is wholly and entirely taken out of reflection again, so as to be back in simplicity, so that the path traversed is: to reach, to come to simplicity.

The watchword becomes: "for Christianity against the illusions" [ed. see e.g. SKS 7, p. 550]. This makes the *indirect method* necessary. If there is a misdirection present in an age, such that what is to be a task for personal existence has become an object of impersonal consideration, then the task of the method is not that of presenting something [104] anew as doctrine, of correcting by lecturing; rather it becomes this: dialectically to place the opposites together in such a way that the recipient can take possession of what is communicated only through the independent appropriation of reproduction, and, in doing so, comes by [ed. 66.3] *himself* into a relation to the truth, not by a direct communication into a relation to the communicator. And if an age's deficiency is this: to live in a deception, then the task, by the indirect method, the author concealing himself, is *dialectically to disrupt the deception* and bring the truth forward so that the reader by himself can at least *become aware*, and then choose. The method in Kierkegaard's writings, insofar as they do not communicate the Christian in the form of the upbuilding discourse, is therefore the indirect one, the form the *doubly reflected* one, by which the author distances the reader from himself in order, as it were, to force him into himself.

Already here lies what is decisively given with the *religious character* of the authorship: that its movement is, not to gather a crowd, a public, but precisely "to shake off the public," to address itself to "*the single individual*" religiously understood. "For religiously there is no public, but only single individuals, for the religious is earnestness, and earnestness is: the single individual, yet in such a way that every human being, unconditionally every human being, as indeed he is one, can be, indeed shall be the single individual — *the single individual before God*." [ed. SKS 13, p. 17.]

Connected with this, too, is the *pseudonymity*³¹ of all the writings that do not communicate the Christian. In order to determine the place of Christianity, to separate it categorically from the other spheres of existence, these had to be brought forward, and brought [ed. 66.4] forward in the form of existence. "The production itself required, for

³⁰Cf. Two Ethical-Religious Essays, [ed. SKS 11, p. 105ff.] — On My Work as an Author p. 6, note [ed. SKS 13, p. 12, cf. also p. 19].

³¹NB. the lower — the higher pseudonymity. (On My Work as an Author. p. 6, note [ed. SKS 13, p. 12].)

the sake of the dialogue, for the sake of the difference of the psychologically varied individuality, poetically that recklessness in good and evil, in contrition and exuberance, in despair and presumption, in suffering and jubilation, which is ideally limited only by psychological consistency, which no factually actual person within the moral limitation of actuality dares allow himself or can want to allow himself.” [ed. SKS 7, p. 569.] The different views of life are represented not merely by different existing individualities but by different fictional authors. The pseudonymity becomes a further means of distancing [105] in the relation between reader and author, a means of distancing that is in the interest of the ideality of understanding. — (As a condition it requires in the author a range of abilities that comprehends the peculiarities of all the individual spheres of life.)

Kierkegaard’s writings can be divided into 3 groups: the *first* would include the series of writings *from the dissertation on irony to Concluding Postscript*. It presents in existence the different stages of life which Kierkegaard places before the Christian, and brings the latter forward in the form of an experiment (in the *Philosophical Fragments* and in *Concluding Unscientific Postscript*). This group can be designated the *propaedeutic* one; their character is *maieutic-dialectical*. The *second* group includes the *upbuilding* [ed. 66.5] *discourses*, of which the first appeared at the same time as *Either/Or*, the last toward the end of Kierkegaard’s authorship. This group could be designated *the religious communication*; its character: *to be upbuilding through the ideal as requirement*, and in it the ideal advances from the generally religious to the Christian, yet in such a way that the latter is not presented in its utmost rigor. The *third* group contains the *Christian-polemical*³² writings: first those in which Christianity is lifted up “to the utmost of ideality” [ed. cf. SKS 12, p. 15], its ideal requirement brought forward in all its rigor: *The Sickness unto Death* and *Practice in Christianity*, — but in such a way that no judgment³³ is pronounced on the established order; next “*the newspaper articles*,” / i.e., the articles in “*Fædrelandet*” from December 1854 / and “*The Moment*,” in which, after the established order had made the attempt to reject the requirement, the struggle is waged for ideal Christianity against Christendom. This group can be designated the *polemical-reformatory* group.³⁴

The content of the different groups and the difference of the situation condition a nuancing in their *form* and *style*. Within the *first* group is found the greatest diversity: in the presentation of the different spheres of life that it includes there is room for the richness of imagination, for poetic pathos, for the play of wit, for irony’s sting, / for [106]

³²cf. the accompanying leaf to *On My Work as an Author*. [ed. SKS 13, p. 23ff.]

³³cf. *On My Work as an Author* p. 19 [ed. SKS 13, p. 25.]

³⁴cf. “*For Self-Examination*,” the words on the back of the title page [ed. SKS 13, p. 32.]

the power of the comic, for the penetrating sharpness of psychological depiction, / for the calm [ed. 66.6] earnestness of the ethical, for the inflexibility of dialectic, and for the profound jest of humor, while the ideal rigor of the religious is glimpsed as if from a distance. — In the *upbuilding* writings, poetic depiction, psychological reflection, dialectic and the comic have come to serve the religious-ideal; *pathos* predominates there, but not the poetic pathos that draws the individual away from himself out into the ideality of imagination; rather *the pathos of personality*, which, *concerned* for the highest, relates itself to *the earnestness of actuality*, and with *the requirement of the ideal* penetrates all the illusions, whose ways it knows. — In the last group of writings, psychological depiction is taken up on a large scale in *The Sickness unto Death*, but as a *means* of illuminating the decisive Christian determinations; in *Practice in Christianity* the dialectical is taken up on a similar scale, but in order to guard the paradox. In both, *the highest pathos* is the character. In the newspaper articles and *The Moment*, dialectic and the comic are the weapon: “laughter, administered in fear and trembling” [ed. SKS 13, p. 301] is the scourge used against the established order, but dialectic and satire are everywhere borne by the deepest pathos, which, sharpened by the pain of sympathy, expresses itself with shattering truth in enthusiasm and longing for death.

[ed. note]

[ed. 66.7] Such is the picture of him that his activity gives. But those who knew him while he lived know a richer and fuller picture, and for them may I be permitted further to call up the memory of his personality, to recall the clear fullness of his thought, the rich inwardness of his feelings, the inflexible energy of his will; — to recall him in jest, which on his lips always let the earnestness shine through transparently; to recall him in earnestness, when a loving word of his enlivened, a reconciling word calmed, a releasing word guided; — to recall him in his youth, when, bold and combative, with the sharp [107] weapons of wit³⁵ and dialectic that never failed, he fought for the ideals of poetry against prose and mediocrity; to recall him when older, when, with the highest goal in view, he labored in the service of the Deity with a steel strength of will that willed only one thing; to recall him finally in the earnest struggles of the last year, when his “wish was death, his longing the grave, his desire that this wish and this longing might soon be fulfilled” [ed. SKS 13, p. 124]; to recall how in the suffering of the struggle he preserved his loving concern for others, even for the smallest circumstances of life, preserved his gentleness, his kindness, even his jest, preserved his equanimity of mind and clarity of thought; preserved above all the peace and rest in faith that did not fail him even amid

³⁵irony

the sufferings of the deathbed. So stands his picture for us, in beautiful agreement with the noble picture that those who know him only from his writings receive from these.

[*ed.* 66.8] What he accomplished as a religious author is what gives him his essential significance; it is as religious writings that his works must essentially be assessed. But beside their worth as such they have a particular worth, in the author's eyes no doubt vanishing and inessential, but significant nevertheless, namely on the side of language. For in no Danish prose writer, surely, has the Danish language, which he "with a filial devotion, and with an almost feminine infatuation was proud to have the honor to write," which he has so ravishly depicted (in his Stages [*ed.* Two Discourses at the Communion on Fridays, [*ed.* SKS 12, 281, cf. SKS 6, p. 449f.]]), attained such range, such flexibility, such richness in forms. Through him it found expression for every mood, for every feeling, for every thought. Always it was fresh, always rejuvenated in the luxuriance of mood, equally beautiful in the playful sport of form with itself and in the plain, moving, simple utterance of the highest truth. Like the form of the crystal, which cannot be separated from the crystal, the form of the language always came into being with the thought, stamped by it, inspirited by its play.

[*ed.* 66.9] Common to all Kierkegaard's writings is their high worth in *stylistic* respect, a worth that for the author was no doubt the inessential and vanishing, but which is nevertheless significant. In no Danish prose writer, surely, has the³⁶ Danish language, [108] "which he with filial devotion and with an almost feminine infatuation was proud to have the honor to write" [*ed.* SKS 12, p. 28f.], and which he has ravishly depicted in his "Stages" [*ed.* SKS 6, p. 449f.], attained such range, such flexibility, such diversity in forms. Through him it found expression for every mood, for every feeling, for every thought. Always it was fresh, always rejuvenated in the luxuriance of mood, equally beautiful in the playful sport of form with itself, in the exuberance of laughter, in the wrestling of struggle, in the outbreathing of passion, and in the plain, moving, simple utterance of the highest truth. Like the form of the crystal, which cannot be separated from the crystal, the form of the language with him always came into being with the thought and the feeling, stamped by them, inspirited by their play. The mother tongue was for him a material that he shaped artistically, his prose a work of art whose equal perhaps only the Greek language in Plato's writings has.

Lecture 22

d.) *The Categories of Existence.*

³⁶(Preface to Two Discourses at the Communion on Fridays)

d.) In the foregoing[ed. 66.10] Kierkegaard's task has in general been designated as this: / to assert *the relation of faith* as the highest by / pointing to the individual's relation to the truth *in existence*; his *problem* as this: how do I, *existing*, express the truth / and, since the truth is determined as Christianity: *how do I become a Christian?* / The deficiency of the age he concentrates in the words: *that it has forgotten to exist, forgotten what inwardness* is [ed. cf. SKS 7, p. 220]. Herein lies his opposition to speculation and to all objective occupation with Christianity; it is from this point that one must set out in order to grasp his view in its coherence.

The *objective* consideration asks purely objectively *about Christianity's* truth, either in the sense that truth means *historical* or *philosophical* truth. It does not, on the other hand, ask about *the truth of appropriation*; it is *not infinitely, personally interested, in passion, with regard to its eternal happiness, in its relation to this truth*. It is assumed [109] that when the objectively true has been procured, appropriation follows of itself; and during the consideration by which the truth is to be procured, the subject relates itself objectively, *disinterestedly*.

But it is easily seen, as far as historical truth is concerned, that the maximum that can be reached with respect to it is *an approximation*, and that such an approximation is so heterogeneous with an eternal happiness that no result can come of it, that *the infinite decision* in passion [ed. 67.1] cannot take place through it at all. Whether the inquiry turns to *Holy Scripture* or to *the Church* in order to secure the objective truth, approximation remains the highest: attack and defense both lie in an approximating which in its perpetually continued striving is not dialectical for an infinite decision on which one builds one's eternal happiness. As soon as one takes subjectivity away, and from subjectivity passion, and from passion the infinite interest, there is reached³⁷ no decision whatsoever, neither in this nor in any other problem. *All decision, all essential decision, lies in subjectivity*. ["Sensuous certainty, let alone historical certainty, is uncertainty, is only approximating; the positive and an immediate relation to it is the negative." [ed. SKS 7, p. 44].]

Just as little as the objective consideration of Scripture and Church can lead to a decision, just as little can *the consideration of world history* lead to one. Centuries cannot furnish a proof of the truth of Christianity; the *historical* consequences would always remain incommensurable with the *eternal* truth, which is more essential than all

³⁷The contradiction is *double*: partly that one wants to relate oneself objectively, i.e., disinterestedly, dispassionately, to what is the object of *the subject's* passionate interest, of its highest passion; — partly that one wants to let what at its maximum is only an *approximation* to certainty become that on which one wants to build an eternal happiness.

consequences, and time becomes incommensurable with the eternal when it is to be a proof of it. Centuries are no more a proof than one day is.

In *the speculative consideration of Christianity* the problem, *becoming a Christian*, does not come up at all. In its objectivity [ed. 67.2] speculation is precisely *altogether indifferent to the individual's eternal happiness*. For the one who speculates, the question of his *personal* eternal happiness cannot come up at all, precisely because his task consists in getting more and more away from himself and *becoming objective*, and so [110] vanishing from himself and becoming *the beholding power of speculation* [ed. cf. SKS 7, p. 60]. Speculation wants *in time* to be *merely eternal*; in the light of eternity it wants to contemplate Christianity, see it in its necessity and in its unity with the eternal truth. "But suppose now that this whole undertaking were a chimera, suppose that Christianity is precisely subjectivity, is inward deepening, suppose, then, that only two classes of human beings can know anything about it: those who, infinitely interested in passion for their eternal happiness, believably build this on their believing relation to it; and those who in the opposite passion (but in passion) reject it — the happy and the unhappy lovers. Suppose, then, that objective indifference can find out nothing whatever." [ed. SKS 7, p. 56f.] In relation to all cognition where it holds that the object of cognition is the very inwardness of subjectivity, it holds that the one who cognizes must be in this state. Only like is understood by like. "In the infinite passionate interest for its eternal happiness, subjectivity is at its utmost exertion, at the extreme, not where there is no object (the imperfect and undialectical distinction), but *where God is negatively in subjectivity*, which in this³⁸ [ed. 67.3] interest is *the form of eternal happiness*" [ed. SKS 7, p. 57]. Here it holds unconditionally that he who is not in this state gains nothing by all his considering. The fact that the human being is not merely eternal but is *a synthesis of the temporal and the eternal* means that the happiness of speculation is an illusion, that³⁹ the highest is *subjectivity's infinite interest in passion for its eternal happiness*; and it is *the highest* because it is the *truer*, which definitely expresses *the synthesis*.⁴⁰

But if now the decision of the problem cannot come about by the way of objectivity, [111] because it leads only into a quantifying, because it leads the subject away from itself / , because it precisely leaves out that by which the decision becomes possible, / and because, forgetting the conditions of existence, it wants to give the subject an illusory eternity, and

³⁸"The infinitely negative is the only adequate form for the infinite" (Stages, p. 377 [ed. SKS 6, p. 448].) "The infinite negative resolution, which is individuality's [ed. 67.3] infinite form for God's being in him." (Concluding Unscientific Postscript p. 21, note* [ed. SKS 7, p. 41].)

³⁹What is amiss with speculation is thus: 1) with respect to the relation to Christianity, its objectivity, 2) with respect to speculation itself, its illusory eternity.

⁴⁰(The section from here to 69,6 was completely reworked in the oral presentation, essentially following the enclosed leaves). [ed. note]

if the decision is thus referred to subjectivity, and the form of the decision provisionally indicated by the determination of the subject as *a synthesis of the temporal and eternal*, then this concept of *subjectivity*, *existing* subjectivity, is now to be considered more closely; and first in general in relation to the *eternal*, to the truth, without taking closer account of the *Christian* determinations.

Objective thinking was indifferent to the thinking subject and its existence; *the subjective thinker*, by contrast, is as existing essentially *interested in his own thinking*, is *existing in it*. Therefore his thinking has another kind of reflection, namely *that of inwardness, of possession*, by which it [ed. 67.4] belongs to him and to no one else. While objective thinking puts everything into *result* and helps the whole of humanity to cheat by copying and reciting the result and the answer, subjective thinking puts everything into *becoming* and⁴¹ leaves out the result, partly because this belongs precisely to him since he has the way, partly *because as existing he is continually in becoming*, which indeed every human being is who has not let himself be fooled into becoming objective, into superhumanly becoming speculation. — *The reflection of inwardness* [ed. cf. e.g. SKS 7, p. 73f.] is the subjective thinker's *double reflection*. Thinking, he thinks the universal, but as existing in this thinking, as acquiring it in his inwardness, he becomes more and more *subjectively isolated*. He therefore cannot, like the objective thinker, *communicate himself* directly, but only indirectly, in the form of double reflection.

As existing, the existing subject is in becoming; its thought must then correspond to the form of existence. But becoming is the alternation between being and non-being, the positive and the negative. The *positive* in relation to thinking can be referred to these determinations: *sensuous certainty, historical knowledge, speculative result*. But *this positive is precisely the untrue*. Sensuous certainty is deceit, historical knowledge is [112] illusion (since it is approximation-knowledge), and the speculative result is a delusion. For all this positive does not express the cognizing subject's [ed. 67.5] state in *existence*; it therefore concerns a *fictive objective subject*, and to confuse oneself with such a one is to be, and to go on being, fooled. Every subject is an *existing subject*, and therefore this must find essential expression in all its cognition, and express itself as preventing that cognition from an illusory closure in sense-knowledge, in historical knowledge, in illusory result. In historical knowledge he moves constantly in the sphere of approximation-knowledge, only imagines he has certainty, which is nevertheless had only *in infinity*, which he, as existing, cannot *be in*, but can only constantly arrive at. *Nothing historical can become infinitely certain to me except this: that I exist, which is not something historical.*

⁴¹“Certainty is impossible for one who is becoming, and is precisely the deception.” [ed. SKS 7, p. 75.]

The *speculative* result is an illusion insofar as the existing subject wants, thinking, to abstract from the fact that it is existing, and to be *sub specie æterni*. — Precisely because *the negative* is present in existence and is present *everywhere* (for existence—*Tilværelse*, Existents—is constantly in becoming), the only salvation against it is to become constantly attentive to it. In becoming positively secured, the subject is precisely fooled. The negativity that is in existence, or rather *the existing subject's negativity* (which his thinking must essentially reproduce in an adequate form), *is grounded in the subject's synthesis, that it is an existing infinite spirit. Infinity and the eternal are the only certain thing, but inasmuch as it is in the subject, it is in existence, and the first expression of this is its deception, and this immense contradiction, that the eternal [ed. 67.6] becomes, that it comes into being.* The existing subject's thinking must then have a form in which it can reproduce this, and since the subjective existing thinker, who has infinity in his soul, always has it, the form must *always* express it, and it does so by being deceptive, *negative*. *As existing, the subjective thinker is constantly just as negative as positive; for his positivity consists in the continued inward deepening, in which he knows of the negative.* He is never a teacher, but *a learner*, and when he is constantly just as negative as positive, he is constantly *striving*. / And this striving is not a striving that ends when a goal is reached, but *infinite striving*. *Existing itself is a striving*, and it is just as pathetic as it is comic. / In his thinking he constantly imitates his existence, i.e. he *puts all his thinking into becoming*. — He has *just as much of the comic as of pathos*. The relative difference that in immediacy lies between⁴² the comic and the tragic vanishes in the double reflection, [113] where the difference becomes infinite and ideality is thereby posited. What lies at the ground of the comic and the pathetic is the disproportion, the contradiction between the infinite and the finite, the eternal and the becoming. The conception of the disproportion, when it is seen looking toward the idea, is pathos; the conception of the disproportion when it is seen with the idea behind it, is comic. If I have not exhausted the whole of the comic, neither do I have the pathos of infinity; if I have the pathos of infinity, I also at once have the comic.

[Beyond the negative relation to the eternal, an existing individual can never be helped by the historical: “contingent historical truths can never become proofs of necessary truths of reason” [ed. SKS 7, p. 92]. Here [ed. 67.7] a *leap* is required, by which the decision comes into being.]

Lecture 23

That the existing individual *is constantly in becoming*, i.e. is constantly *striving*,

⁴²“In all his thinking the thinker must also think this: that he is existing.” [ed. SKS 7, p. 91.]

entails as its consequence that for him *no system of existence* can be given, even though there can be a *logical system*. *System and conclusiveness correspond to each other, but existence is precisely the opposite of conclusiveness*. For *God* existence is a system, but it cannot be one for an existing spirit, who can gain a conclusiveness outside existence only fantastically. *In order to think existence, systematic thought must think it as annulled, hence not as existing*. Existence is the spacing-apart, which falls asunder: the systematic is conclusiveness, which closes together. For the existing individual, even if he has reached the highest, *repetition*, by which he must indeed fill out his existence if he is not to go backward (or become a fantastical being), will again be a continued striving, because here again conclusiveness is put at a distance and deferred. *Continued striving* is the upshot for the existing subject's ethical view of life. The systematic idea is the *subject-object*, a [114] unity of thinking and being; existence, by contrast, is precisely separation. From this it by no means follows that existence is thoughtless, but it has spaced and spaces the subject apart from the object, thinking from being. *Objectively understood*, thought is *pure thinking*, which just as abstract-objectively corresponds to its object, which object is therefore again itself, and *truth* is thought's agreement with itself. This objective thinking has no relation to existing subjectivity and ends by becoming, — if it [ed. 67.8] is, incidentally, possible for the subject to slip into this objectivity, and if it is not something that at most it can come to know of through the imagination, — the purely abstract co-knowledge in, and knowledge of, this pure relation between thinking and being, this pure identity, indeed this *tautology*, because by being it is not said that the thinker is, but strictly only that he is a thinker. The *existing* subject, on the other hand, is existing, and that indeed every human being is. And *this demand of existence prevents one from remaining in the metaphysical, strikes the one who will remain in it with the comic*.

If in this way *the existing individual's relation to truth* is now determined as a *relation of subjectivity*, then the determination now gained, *subjectivity's* determination, becomes at the same time the determination of the highest *task* that is possible for the existing individual. "Objectively one speaks constantly about the matter; subjectively one speaks about the subject and subjectivity, and behold, *precisely subjectivity is the matter*. It must constantly be held fast *that the subjective problem is not something about the matter, but is subjectivity itself*. For since the problem is the *decision*, and the decision, as shown above, lies in subjectivity, what matters is *that objectively no trace of any matter at all remains*; for in the same moment subjectivity will shirk some of the pain and crisis of decision, i.e. will make the problem a little objective, and thereby the decision is postponed." [ed. SKS 7, p. 121.]

Becoming a subject / , subjectivity's development or transformation, its infinite concentration in itself over against the representation of infinity's highest good, an eternal happiness, (subjectivity's infinite concern about itself.) / *is the highest task set for every human being, and if it were not, then ethics would have to despair.* Ethics and the ethical have an irrefutable claim on every existing individual by being the essential stay of individual [ed. 68.1] existence; such an irrefutable claim that whatever a human being accomplishes in the world, the most astonishing thing, it is nonetheless dubious if he has not ethically been clear with himself when he chose, and ethically clarified [115] his choice. Ethics must therefore regard *objective world-historical knowledge* with suspicious eyes, because it easily becomes a snare, a demoralizing aesthetic distraction for the knowing subject, since the distinction between what becomes world-historical and what does not is quantitatively dialectical, which is also why the absolute ethical distinction between⁴³ *good and evil* is, world-historically, — aesthetically neutralized in the aesthetic-metaphysical determination: *the great*, the significant, to which the bad man has equal access with the good. Ethically seen, that by which the individual becomes world-historical is *the contingent*, but ethics regards as⁴⁴ unethical the transition by which one lets go of the ethical quality in order to try oneself in the quantifying other. Constant preoccupation with the world-historical makes one unfit to act, since regard for the *outcome* displaces the will's ethical enthusiasm, and makes the individual unethical. The true *ethical enthusiasm* lies in willing to the utmost of one's ability, but at the same time, uplifted in divine jest, never thinking about whether one thereby accomplishes anything or not. — Since a human being cannot by himself, by freedom, by the will to the good, become a world-historical figure, — this is namely dependent on something else, hence contingent — it is unethical to be concerned about it. The true ethical individuality would, even if the governing power so arranged circumstances that he became a world-historical figure, by a resolution of the will remain ignorant [ed. 68.2] of it, because the external is not in his power, and therefore means nothing either pro or contra; he *would* not, even in death, know that his life had had any significance other than that of having ethically worked through his soul's development. Significance must always be apprehended as something Governance adds to his ethical striving in itself, hence not as the fruit of his work; it is a pro that must be regarded as a spiritual

⁴³Only *in himself* can the human being study the ethical — if he seeks it in history, he never comes to act. Speculation in ethics wants a now-living individual to act by virtue of a theory of immanence, i.e. to act by virtue of refraining from acting.

⁴⁴“The ethical is the only certain thing; to concentrate oneself upon this, the only knowledge that does not at a last moment possibly change into a hypothesis; to be in it, the only secure knowledge, where knowledge is secured by something else.” [ed. SKS 7, p. 142.]

[116] trial fully as much as any contra. The proposition: *world history is the world's judgment*, can, when it is to express an *ethical* consideration of life, in any case have validity for God, because in his eternal co-knowledge he possesses the medium that is precisely the commensurability of the outward and the inward. But the *human* spirit cannot see the world-historical in this way, even apart from the difficulties: a) that access to becoming world-historical is quantitatively dialectical, so that what has become world-historical has passed through this dialectic; b) that the world-historical consideration, as an act of cognition, is an approximation, subject to the same dialectic as every conflict between idea and empirical reality, which at every moment will hinder the beginning, and when it has begun, at every moment threatens a revolt against the beginning; — c) that in world history, being the history of the race, the ethical cannot be seen, but only the *abstract*, the metaphysical relation of immanence between cause and effect, ground and consequence. (NB. besides, the slowness of world history)

Becoming subjective is thus the highest task set for a human being, just as [ed. 68.3] the highest reward, *an eternal happiness*, exists only for the subjective person, or rather *comes into being* for the one who becomes subjective. And becoming subjective shall give a human being plenty to do as long as he lives (cf. the examples in Concluding Unscientific Postscript p. 121ff.) [ed. SKS 7, pp. 153–67.]

We are now led by this to the determination of *subjective truth*.

If truth is defined as *agreement between thinking and being*, and if by being is understood *empirical* being, then truth itself is transformed into a desideratum and everything is put in becoming, because the empirical object is not finished, and because the existing cognizing spirit is itself indeed in becoming, and thus truth is an approximating, in which the beginning cannot be absolutely posited, precisely because there is no conclusion, which has retroactive force; whereas every beginning (if it is not, by being conscious of this, an arbitrariness), when it is *made*, does not take place by virtue of immanent thinking, but is *made* by virtue of a *resolution*, essentially by virtue of faith. — If, on the other hand, in that definition one takes *being abstractly* as the abstract rendering of, or the abstract prototype for, what being in concreto is as empirical being, then nothing [117] prevents truth from being abstractly determined abstractly as *something finished*; for the agreement between thinking and being is, *abstractly seen*, always finished, since the beginning of *becoming* lies precisely in *concretion*, from which abstraction abstractly looks away. But if being is understood in this way, the formula is a *tautology*, thinking and being mean one and the same, and the agreement becomes the abstract identity with [ed. 68.4] itself. All that is expressed is that truth is not something single, but, quite

abstractly, a *duplication*, which is nevertheless annulled in the same moment. Abstraction can go on paraphrasing this as much as it likes; it never gets any further. As soon as the being of truth becomes *empirically concrete*, truth itself is *in becoming*, is indeed again, *as divined*, agreement between thinking and being, and is indeed so actually *for God*, but is not so for any *existing spirit*, because this spirit, existing, is itself in becoming.

For the existing spirit qua existing spirit the question of truth now comes back. Existence holds the two moments in truth's abstract reduplication apart from each other, and reflection shows two relations. For *objective* reflection truth becomes an objective something, an object, and the point is to look away from the subject; for *subjective* reflection truth becomes appropriation, inwardness, subjectivity, and the point is precisely, existing, to immerse oneself in subjectivity. *Mediation*, which would connect these two forms, only leads us back to abstraction; it does not explain how the eternal truth is to be understood *in the determination of time* by one *who, by existing, is himself in time*.

The way of *objective* reflection makes the subject the *contingent*, and thereby existence into an *indifferent* vanishing thing. The way to objective truth goes away from the subject, and while the subject and subjectivity become indifferent, truth becomes so too, and precisely this is its objective validity; for interest, like decision, is subjectivity. The way of objective reflection now leads to *abstract thinking*, to *mathematics*, to *historical knowledge* of various kinds; [ed. 68.5] it constantly leads *away from the subject*, whose existence or non-existence becomes, objectively quite rightly, infinitely indifferent. At its maximum it will lead to the *contradiction* that only objectivity has come into being and subjectivity has gone out, that is to say, the *existing subjectivity* that has made an attempt to become what in the abstract sense is called subjectivity, abstract objectivity's abstract form. And yet the objectivity that has come into being is, subjectively seen, at [118] its maximum either a *hypothesis* or an *approximation*, because all eternal decision lies precisely in subjectivity.

Subjective reflection turns inward toward subjectivity, and wants in this *inward deepening* to be the truth, and in such a way that, just as in the foregoing, when objectivity had been brought forth, subjectivity had vanished, here *subjectivity itself becomes the last thing and the objective the vanishing*. Here it is not forgotten for a single moment that the subject is existing, and that existing is a becoming, and that therefore that identity of truth, of thinking and being, is a chimera of abstraction, and in truth is only the longing of creation, not because truth is not this, but *because the cognizer is an existing individual, and so truth cannot be this for him as long as he exists*. Only *momentarily* can the existing

subject be in a unity of finitude and infinity that goes beyond existing. This moment is *the moment of passion*. *Passion is, for an existing individual, precisely the highest of existence*. In passion the existing subject is infinitized in the eternity of imagination and yet at the same time precisely most definitely itself.

All *essential cognizing* relates itself to existence[ed. 68.6], i.e. it relates itself to *the cognizer, who is essentially an existing individual*. Only *ethical* and *ethical-religious cognizing* is therefore essential cognizing. But all ethical and all ethical-religious cognizing is essentially relating itself to the fact that the cognizer exists.

When the question of truth is asked *objectively*, one reflects objectively on truth as an object to which the cognizer relates himself. One reflects not on the *relation*, but on its being *the truth*, the true, that he relates himself to. When what he relates himself to is only the truth, the true, then the subject is in the truth. When the question of truth is asked *subjectively*, one reflects subjectively on the individual's relation; if only the *how* of this relation is in truth, then the individual is in truth, even if he were thus relating himself to untruth (NB. here the talk is of essential truth, or of the truth that relates itself essentially to existence.). — *The cognition of God* may serve as an example. *Objectively* one reflects on this: that it is *the true God*. God is then to be brought forth objectively through the whole approximating deliberation, *which is never achieved, because God is* [119] *subject, and therefore is only for subjectivity in inwardness*. *Subjectively* one reflects on this: that the individual relates himself to a something *in such a way* that his relation is in truth a God-relationship. The existing individual who chooses the subjective way grasps in the same moment the whole dialectical difficulty in his having to spend some time, perhaps a long time, finding God objectively; he grasps this dialectical difficulty in all its pain, because he must make use of God in the same moment, because every moment is wasted in which he does not have God. In the same moment he has God, not by virtue of any objective deliberation, but by virtue of *inwardness's*[ed. 68.7] *infinite passion*. (God thus becomes a postulate, but this must be understood in such a way that the existing individual's postulating God is a *necessity*.)

Objectively the accent falls on *what* is said, subjectively on *how* it is said. At its maximum this *how* is *the passion of infinity*, and *the passion of infinity is the truth itself*. But the passion of infinity is precisely *subjectivity*, and thus *subjectivity is the truth*. Objectively seen there is no infinite decision, and thus it is objectively correct that the difference between good and evil is annulled along with the principle of contradiction, and thereby also the infinite difference between truth and falsehood. Only in subjectivity is there decision, whereas wanting to become objective is untruth. *The passion of infinity*

is the decisive thing, not its content, for its content is precisely itself. Thus the subjective how and subjectivity are the truth. Truth can then be defined thus: *the objective uncertainty, held fast in the appropriation of the most passionate inwardness, is the truth, the highest truth there is for an existing individual* [ed. cf. SKS 7, p. 186]. But this determination of truth is a paraphrase of *faith*.

In the proposition that subjectivity is the truth, the *Socratic wisdom* is contained, which paid heed to the fact that the cognizer is existing. To this determination corresponds the objective determination of truth as *paradox*. The paradox is *the objective uncertainty*, which is the expression for the passion of inwardness, which is precisely the truth. *The eternal essential truth is the paradox inasmuch as it relates itself to an existing individual*. The existing individual's *ignorance* is the expression for the objective uncertainty; but the fact that cognizing is determined as *recollecting* points to this: that the eternal essential truth is *not in and for itself* [ed. 68.8] *paradoxical, but only by its relation to the existing individual*. (NB. Socrates's relation to Plato.)

If one wants to seek a more inward expression than the Socratic for the proposition: subjectivity is the truth, then one must begin with: *subjectivity is untruth*, or, in other words, with the Christian decisive determination of *sin*, which annuls the possibility of recollectively taking oneself back into eternity. *The individual becomes a sinner by coming into being*. The way back is barred; he must go forward. The individual must now *in existence* get hold of the truth, but then the *eternal* truth must come into being *in time*, and in doing so it *itself* becomes the paradox. The strongest expression for inwardness now emerges, and it is: when the retreat out of existence, recollecting, into eternity has been made impossible, then *with the truth against one as the paradox, in the anxiety of sin and with this pain, with the immense risk of objectivity, to believe — by virtue of the absurd* (The absurd is that the eternal truth has come into being in time, that God has come into being as this individual human being). *Speculation is here cut off* (it remains in *immanence* and volatilizes the paradox.) The absurd, held fast with the passion of infinity, is *faith in the strict sense*. The paradox is not what is to be explained; what is to be grasped, only more and more deeply, is *that it is the paradox*. Just as God, as the highest representation, cannot be explained by anything else, but can only be explained by immersing oneself in the representation itself, and just as the supreme principles of all thinking can only be proved indirectly (negatively), so the paradox, as the ground of an existing individual's relation to an eternal essential truth, will not be explicable by anything else either, when the explanation is to be for existing individuals. — *Faith relates itself self-actively to the paradox, self-actively in discovering it, and at every* [120]

moment holding it fast — in order to be able to believe. [ed. 69.1] (“Speculation is *objective*, and *objectively* there is no truth for an existing individual, but only approximating, for he is prevented from becoming entirely objective by existing. Christianity, by contrast, is subjective; the inwardness of faith in the believer is subjectivity’s eternal decision. And objectively there is no truth; for the objective knowledge of the truth of Christianity, or of its truths, is precisely untruth; to know a confession of faith by heart is paganism, because Christianity is inwardness”. [ed. SKS 7, p. 204])

Now that truth has been determined as subjectivity, *the actuality of subjectivity* must be considered. *Abstraction* looks away from actuality and from its difficulty, which is this: that *this determinate something* and *the ideality of thinking* are to be put together. [121] The *particular*, the *contingent*, is something belonging to everything actual and directly opposed to abstraction. *In the domain of abstraction the principle of contradiction is annulled, but in existence it is an impossibility to annul it, for then existence itself is annulled.* When I take existence away (abstract), then there is no aut-aut; when I take it away in existence, then this means that I take existence away, but then I do not, after all, annul it in existence. For the existing individual, who as such is *in becoming*, the eternal is not the eternal but *the future*. When he, acting, relates himself to this — acting as in immanence — he relates himself to it in *infinite passion*, and then an *aut-aut* is posited. Where everything is in becoming, where there is only so much of eternity present that it can *hold back* in the passionate decision, there where eternity relates itself as futurity to the one becoming, there *the absolute distinction* belongs. *For when I put eternity and becoming together, I get not rest but futurity.*

[ed. 69.2] To exist in truth, thus with consciousness to penetrate one’s existence, at once as it were far out beyond it, and yet present in it and yet in becoming: that is difficult. To think existence sub specie æterni and in abstraction is essentially to annul it. Existence cannot be thought without motion, and motion cannot be thought sub specie æterni. Insofar as all thinking is nevertheless eternal, the difficulty is there for the existing individual. Existence, like motion, is a very difficult thing to deal with. If I think it, I annul it, and then I do not think it. It might then seem right to say that there is something that cannot be thought: existing. But the difficulty is there again, *that existence puts it together in that the thinker exists.* — Insofar as existence is motion, it holds that there is nevertheless something *continuous* that holds motion together; for [122] otherwise there is no motion. The *unmoved*⁴⁵ belongs with motion as motion’s goal,

⁴⁵“The existing individual thinks momentarily, he thinks beforehand and he thinks afterward. Absolute continuity his thinking cannot attain.” [ed. SKS 7, p. 300.] “Existence separates the ideal identity of thinking and being. I must exist in order to be able to think, and I must be able to think (e.g. the good)

both in the sense of *τελος* and of *μετρον*; otherwise the claim that all is in motion, if one at the same time wants to take time away and say that all is always motion, is *eo ipso* standstill. The difficulty for the existing individual is now this: *to give existence the continuity without which everything simply vanishes*. An *abstract continuity* is no continuity, and the fact that the existing individual exists essentially hinders continuity, whereas *passion* is the *momentary* continuity, which at one and the same time holds back and is the impulse of the motion. For an existing individual the goal of motion is *decision and repetition*. *The eternal is the continuity of motion*, but an abstract eternity is outside motion, and a concrete eternity in the existing individual is the maximum of passion. *For all idealizing passion is an anticipation [ed. 69.3] of the eternal in existence for an existing individual to exist*. But passion's anticipation of the eternal for an existing individual is still not the abstract continuity, but *the possibility of approximation to the only true one there can be for an existing individual* (NB. The eternity of abstraction and of pure thinking, Concluding Unscientific Postscript p. 236f. [ed. SKS 7, p. 284ff.])

For the existing individual, existing is his highest interest, and interestedness in existing is actuality. What *actuality* is cannot be stated in the language of abstraction. Only by annulling actuality can abstraction get hold of it, but to annul it is precisely to transform it into *possibility*. All that is said about actuality in the language of abstraction within abstraction is said within possibility. Actuality, existence, is the dialectical moment in a trilogy whose beginning and end cannot be for an existing individual, who qua existing is in the dialectical moment. Abstraction joins the trilogy together, but the one abstracting is, after all, an existing individual, and as existing therefore in the dialectical moment, which he cannot mediate or join together, least of all absolutely, as long as he is existing. When he nevertheless does so, then this must relate as a possibility to actuality, to existence, where he himself is. He must explain how he goes about it, i.e., how he *as existing* goes about it, or whether he ceases to be existing, and whether an existing individual *has a right to do so*. At the same moment we begin to ask in this way, we ask *ethically* and assert the ethical's claim upon the existing individual, which cannot be that he should abstract from existence, but that he should exist, which is also the [123] existing individual's highest interest.

All knowledge about actuality is a possibility; the only actuality of which an existing individual is more than knowing is his own actuality, the fact [ed. 69.4] that he exists, and

in order to exist in it" [ed. SKS 7, p. 301.] "Existence is always the particular; the abstract does not exist." [ed. SKS 7, p. 301.] "God does not think, he creates. God does not exist, he is eternal. *The human being thinks and exists, and existence separates thinking and being*, holds them apart from each other in succession." [ed. SKS 7, p. 303.]

this actuality is his absolute interest. Abstraction's requirement of him is to become disinterested in order to come to know something; the ethical's requirement of him is to be infinitely interested in existing. *The only actuality there is for the ethical individual is his own ethical actuality; all other actuality he only knows about; but true knowledge is a translation into possibility.* — The reliability of *sense perception* is deception. The reliability *that knowledge of the historical* wants to have is also only deception, insofar as it wants to be the reliability of actuality, since the knower only knows about a historical actuality when he has dissolved it into possibility. *Abstraction* is possibility, the preceding or the subsequent. *Pure thinking* is a phantom. *Actual subjectivity* is not the knowing subjectivity, for by knowledge he is in the medium of possibility, but is *the ethically existing subjectivity*⁴⁶ (this thinks everything in relation to itself, infinitely interested in existing.) (NB. The different rank of actuality and possibility in the domain of the aesthetic and of the ethical, — *faith's*⁴⁷ relation to an actuality that is not one's own. — "*Actuality is ideality.* But aesthetically and intellectually ideality is possibility. Ethically, ideality is actuality in the individual himself. *Actuality is interiority infinitely interested in existing, which the ethical individual is for himself*" [ed. SKS 7, p. 296] — "*The individual's own ethical actuality is the only actuality.*" [ed. SKS 7, p. 522] / (to everything else he has only a relation of possibility, precisely as a maximum.) / "*Subjectivity is truth, subjectivity is actuality.*" [ed. SKS 7, p. 314.]

In the existing actual subjectivity the task is *to give the individual moments of subjectivity simultaneity*, and this simultaneity is the opposite of the speculative process. In the [124] direction of existence, thinking [ed. 69.5] is not at all higher than imagination and feeling, but they are coordinate. The task is not to raise the one at the other's expense, but the task is equality, simultaneity, and the medium in which they are united is in existing.

For a subjective thinker there is required *imagination, feeling, dialectic in existence-inwardness with passion*. But first and last *passion*, for it is impossible, existing, to think about existence without coming into passion, because existing is an enormous contradiction, which the subjective thinker has not to abstract from, but to remain in. The subjective thinker is a dialectician in the direction of the existential; he has passion of thought for holding fast the qualitative disjunction; he has this absolute disjunction as the final decision, which prevents everything from spreading out into a quantifying.

⁴⁶NB. The self-relation in relation to knowledge.

⁴⁷"The object of faith is the actuality of the god in existence, i.e., as a single individual, i.e., that God has existed as an individual human being." [ed. SKS 7, p. 298] — "Christianity is no doctrine, but the fact that the god has existed." [ed. SKS 7, p. 298.] "Actuality is not the external action, but is interiority, in which the individual annuls possibility and identifies himself with what is thought in order to exist in it. This is action." [ed. SKS 7, p. 310.]

He has it at hand, but not in such a way that, by abstractly recurring to it, he hinders existence. He therefore also has aesthetic passion and ethical passion; thereby concretion is gained. He is, however, not a poet, even if he is *also* a poet, not an ethicist, even if he is also an ethicist, but *also* a dialectician and essentially *himself existing*, whereas the poet's existence is inessential in relation to the poem, and likewise the ethicist's in relation to the doctrine he expounds, and the dialectician's in relation to the thought. He is not a man of science but an *artist*. *Existing is an art*. The subjective thinker is aesthetic enough for his life to acquire aesthetic content, ethical enough to regulate it, dialectical enough to master it in thought. His task is: *to understand himself in existence*. *Every human being must essentially be assumed to be in possession of what essentially belongs to being a human being*. The subjective thinker's[*ed.* 69.6] task is to transform himself into an instrument that clearly and definitely expresses *the human in existence*. —

[*ed. note*]

[*ed.* 1] *for Lecture 23* (Sheets 67.3–69.6) (Recapitulation of the foregoing: The problem: to become a Christian. — The relation to an eternal happiness (cf. “Philosophical Fragments.”) — If the problem is posed objectively, the decision becomes impossible.) But when by the way of objectivity no decision can be reached, we are referred to *subjectivity*.

First, then, the general relation between subjective and objective thinking is to be stated. The latter points away from the individual, strives toward the objective finished result; the former leads back to the individual so that he can exist in what is thought, and since existence, which always is in becoming, becomes its domain, it places all thinking in becoming. The subjective thinker's thought must therefore express the determination of existence: becoming, — which, since becoming is the alternation between the positive and the negative, being and non-being, means: it must have the moment of negation in it. In other words: the “positive,” secured knowledge after which the objective relation strives is in none of its forms reliable for the existing individual (cf. 67.4f and 69.4); the existing individual, who is a synthesis of the temporal and the eternal, an existing infinite spirit, — cannot hold fast the infinite and eternal, which is the only certain thing — in the element of infinity, but since he must hold it fast in the element of finitude[*ed.* 2], in existence, the highest relation cannot become secured certainty, but the infinite interest in passion, and the only certainty about the infinite becomes that which the passion of faith grasps out of objective uncertainty. The existing individual is thus in his relation to the truth as much positive as negative; he is constantly learning, constantly striving, and this striving is an infinite striving, which lasts as long as existence lasts; for existing itself is a striving. As existing, the subjective thinker cannot want to attempt to

win that conclusiveness outside existence from which a system of existence could be formed; for existence, which has an irrefutable claim upon him, is precisely the opposite of conclusiveness, and in order to be thought, existence must be thought as annulled. Nor can he, and nor can he want to, identify himself with pure thinking's metaphysical identity of subject-object, the unity of thought and being in the element of abstraction; he cannot want to fly over existence in order to reach speculation's illusory eternity. The claim of existence will prevent him from remaining in the metaphysical, and it strikes whoever wants to remain there with the comic. (NB. The consequences of this for speculative philosophy and for "the science of faith[*ed.* 3]." — From the thought of immortality an example is taken of what has been developed. *Moments*: the immortality [126] that is asked about is not a fantastic eternity sub specie æterni, but the immortality of the mortal (not the immortality of the human race). — "The question of immortality is a question of inwardness, which the subject, by becoming subjective, must put to himself. Objectively the question cannot be answered at all, because objectively one cannot ask about immortality at all, since immortality is precisely the potentiation and highest development of developed subjectivity. Only by rightly willing to become subjective can the question rightly come forth: do *I* remain, or am *I* immortal." [*ed.* SKS 7, p. 160] — Systematically, immortality cannot be proved; for, seen systematically, the whole question is nonsense. Immortality is subjectivity's most passionate interest; in the interest lies precisely the proof. With immortality the point lies in subjectivity and in subjectivity's subjective development. — Immortality in general does not exist at all. — Through the constant self-relating to the alternating that is existence, the determinateness of immortality must become indeterminateness; the highest for the existing individual is to stake all his passion on the indeterminateness and infinitely passionately relate himself to the indeterminateness of the determinateness, and this is the only way in which he as existing can know about his immortality, because as existing [*ed.* 4] he is so strangely composite that the determinateness of immortality can be had in determinateness only by the eternal one, but its determinateness can be had by the existing individual only in indeterminateness.)

It is thus the assertion of existence, in which the eternal is only as bound up with the temporal, that posits faith's subjectivity-relation to the eternal as the highest, since it becomes the only one possible for an existing individual. But if this subjectivity-relation is the highest, then the task is accordingly: to *become subjective*, and since what is posited as the object of a task is what every human being might seem to be without further ado,

becoming a subject acquires the⁴⁸ definite meaning: to become what the human being is according to his essence, to let⁴⁹ subjectivity be developed, be transformed within itself over against the eternal. Only for such a subjectivity, which is the developed possibility of subjectivity's highest possibility, does the truth come into being. The subject, referred [127] to itself, receives the task: to be infinitely concerned about itself; but this infinite concern about itself is the direction toward the eternal in relation to existence, and it leads toward the ethical and the ethical-religious, / the essential truth, and / the only essential cognizing, and this ethical and ethical-religious the subject must seek in itself; for only there, and not outside itself, and above all not in the objective observation of the [ed. 5] historical, can the individual find it (NB with regard to the observation of the historical: the transformation of the categories of ethics. — The accidentality of its world-historical significance. — The outcome. — / The impossibility for the observer of coming to act. / — The task of the ethical individuality. — The impossibility for the human spirit of seeing world history as an ethical world order.)

“To understand *oneself in existence*” then becomes the expression for the task. Whereas abstraction wants to look away from actuality and its difficulties, the subject's⁵⁰ task accordingly becomes to immerse itself in existence, to put together the ideality of thought and the singularity of existence, with consciousness to penetrate one's existence, at one and the same time as it were far above it and yet present in it and yet in becoming. — The difficulty for the existing individual becomes to give existence the continuity without which everything simply vanishes. The eternal is what gives continuity, and idealizing passion is an anticipating of the eternal in existence for an existing individual to exist. That anticipation of the eternal by passion is still not the absolute continuity, but the possibility of the approximation to the only true one there can be for an existing individual. (cf. 69.2f.)

Actual subjectivity is not the knowing but the ethically existing subjectivity. The only actuality there is for the ethical individual is his own [ed. 6] ethical actuality; all other actuality he⁵¹ only knows about, but true knowledge is a translation into possibility. — The determination of actuality as ideality (69.4). — Subjectivity is truth, subjectivity is actuality. (NB. The simultaneity of the moments of subjectivity in the existing actual [128] subjectivity. — The condition for a subjective thinker. — “Existing is an art”. [ed. SKS 7, p. 321.]

⁴⁸NB: “to choose oneself *according to one's eternal validity*” [ed. cf. e.g. SKS 3, p. 203.]

⁴⁹cf. Concluding Unscientific Postscript p. 21, note* [ed. SKS 7, p. 41.]

⁵⁰“For the existing individual, existing is his highest interest, and interestedness in existing in actuality.” [ed. SKS 7, p. 286.]

⁵¹“The individual's own ethical actuality is the only actuality.” [ed. SKS 7, p. 522.]

In the foregoing, the subjectivity-relation to the eternal has been posited as the highest, and the form of subjectivity determined. There now arises again the question: has not precisely by that determination something still been posited to which the subject relates itself, thus something objective, a matter, and by this question we are led to the final decision of the relation between subjectivity and objectivity. — (here is inserted 67.8). — Closer elaboration of the determination that truth is *in becoming*. (Truth defined as agreement between thinking and being, either in such a way that being is taken as empirical being, or abstractly as the abstract reproduction of, or the abstract prototype for, what being in concreto is as empirical being. In the first case only an approximating is reached; in the latter case the formula is a tautology. As soon as being is empirically concrete, truth itself is in becoming, and can for an existing spirit only [ed. 7] be *divined* as agreement between thinking and being). — The necessity of a *choice* between the subjective and the objective way, the impossibility of a mediation. (68.4). — The objective direction ends in a contradiction (68.5 cf. 69.1). — The subjective direction. The vanishing of objectivity. Passion as the highest of existence (68.5). — The cognition of God from the objective and the subjective standpoint (68.6) — The how of the relation is what is essential in subjectivity. In its maximum this how is the passion of infinity, and the passion of infinity is the truth itself. But the passion of infinity is precisely subjectivity, and thus subjectivity is truth. — Definition of truth. Faith. (68.7). — The Socratic wisdom. Truth as the paradox — The Socratic relation to the Christian (68.7f.).

Summing up of what has been developed, a glance toward speculation and dogmatics. — The determinations of existence: existence — becoming — synthesis of the eternal and the temporal — continued striving. — Subjectivity — inwardness — passion — the passion of infinity — / The single individual / — faith — truth as the paradox. NB. the domain of objective knowledge.

[129] [ed. 69.6 continued] Lecture 24

e) *Division of the spheres of existence*. — Since *existing* has been determined as the task for the individual, various possible *views of life* appear, various possible forms of existence, whose relation to one another must be made clear. Kierkegaard distinguishes 3 *spheres of existence*: the aesthetic, the *ethical*, the *religious*, and as a confinium between the first two he places *irony*, between the last two *humor*. The *metaphysical* forms no sphere of *existence*, since no human being exists metaphysically. The metaphysical, the ontological, *is*, but it *does not exist*; for when it exists, it is in the aesthetic, in the ethical, in the religious, and when it is, it is the abstraction of, or a prius for, the aesthetic, the ethical, the religious.

Aesthetic existence is that of *immediacy*. The aesthetic in a human being is *that by which he is immediately what he is*; he who lives in and with and from and for the aesthetic in him lives aesthetically. Within this sphere the difference can be manifold and great, but they all possess immediacy, in this: *that spirit is not determined as spirit, but immediately determined*. Even at the stage where spirituality shows itself, spirit is not determined as spirit, but as *gift*. The view of life at all these stages is *enjoyment*, but thereby is posited a condition *outside* the individual, or a condition *in* the individual such *that it is not through the individual himself*. Immediacy[ed. 69.7] is *good fortune*, and good fortune its view of life. The opposition comes *from outside*, since immediacy is *undialectical*; the opposition is then sensed as *misfortune*, but is not grasped in its *essential* significance.⁵² Misfortune is *an occurrence* in relation to immediacy (fate); seen ideally (in the direction of immediacy's view of life) it is gone, or it must go.

The *various stages* within the aesthetic can now be nuanced according as either 1) the personality is immediately determined, not spiritually but *physically* (health, beauty posited as the highest good); — or 2) the condition for enjoyment is posited *outside the individual* (wealth, honor, love etc.); or 3) the condition is posited in the individual, but *not through the individual itself* (e.g. the development of talent); — or 4) the task [130] is posited as this: *to live for one's desire* (here the multiplicity becomes an object of reflection, but this reflection is *finite*, and the personality remains in its immediacy. — In desire the individual is immediate, is *in the moment*). — ; or 5) enjoyment is determined as enjoyment of oneself, *enjoyment of oneself in enjoyment* (Epicureanism, Cynicism), — or 6) when *grieving* becomes the meaning of life, when the individual enjoys himself in sorrow in egoistic idealizing; — or 7) when *despair* itself is made a view of life, but as *despair of thought*. Also in this simple⁵³ form of aesthetic view of life, which has to a certain degree taken up into itself the consciousness of the nothingness of such a view of life, the personality remains in its immediacy. Here too life is a passionate *seizing of the moment*, [ed. 69.8] in which *continuity is lacking*, an alternation of energy and indolence, an arbitrary holding fast of the particular and the accidental. The *mood* in the individual is between wistfulness and transient sorrow. Common to all the aesthetic stages is thus⁵⁴ this: *that spirit has not taken itself out of its immediacy, has not become conscious of itself according to its eternal validity*. Where this movement has begun but been broken off, *melancholy* appears. But common to all aesthetic stages is also *despair*, conscious or

⁵²NB. The domain of poetry — The poetic ideality.

⁵³NB. The standpoint of irony.

⁵⁴The one who lives aesthetically develops *with necessity*, not with freedom. — *He is in the moment*, does not acquire continuity, *not transparency*.

unconscious. The immediate, on which the aesthetic view of life builds, is the accidental, the *transitory*. Its annihilation, the non-appearance of the external condition, of good fortune, the coming of misfortune, brings the aesthetic individual to despair; but the fact that he *comes to* despair shows only that he *was* in despair, for the transitory has *become manifest to him as what it was*. The difference, then, is that before he *was not* conscious of being in despair. *But every aesthetic view of life⁵⁵ is despair, and everyone who lives aesthetically is in despair, whether he knows it or not.*

But *despair is the means of healing*. When I despair over the *finite*, the transitory,⁵⁶ [131] and in despair separate myself from it, I find the *infinite*, the *eternal human being*. But *despair is a choice*. I can doubt without choosing it, but I cannot despair without choosing it, and when I despair, I choose again, *and choose myself, not in my immediacy, not as this accidental individual, but in my eternal validity. Despair is the doubt of the personality*. Its condition is *the will*, [ed. 70.1] and when one has in truth willed to despair, then one is in truth *beyond it*; one has found one's *self*, the personality is set at rest, the absolute won, in myself, *in my freedom*. And with this the transition is formed to another view of life, another sphere of life: the *ethical*.

By the choice, then, the *ethical* is posited. The choice in the stricter sense is therefore the *ethical* choice, not the aesthetic, which is no choice. The only *absolute either/or* there is, is the choice between good and evil, but that is also absolutely ethical. In the first instance, however, the ethical choice is not the choice *between* good and evil, *but the choice by which the distinction: good and evil, is chosen or excluded*.

From the standpoint of ethics, which is the standpoint of *self-assertion*, the choice is seen as *the self's own deed*; it endures despair and finds itself immanently⁵⁷ in despair. The choice is then determined more closely thus: when I *choose absolutely*, I choose despair, and in despair I choose⁵⁸ *the absolute*; for *I myself am the absolute, I posit the absolute and am myself the absolute*; but as entirely identical with this I must say: *I choose the absolute that chooses me, I posit the absolute that posits me*; for if I do not remember⁵⁹ that this second expression is just as absolute, then my category: to choose, is untrue, for it is precisely the identity of both. What I choose I do not posit, for if it were not posited, I could not choose it; and yet, if I did not posit it by choosing it, then I would not choose

⁵⁵The aesthetic individual is *undialectical* in himself, and has his dialectic outside himself. Existing is one thing, the contradiction something else, which comes from outside.

⁵⁶“To *will one's despair* in the infinite sense is identical with *absolute devotion*.” [ed. cf. SKS 3, p. 212.]
— “Finite despair is hardening, absolute despair is infinitization.” [ed. SKS 3, p. 212.]

⁵⁷NB. the infinite resignation (cf. Fear and Trembling.) [ed. cf. SKS 4, p. 132 ff.]

⁵⁸(This is developed further orally, and reference is made to the relation of the ethical to that of immanence.)

⁵⁹to choose oneself = to receive oneself.

it. It *is*; for if it were not, I could not choose it; it *is not*, for it first comes to be by my choosing it, and otherwise my choice would be an illusion. — When I choose the absolute, I choose *myself in my eternal validity*. Something *other than myself* I can [ed. 70.2] never choose as the absolute: for if I choose something else, then I choose it *as a finitude*, and choose it therefore *not absolutely*. But this *self* of mine is at once the most abstract and [132] the most concrete of all: it is *freedom*. The self that chooses has a multiplicity within it, insofar as it has a *history*, in which I acknowledge the identity with myself. In this history I stand in relation to *the whole race*, and this history contains something painful, and yet I am who I am only through this history. None of it can I give up when I would choose myself, but then the expression for *this acquiring of myself is repentance*. *I repent myself back into myself, back into the family, back into the race, until I find myself in God*. Only when I choose myself as guilty do I choose myself, if I am to choose myself at all in such a way that *choosing oneself* does not become identical with *creating oneself*. Since the self has come forth through a choice, it is the consciousness of *this particular free being*, which is *itself* and no other. It contains within it a rich concretion, a multiplicity of determinacies, of qualities; in short, it is *the whole aesthetic self* that has been chosen ethically, that has been *taken over by itself*. When I *think*, I also infinitize myself, but not absolutely; for *I vanish in the absolute*; only when I absolutely *choose myself* do I infinitize myself *absolutely*; for only myself can I choose absolutely, and this absolute choice of myself is *my freedom*, and only when I have absolutely chosen myself have I posited an *absolute difference*: that between *good and evil*. *The good is through my willing it, and otherwise it is not at all; it is the in-and-for-itself, posited by the in-and-for-itself, and* [ed. 70.3] *this is freedom*. As for *evil*, repentance is the expression for its belonging to me essentially, and at the same time for its not belonging to me essentially. If it did not belong to me essentially, I could not choose it, and if there were something in me that I could not choose absolutely, then I would not be choosing myself absolutely at all, then I would not myself be the absolute, but only product.

Through the ethical choice there thus takes place *the movement of infinity* in the individual; the ethical is *that whereby the human being becomes what he becomes*; what despair brings forth is the universal / and *continuity* becomes the form of the ethical life (NB. *disclosure* in the universal). /

He who chooses himself *according to his freedom* has not chosen himself *abstractly* in a contentless eternity; however concrete his self may be, he has chosen himself according to his possibility; in repentance he has ransomed himself in order to remain in his freedom, but he remains in it only *by constantly realizing it*. He is therefore eo ipso [133]

acting. One can choose oneself according to one's freedom only when one chooses oneself ethically, but ethically one can choose oneself only by *repenting* oneself, and only by repenting oneself does one become concrete, and only as a *concrete* individual is one a *free* individual. When one chooses oneself abstractly, one does not choose oneself ethically. Only when in the choice one has *taken over oneself*, put oneself on, penetrated oneself totally, so that every movement is accompanied by the consciousness of a *responsibility for oneself*, only then has one *chosen oneself ethically*, only then has one *repented oneself*, only then is one concrete, only then is one, in one's total *isolation*, in absolute *continuity with the actuality to which one belongs*. When I choose myself repentantly, I gather myself together in my whole finite [ed. 70.4] concretion, and in having thus chosen myself out of finitude, I am in the most absolute continuity with it.

The ethically chosen actual concretion is the individual's *task*. *Task is the category of ethics*, it leads immediately to action, it expresses the individual's independence of the external, his self-assertion. The condition of the task is thoroughgoing consciousness, *the individual's transparency to himself*.

The task for the ethical individual is, more precisely expressed, this: since his self, as immediate, is accidentally determined, *to work the accidental together with the universal*. He who lives ethically, he expresses in his life the universal: he makes himself *the universal human being*, not by taking off his concretion, for then he becomes nothing at all, but by putting it on and penetrating it with the universal. But *this universal the individual must himself be*, otherwise the ethical falls as an *abstraction* outside him and cannot be realized. In *conscience* lies this secret, *that the individual life is at once an individual life and also the universal*, if not immediately as such, then still according to its possibility.

The *self* that the ethical individual knows through an act of self-scrutiny is at once the *actual self* and the *ideal self*, which the individual has outside itself as the image in whose likeness it is to form itself, and which it nevertheless, on the other hand, has within itself, since it is that self. If one does not hold fast to the individual's having the ideal self *in himself*, then his thoughts and aspirations become *abstract*. The task becomes: *to transform oneself into the universal individual*, but this is possible only when

[134] Ἰ κατὰ δύναμιν have this *in me*. For the universal can very well subsist with and in the distinctive without consuming [ed. 70.5] it; it is like the fire that burned without consuming the thornbush. In the act of despair the universal human being came forth, and is now behind the concretion and breaks forth through it. *The accidental in the individual is ennobled by the choice*.

The possibility of *fulfilling duty*, the universal, is present only when the individual is at once conceived⁶⁰ as the universal and the particular. If I posit duty as something *external*, then the difference between good and evil is annulled, for when I am not myself the universal, I can enter only into an *abstract* relation to it, but the difference between good and evil is incommensurable for an abstract relation. When the personality has felt the intensity of duty with all his energy, then he is ethically matured, and duty will then break forth in himself. As soon as the personality has found himself in despair, has absolutely chosen himself, has repented himself, he has himself as his task under an eternal responsibility, and thus duty is posited in its absoluteness. Since, however, he has not *created* himself but *chosen* himself, duty is the expression of his absolute *dependence* and absolute *freedom* in identity with each other. The *particular duty* he will learn *by himself*, and in vain seek information about it from anyone else, and yet here again he will be an *autodidact* just as he is a *theodidact*, and conversely. Duty then in no case becomes something abstract for him, partly because it is not something external to him; for when that is the case, it is always abstract, partly because he himself is concrete, for when he chose himself ethically, he chose himself *in his whole concretion* and renounced the abstractness of arbitrariness.

Since the *universal is the norm of ethics*, the consequence is *that nothing universal can be given up except by virtue of a resolution*, for which the individual must at every moment bear the responsibility; that: *not to realize the universal*, is, from the standpoint of ethics [ed. 70.6], *the imperfection that is to be repented*. It follows further from this that *it is every human being's duty to have a calling*; for this is the expression of there being a rational order of things, in which every human being, if he will, fills his place in such a way that he at once expresses the universally human and the individual. *In the universal* [135] *the human being becomes disclosed: disclosure is therefore the commandment of ethics*.

In relation to the aesthetic view of life and sphere of life, the distinctive character of the ethical is, then: *freedom, choice of personality according to its eternal validity, acting, infinity, continuity, disclosure*. The sphere of action is *the inner: the individual's transformation according to the*⁶¹ *ethical ideal*. The external, *the outcome*, is the ethically indifferent: *the resolution, the willing of the good*, the ethical reality. *The requirement of infinity* is present at every moment in its absoluteness, but before this requirement the individual collapses, and *the ethical shows itself to be a transitional sphere*. Faced with the requirement the individual comes to know itself as *guilty*; in *repentance* it now seeks to

⁶⁰Ethically regarded, the single individual becomes *at once moment and the whole*.

⁶¹the “*accomplishing of one's work*” [ed. cf. SKS 3, p. 281] is the ethical individual's highest, but this work is not identical with the external result, the outcome.

regain itself; but *this it cannot do by itself*. When the individual⁶² despairs, it brings itself to despair, and therefore it can indeed by itself despair of everything, but *not*, when it does this, *come back by itself*. In the moment of decision it needs *a higher assistance*, and here the *religious* breaks forth from the ethical. —⁶³

The acting of the ethical was *inward* acting, but the acting of inwardness must show itself as *suffering*; for the individual is not able to⁶⁴ create itself anew, therefore *to suffer* is the highest acting in the inward. The human being's highest inward acting is to *repent*. To repent is not a *positive movement outward* or toward; but a *negative movement inward*,⁶⁵ [136] [ed. 70.7] *not a doing, but a letting oneself by oneself undergo*⁶⁶ *something*. Repentance, when it is held out, but in any case by means of *the sympathetic-dialectical* in it, leads on to *the religious*, to *despair over the possibility of self-assertion*, to *self-annihilation before the Deity*.

[ed. note]

[ed. 1] *Lecture 24. Recapitulation of the previous lecture.* (The assertion of existence against speculation. — The relation of faith as the highest. — The task: to become subjective. — The ethical and the ethical-religious as the essential cognizing and the essential truth. — The actual subjectivity. — Actuality. — The choice between the subjective and the objective way. — Definition of truth. — The Socratic and the Christian. — The categories of existence. — The significance of the Kierkegaardian polemic.)

The spheres of existence. 1) *the aesthetic*. — The determination: immediacy. — Enjoyment as view of life. — Good fortune. (the undialectical in immediacy. The conception of misfortune.). — The various nuances of the aesthetic. — What is common to them. — Despair in the aesthetic view of life.

2) *the ethical*. — Despair as a means of healing: in despair I find *the infinite*, the *eternal human being*. — Despair is a *choice* (NB. the significance of the will): I choose myself in

⁶²The ethical individual is dialectical inwardly in itself, in *self-assertion*, in such a way *that therefore the ultimate ground* does not become dialectical in itself, since the underlying self is used to overcome and assert itself. (the determination of the religious is self-annihilation before God.)

⁶³The ethical is only a *transitional sphere*, and therefore its highest expression is repentance as a *negative action*. [ed. SKS 6, p. 439.]

⁶⁴While aesthetic existence is essentially *enjoyment*, ethical existence essentially *struggle and victory*, religious existence is *suffering*, and not as a transitional moment, but as constantly accompanying". [ed. SKS 7, p. 263.]

⁶⁵cf. The Concept of Anxiety p. 130. [ed. SKS 4, p. 419f.] Fear and Trembling p. 106. 107f. [ed. SKS 4, p. 187f., p. 188f.]

⁶⁶The ethical already posits a kind of relation of opposition between the outward and the inward, insofar as it posits the outward in indifference, — — the religious posits the opposition definitely between the outward and the inward, definitely as opposition, therein lies precisely suffering as the existence-category for the religious, but therein lies precisely also the inner infinity of interiority, inwardly." [ed. SKS 7, p. 270f.]

my eternal validity. — Through the choice the *ethical* comes forth. The choice is in the stricter sense always ethical (the choice by which the distinction: good and evil, is chosen or excluded.) . — In the choice I choose *myself as the absolute* (NB. the dialectic of the choice). The choice brings forth *the eternal human being*, the *universal*, *freedom*. — The determination of the *self*. — *Repentance* (NB. the standpoint of ethics as the standpoint of self-assertion.) — The return of the aesthetic self. — *Good and evil* (the relation of repentance to evil). Summing-up of the determinations of the choice in relation to the aesthetic. [ed. 2] The *concretion* of the self as won by the choice and repentance. The [137] *self's taking over of itself*. — The self as *task for itself*. Working together of *the accidental and the universal*. The ethical individual expresses in his life the *universal human being*. — The being of the universal in the individual. — The *actual* self and the *ideal* self. — The fulfillment of *duty*. — *Realization of the universal*. The exceptions to this. — Having a *calling*. — *Disclosure*.

Comparison of the aesthetic and the *ethical*. The transition of the *ethical* to the *religious*. — Comparing of the basic determinations of the ethical and the religious.

At the end of the lecture the work: *The Point of View for My Work as an Author* is discussed. Attention is drawn to a) its relation to the work: *On My Work as an Author*, — b) the relation of the communications given in it to my presentation of Kierkegaard's personal development; — c) the apparent discrepancy between my division of his writings and his own, — a discrepancy which is nevertheless removed on closer consideration of the matter.

[ed. 70.7 continued] Lecture 25

The first expression of *religious* existence, which recalls the ethical's starting point, / infinite resignation, / is *the absolute*⁶⁷ *direction (respect) toward the absolute* *τελος*,⁶⁸ *expressed in action in the transformation of existence*. The *pathos* that is hereby posited is not the aesthetic, which expresses itself in the word, and in its truth can signify that the individual abandons himself in order to lose himself in the idea, whereas *existential pathos* arises through the idea's relating itself transformingly to the individual's existence. Poetic pathos is imagination with the ideality of possibility, existential pathos relates itself to the ideality of actuality, and in relation to actuality the *deed* is the highest pathos.

⁶⁷NB. The relation to the ethical.

⁶⁸infinite resignation. [ed. cf. SKS 4, pp. 123–49.]

Existence is composed of infinity and finitude, the existing individual is infinite and [138] finite. If now an *eternal happiness* is his highest good, this means that the moments of finitude are once and for all, in action, reduced to what must be given up in relation to the eternal happiness. If it does not transform his existence absolutely for him, then he is not relating himself to an eternal happiness; if there is something he will not give up for its sake, then he is not relating himself to an eternal happiness. “*To will absolutely*”⁶⁹ is to will the infinite, and to will an eternal happiness is to will absolutely, because it must be capable of being willed at every moment. And therefore it is so *abstract*, and, aesthetically seen, the poorest idea, because it is *the absolute τέλος for one willing who absolutely wills to strive* — and not thoughtlessly imagine himself finished, and not foolishly engage in haggling, whereby he only loses the absolute telos; and therefore in a finite [ed. 70.8] sense it is foolishness, precisely because in an infinite sense it is the absolute τέλος. *And therefore the one willing does not even want to know anything about this τέλος,*⁷⁰ *other than that it exists*; for as soon as he gets to know something about it, he already begins to be slowed down in his course.” [ed. SKS 7, p. 359.] — The absolute τέλος is only when the individual relates himself absolutely to it, and as an eternal happiness relating itself to an⁷¹ existing individual, they cannot possibly get each other or rest in belonging to each other in existence, i.e. in temporality; the *whole* time, existence, is the time of being in love. Mediation gets no place here; for the existing individual is prevented from gaining such a foothold outside existence that from it he could mediate what, moreover, by being in becoming, withdraws itself from completion. In relation to the absolute τέλος, that there is mediating means precisely that the absolute τέλος is reduced to a relative τέλος. *Nor is it true that the absolute τέλος becomes concrete in the relative ones*; for the absolute distinction of resignation will at every moment secure the absolute τέλος against all [139] fraternizing. It is true that the individual with the direction toward the absolute τέλος is *in the relative ones*, but he is not in these in such a way that the former exhausts itself in them. It is true that for God and for the absolute τέλος we are all equal; but it is not true that for me or for a single individual *God or the absolute τέλος* is equal to everything else. The relation to the absolute τέλος cannot be said to exhaust itself in the relative

⁶⁹(the finite cannot be willed absolutely.) cf. Concluding Unscientific Postscript p. 323. [ed. SKS 7, p. 384f.]

⁷⁰“For a finite being the *negative infinity* is the highest, and the positive a dubious reassurance.” (Stages. p. 345.) [ed. SKS 6, p. 411.]

⁷¹“In temporality the *expectation* of an eternal happiness is the highest reward” [ed. SKS 7, p. 366.] — “The first true expression for relating oneself to the absolute τέλος is *to renounce everything*; but if in the same moment the retrogression is not to begin, then the true understanding of it is *that this renouncing of everything is nevertheless nothing, if it were to merit the highest good*.” [ed. SKS 7, p. 368.]

ends, since the absolute relation can require the renunciation of⁷² *them all*. On the other hand, he who relates himself to the absolute *τελος* can very well *be in the relative ones* precisely in order, by renouncing, to practice the absolute relation. The individual is not to go out of the world, — for *externality is the untrue expression* — the task is to be that the individual strives, while practicing the absolute relation to the absolute *τελος*, to reach [ed. 71.1] the maximum: *to relate himself at one and the same time to the absolute *τελος* and to the relative ones* — not by mediating them, but by relating himself *absolutely* to his absolute *τελος* and *relatively* to the relative ones. To relate oneself now and then to one's absolute *τελος* is to relate oneself to it relatively, but to relate oneself to it relatively is to relate oneself to a relative *τελος*, for *the relation* is what is decisive. The task, then, is to *practice one's relation to the absolute *τελος* so that one constantly has it with one, while one remains in the relative ends of existence*. In the absolute respect for the absolute *τελος* a yawning chasm is fixed between it and the relative ones. *The individual does indeed live in finitude, but no longer has his life in it*. As in the great moment of resignation there was no mediating, but *choosing*, so the task is to acquire proficiency in repeating the choice of passion, and, existing, to express it, in that he no longer exists *immediately* in finitude. In existence the word is always: forward, and as long as the word is: forward! the point is to practice *the absolute distinction*.

Since there is an absolute difference between the human being and God, the human being's absolute relation to God must express this. The human being expresses himself most perfectly when he absolutely expresses the difference. *Worship is the maximum of a human being's God-relationship*, and thereby of his likeness to God, since the qualities are absolutely different. But worship means precisely *that God is everything to him*, and the one who worships is in turn the one who absolutely distinguishes. *The one who absolutely distinguishes relates himself to his absolute *τελος*, but eo ipso also to God*. The [140] absolute distinction is not between finitude and infinity, but between *existing finitely and infinitely*. For infinity and finitude are put together in existing and in the existing individual, who is not to trouble himself about creating existence or about imitating existence in thought, but all the more about existing. Existing, then, he is not to form [ed. 71.2] existence out of infinity and finitude, but, composed of finitude and infinity, he is to *become* one of the two; and one does not *become* both at once, as one is both by *being* an existing individual. Ethics has not the medium of being but of *becoming*, and, regarding every existing individual as its serf, it will constantly forbid him to begin on an abstracting from existence, whereby becoming is exchanged for being.

⁷²NB.

Only through the venture of relating himself absolutely to the absolute *τελος* does the individual become infinitized; through the venture he becomes another. The existence of the *absolute ethical good* can be expressed only by the individual himself, existing, expressing that it exists. The existing individual's relation to the eternal is *the relation of ignorance, of expectation, to what is to come*. Precisely this gives the highest pathos. The eternal happiness, as the absolute good, can be defined solely and only *by the mode of acquisition*, nothing else can be said of it than that it is *the good that is attained by absolutely venturing everything*.

Since existential pathos was determined as action, as the transformation of existence / (by this transformation it becomes more and more concrete.) / , and the task is posited as this: at one and the same time to relate oneself absolutely to one's absolute *τελος* and relatively to the relative ones, then, since this task is to be realized in existence, the beginning becomes this: *to practice the relation to the absolute τέλος by renunciation*, and thereby *to take the power away from immediacy*. For the actual individual is in immediacy, and to that extent properly *absolutely in the relative ends*. That renunciation is the condition for its being possible to begin on the *ideal* task. But even when the individual has overcome immediacy, it is nevertheless, with the victory, once again in *existence*, and thereby once again prevented from *absolutely* expressing the absolute relation to an absolute *τελος*.

The acting that belongs to existential pathos [ed. 71.3] now receives its essential [141] religious expression in being determined as *suffering*. The essential existential pathos relates itself to this: essentially existing; and essentially existing is *inwardness*, and *the acting of inwardness is suffering*; for the individual is not able to *create* itself anew, and therefore to suffer is the highest acting in the inward. Inwardness (the ethical and ethical-religious individual) grasps suffering *as the essential*, the religious individual constantly has suffering with him, demands suffering in the same sense as the immediate individual demands good fortune, and demands suffering and has suffering even if misfortune is not there in the outward. (The religious address has essentially *to uplift through suffering*.) *Religiousness is inwardness, and inwardness is the individual's relation to itself before God, its reflection into itself, and it is precisely from this that suffering comes*. — The *religious suffering* is *actual* suffering, and by the actuality of suffering is understood its *continuance* as essential for the pathetic relation to an eternal happiness, so that suffering is not deceitfully revoked or the individual goes beyond it. (Aesthetically, suffering relates itself as accidental to existence.). Nor is the actuality of suffering revoked by its acquiring significance for the eternal happiness, so that suffering could thus seem to turn into joy;

— for the *existing individual* cannot make the dialectical conversion by which suffering is converted into joy; for his knowledge of the eternal happiness is to be held fast *in the medium of existence*, not in eternity, and the perfection of joy must then fail, since it is to be had *in an imperfect form*. The individual cannot, at the same time as it suffers religiously, be beyond suffering in joy over this suffering's significance as the relation; for suffering concerns precisely this, *that he is separated from joy*, but it also signifies^[ed. 71.4] the relation, so that being without suffering signifies that one is not religious. — As for an existing individual the highest principles of thinking can be proved only negatively, and wanting to prove them positively at once betrays that the existing individual, insofar as he is after all surely an existing individual, is in the process of becoming fantastical: so also for an existing individual the existence-relation to the absolute good can be determined only by *the negative*: the relation to an eternal happiness by *suffering*, just as the certainty of faith, which relates itself to an eternal happiness, is determined by uncertainty (NB. the significance of *spiritual trial* for religious suffering. "Spiritual trial expresses the reaction of the boundary against the finite individual" [ed. SKS 7, p. 417], it is "precisely the reaction against the absolute relation's absolute expression" [ed. SKS 7, p. 142] 417], "the⁷³ absolute's own resistance." [ed. SKS 7, p. 417.]])

The religious suffering, which continually persists, is the individual's *dying away from immediacy*. The meaning of suffering is: to express, in existing: that *the individual is capable of nothing at all, but is nothing*⁷⁴ *before God*; for here again the God-relationship is recognizable by the negative, and *self-annihilation* is the essential form of the God-relationship. And this not-being-able the individual is to have continually with him, for its disappearance is the disappearance of religiousness. (This does not mean that the human being is to will to undertake nothing at all because everything is after all vanity and trumpery; but to work with one's utmost ability and then nevertheless to understand that all our being-able and not-being-able is a jest.) The religious person lies bound in finitude with the absolute idea of God present to him in the lowliness of the human being. The suffering of annihilation is there for him when in his nothingness he has the absolute idea, but no reciprocity. He wills absolutely to hold fast to the idea, and precisely this annihilates him; he wills to do everything, and while he is doing it, the powerlessness begins; for [ed. 71.5] for a finite being there is, after all, a meanwhile; he wills to do everything, he wills to express this relation absolutely, but he cannot make finitude commensurable with it. — And yet the individual is to exist in finitude, and

⁷³“The suffering in the inward, *the suffering of the God-relationship*.” [ed. SKS 7, p. 418.]

⁷⁴“The human being is capable of nothing at all before God *except becoming conscious of this*.” [ed. SKS 7, p. 419.]

cannot there uninterruptedly lead the life of eternity. When accidental finitude is put together with the idea of God, the difficulty becomes, after that first difficulty has been overcome: *to be able to do it with God*. (The *ethical* steps in as regulative.) (The *equality* of love expresses itself in that between God and human being there is *the absolute difference* through the *absolute unlikeness*, and its form is the *humility* that fully acknowledges its human lowliness with humble confidence before God.) — *The actuality of suffering* belongs to inwardness, and must not express itself in the outward; the religious is *the inwardness whose explanatory determination is to be hidden* (the determination of the ethical was disclosure). The martyrdom of hidden inwardness lies in the suffering of annihilation that is dying away from immediacy, in the very resistance of the divine [143] against an existing individual who is prevented from relating himself absolutely, and finally in life in the world with this inwardness without having an expression for it. —

Suffering was determined as the specifically religious expression of existential pathos; but it finds a still more decisive expression in *guilt*. In existence the individual is a concretion, time concrete, and even while the individual deliberates, it is ethically responsible for the use of time. Existence is not abstract haste, but *striving* and a *continuing meanwhile*; even in the moment the task is posited, something has already been wasted, because existing has gone on meanwhile and the beginning has not been made at once.

[ed. 71.6] Just as the beginning is to be made on dying away from immediacy, it is discovered that, since time has meanwhile passed, *a wrong beginning* has been made, and that the beginning must be made by becoming guilty; and *from that moment the total guilt, which is decisive, accrues usurious interest in new guilt*. *Guilt is the most concrete expression of existence; and precisely for that reason it is, for the existing individual, the expression of his relation to the eternal happiness*. The more abstract the individual is, the less it relates itself to an eternal happiness, and the more it also distances itself from guilt; for abstraction puts existence into indifference, but guilt is the expression of existence's strongest self-assertion, and it is, after all, an existing individual who is to relate himself to an eternal happiness. (*Yet the individual cannot shift the guilt onto the one who has placed him in existence, or onto existence itself*, cf. Concluding Unscientific Postscript p. 405f. [ed. SKS 7, 477f.]). *The totality of guilt* comes into being for the individual by putting his guilt, even if it were only a single one, even if it were the most insignificant of all, together with *the relation to an eternal happiness*. The putting-together yields the determination of quality. Since the idea of God is included, it transforms the determination of guilt into a determination of quality. Put together with the comparative as standard, guilt becomes

a quantifying; over against the absolute quality, guilt becomes dialectical as quality.

The *essential consciousness of guilt* is the expression for the relation to an eternal happiness by expressing *the disproportion*. Yet, however decisive the consciousness may be, *it is nevertheless always the relation that bears the disproportion*, only the existing individual cannot get hold of the relation, because the disproportion continually places itself in between as the expression for the relation. But on the other [ed. 71.7] hand they do not, after all, repel each other so (the eternal happiness and the existing individual) [144] that *the break* constitutes itself as such; on the contrary, only by being held together does the disproportion repeat itself as the decisive consciousness of guilt essentially, not of this or that guilt. *The consciousness of guilt still lies within immanence*. It is *the same* subject that, by holding guilt together with the relation to an eternal happiness, becomes essentially guilty, but the subject's ideality is nevertheless such that guilt does not make the subject into *another*, which is the expression for the break. But the break, in which lies the *paradoxical* accentuation of existence, cannot enter into the relation between an existing individual and the eternal, *because the eternal everywhere embraces the existing individual*, and the disproportion therefore remains *within immanence*. If the break is to constitute itself, the eternal must *itself* determine itself as something *temporal*, as in time, as *historical*, whereby the existing individual and the eternal in time get eternity between them. This is *the paradox*.

The decisive expression of the consciousness of guilt is this consciousness's *essential persistence*, or *the eternal recollecting of guilt* because it is continually put together with the relation to an eternal happiness. The consciousness is that the subject *is decisively changed*, while the subject's *identity* nevertheless lies in this, *that it is he himself who becomes conscious of it* by putting the guilt together with the relation to an eternal happiness. Guilt is the expression of *freedom*.

The religiousness treated in the foregoing, *the religiousness of hidden inwardness*, is not the specifically *Christian* one. The kind of religiousness described (*Religiousness A.*) is not undialectical, but it is *not paradoxically dialectical*. It is the dialectic of inward deepening, it is the relation to an eternal happiness not conditioned [ed. 71.8] by a something, but is the dialectical inward deepening of the relation, thus conditioned only by the inward deepening, which is dialectical. *This religiousness, which can also be present in paganism, must be in the individual before there can be any question of becoming attentive to the dialectical determinations of the Christian. It has only human nature in general as its presupposition.*

The upbuilding in this sphere is that of immanence, is *the annihilation in which*

the individual puts himself aside in order to find God, since it is namely the individual himself who is the hindrance. The upbuilding is thus here quite rightly recognizable by *the negative*, by the self-annihilation that finds the God-relationship *within itself*, that, [145] suffering through, sinks into the God-relationship, is grounded in it, because God is in the ground, if only everything that is in the way has been cleared away, every finitude and first and foremost the individual himself in his finitude, in his insistence on being in the right against God.

The border territory of this religiousness is *humor*. The humorist grasps the meaning of suffering in relation to existing, / he feels the pain and is sympathetic /, but then makes the deceitful turn and revokes the suffering in the form of jest. He continually puts the idea of God together with something else, and brings out the contradiction, but he does not himself relate himself in religious passion to God; he transforms himself into a jesting and yet profound point of transit for all these conversions, but he does not himself relate himself to God. Humor puts the eternal recollecting of guilt together with everything, but does not itself, in this recollecting, relate itself to an eternal happiness. Humor rests in immanence; it is, when it makes use of the Christian determinations, not Christianity but a pagan speculation that has come to *know* everything Christian. It is *the equilibrium of the comic and the tragic*.

[ed. 72.1] In the same relation as humor stands to religiousness, *irony* stands to the ethical. Irony arises by continually putting the particulars of finitude together with *the ethical infinite requirement* and letting the contradiction come into being. But the ironist does not in himself relate himself to the absolute requirement of the ethical. Irony is an *art of existence*, he who essentially has it has it *always*; for irony is the infinity in him. — “The ironist levels on the basis of *abstract humanity*, the humorist on the basis of *the abstract God-relationship*.” [ed. SKS 7, p. 408.] — “In irony there is *no sympathy*, there is self-assertion, and its sympathy is therefore altogether indirectly sympathizing, not with any human being, but with the idea of self-assertion as every human being’s possibility.” [ed. SKS 7, p. 502.]

Since humor and irony become the border territories of the religious and the ethical, they can become the *incognito* of the religious person and the ethicist.

[ed. note]

The religious. 1) the absolute orientation toward the absolute $\tau\epsilon\lambda\omicron\sigma$, expressed in [146] action in the transformation of existence. (aesthetic — existential pathos?). — Relinquishing the moments of finitude over against the eternal happiness. — The abstraction of the eternal happiness. — *The expectation* of an eternal happiness. — The absolute $\tau\epsilon\lambda\omicron\sigma$ in

relation to the relative ones (NB. God and the absolute *τελος*). — At one and the same time to relate oneself absolutely to the absolute *τελος* and relatively to the relative ones. — The absolute distinction. — Worship as the God-relationship. — To *become* infinite. — Inward infinitizing. — Determination of the essence of the eternal happiness.

2) The practice of the relation to the absolute *τελος*. Suffering — the acting of inwardness is suffering. — The relation of suffering to the God-relationship. — The actuality of suffering is its *persistence*. (NB. Spiritual trial) — Dying away from immediacy. That the individual is capable of nothing at all, but is nothing before God (self-annihilation). — The norm's determination of suffering. — Existence in finitude. — Religiousness as hidden inwardness. — The martyrdom of hidden inwardness.

3) Guilt as the specific expression of the religious. — Guilt as the most concrete expression of existence. (NB. pushing the guilt away from oneself). — The totality of guilt. — The consciousness of guilt; its relation to immanence. — The eternal recollecting of guilt.

The relation between Religiousness A. and the Christian. Humor — irony.

[ed. 72.1 continued] Lecture 26

f) *Christianity*. — From the preceding religious sphere the Christian, *paradoxical religiousness* (Religiousness B), is distinguished by this, that it has *conditions* that are not the dialectical deepening of inward deepening, but a *specific something that more precisely determines the eternal happiness*, not in that it more precisely determines the individual's appropriation of it, but more precisely determines the eternal happiness, yet not as a task for thinking, but precisely as *paradoxically repelling toward new pathos, the pathos of the absurd*. The learning Christian both has and uses his understanding, respects the universally human, does not explain it by lack of understanding if someone does not become a Christian, but in relation to Christianity *he believes against the understanding*, and here too uses the understanding — in order to take [ed. 72.2] care that he believes against the understanding. *Nonsense he therefore cannot believe against the understanding*, [147] for⁷⁵ the understanding will precisely see through that it is nonsense, and prevent him from believing it, but he uses the understanding so much that through it he becomes *attentive to the incomprehensible*, and now he relates himself to this, believing against the understanding. *Faith belongs essentially in the sphere of the paradoxical-religious*; all other faith is only an analogy that is none. In faith there is a break with the understanding and with immanence; immanence's last foothold, *eternity behind*, is lost, and the subject

⁷⁵NB. *Religiousness A must come in between as terminus a quo for paradoxical religiousness*, only thereby is it prevented that the Christian determinations run together with the aesthetic ones.

exists hard pressed at the extremity of existence, *by virtue of the absurd*.

That in which the Christian can be concentrated is: *that an eternal happiness is decided in time by the relation to something historical*. All the other Christian determinations lie in this one, and can be consistently derived from it. It forms the sharpest contrast to paganism; in it lies *the new dialectical element that sharpens pathos*.

The dialectical contradiction is then *first* this: that *an eternal happiness is expected in time through a relation to something else in time*. Existence is here paradoxically accentuated, the distinction *here and hereafter* absolutely determined *in that the eternal itself has come into being in a moment of time*. Since the eternal has come into being in a moment of time, the existing individual does not come in time to relate himself to the eternal or to bethink himself of his relation to it (this is A.), but *in time to relate himself to the eternal in time*, so that the relation is thus within time, which relation is equally in conflict with all thinking, whether one reflects on the individual or on the god.

The paradoxical-religious posits the opposition absolutely between existence and the eternal, for precisely the fact that the eternal is at a specific [ed. 72.3] moment of time is the expression for this, *that existence is led astray by the hidden immanence of the eternal*. In the religious A. the eternal is *ubique et nusquam*, but hidden by the actuality of existence; in the paradoxical-religious the eternal is at a specific place, and this is precisely *the break with immanence*. *The individual is paradoxically dialectical*, every remnant of original immanence annihilated, and all connection cut off, the individual hard pressed at the extremity of existence. Existing becomes the absolute contradiction of immanence. There is no underlying immanent kinship between the temporal and the [148] eternal, because the eternal itself has come into time and wills *there* to constitute the kinship. — *The teacher becomes the god in time*, the disciple a *new creation*, the individual, who was not eternal, *becomes so*, thus does not bethink itself of what it is, but becomes what it was not, and, be it noted, becomes something that has the dialectic that, as soon as it is, it *must have been*; for this is the dialectic of the eternal. What is inaccessible to all thinking is *that one can become eternal although one was not*.

The dialectical contradiction is *next* this: *that an eternal happiness is based on the relation to something historical*. For all historical knowledge and information it holds that it is only an *approximation* even at its maximum. The contradiction is: to build one's eternal happiness on an approximation, which can be done only *when one has no eternal determination in oneself* (which again cannot be thought, any more than how one then hits upon it; *therefore the god must provide the condition as well*), for which reason this again hangs together with the paradoxical accentuation of existence. The contradiction

arises in that the subject, at the extremity of its subjective passion [*ed.* 72.4] (in concern for an eternal happiness), is to base this on a piece of historical information whose maximum becomes an approximation. This presupposes that the existing individual must have lost continuity with himself, must have become *another* (not different from himself *within himself*), and now, by receiving the condition from the god, become a new creation. The contradiction is *that becoming a Christian begins with the miracle of creation*, and that this befalls one who is created, and that Christianity is nevertheless proclaimed to all human beings, who by it must be regarded *as not existing*, since the miracle by which they come into being must come in between, as actual, or as the expression for the break with immanence and the resistance that absolutely makes the passion of faith paradoxical so long as one exists in faith, i.e., for⁷⁶ the whole of life; for he always has, after all, his eternal happiness based on something historical. Here too is a break with all thinking.

The dialectical contradiction is *finally* this: *that the historical in question is not something simply historical, but formed from what can become historical only against its essence, thus by virtue of the absurd*. The historical is that the god, the eternal one, has come into being at a specific moment of time as a single human being. That the one who according to his essence is eternal comes into being in time, is born, grows, dies, is a break [149] with all thinking. In all *speculative* talk of an eternal becoming of God the scene is in the medium of *possibility*⁷⁷, but when it is moved over into that of *actuality*, the *absolute paradox* emerges. Here possibility is not higher than actuality, but actuality is the highest and is the absolute paradox. Actuality, i.e., that this and that has actually happened, is the object of faith, and yet surely not any human being's or humanity's own thoughts; for thought is then at most possibility, but possibility as comprehension is precisely the [*ed.* 72.5] comprehension by which the retrograde step is taken that faith ceases. In the fantasy-medium of possibility God can very well, in imagination, fuse together with the human being, but in actuality, with the single human being, lies precisely the paradox.

In Religiousness A, which rests in immanence, *every* human being is⁷⁸ essentially regarded as a partaker in happiness and becomes so in the end. *Religiousness B is separating, polemical: only on this condition* do I become blessed, and as I absolutely

⁷⁶“Christianity makes existing paradoxical, for which reason it becomes the paradox so long as one exists, and only eternity has the explanation.” [*ed.* SKS 7, p. 512.]

⁷⁷“Faith is the objective uncertainty with the repulsion of the absurd, held fast in the passion of inwardness, which is precisely the relation of inwardness raised to its highest power.” [*ed.* SKS 7, p. 554f.] “The appropriation [the believer's] is the paradoxical inwardness.” [*ed.* SKS 7, p. 554.]

⁷⁸“Religiousness A makes existing as strenuous as possible (outside the sphere of the paradoxical-religious), but does not base the relation to an eternal happiness on its existing, but lets the relation to an eternal happiness be the basis of the transformation of existence.” [*ed.* SKS 7, p. 522.]

bind myself by it, so I exclude everyone else. Having one's eternal happiness based on something historical makes the Christian's good fortune recognizable by *suffering*; the chosen one is not directly understood as the fortunate one, but understood with such difficulty that for anyone other than the chosen one it would have to be something to despair over.

Through the dialectical contradictions in Religiousness B *pathos is sharpened*, and this sharpened pathos is a) *the consciousness of sin*. This is the expression for *the paradoxical transformation of existence*. Sin is the new medium of existence; to exist now means that *the individual, by having come into being, has become a sinner*. The consciousness of sin is the break with immanence; by coming into being the individual becomes another, or: in the now in which he is to come into being, he becomes, by coming into being, another. From eternity the individual is not a sinner, but when the being eternally disposed, which [150] comes into being in birth, becomes a sinner in birth or is born as a sinner, then it is existence that so closes in around it that every communication of immanence by way of recollection, through being taken back into the eternal, is broken off, and the predicate "sinner," which first, but also at once, appears with the coming into existence, acquires such paradoxically overwhelming [ed. 72.6] power that the coming into existence makes him another. This is the consequence of the god's appearance in time, which prevents the individual from relating himself backward to the eternal, since he now, going forward, comes in time to become eternal through the relation to the god in time. *The consciousness of sin, therefore, the individual cannot, like the consciousness of guilt, come to know by himself*; for the consciousness of sin is the very change of the subject, which shows that there must be *outside* the individual the power that informs him that he, by having come into being, has become other than he was, has become a sinner. This power is *the god in time*. — In the consciousness of sin the individual becomes conscious of himself *in his unlikeness to the universally human*, which only by itself becomes conscious of what it is to exist as a human being. For since the relation to that historical something conditions the consciousness of sin, *this cannot have existed during all the time in which this historical something did not exist*. The believer extends the consciousness of sin to *the whole race*,⁷⁹ but does not at the same time know the whole race saved, inasmuch as the single individual's salvation will, after all, depend on his being brought into relation to that historical something, which precisely because it is historical cannot be everywhere at once, but takes time to become known to human beings, so that countless generations, without any guilt of their own, may remain ignorant that it has existed. To have an

⁷⁹NB. *Hereditary sin*. The Sickness unto Death. p. 90. 97. [ed. SKS 11, p. 202f., p. 208.]

existence in this determination is sharpened pathos, both *because it cannot be thought* and *because it is isolating*. For sin is no teaching or doctrine for thought, in that case the whole thing becomes⁸⁰ nothing; it is a *determination of existence* and precisely cannot be thought.

b) *The possibility of offense* or the *antipathetic collision*, which is immediately given with the paradox, which requires *faith against the understanding*. Christianity is the only power that can in truth arouse offense. For the believer offense is at the beginning, and its possibility is the [ed. 72.7] constant fear and trembling in his existence.

c) *The pain of sympathy* on account of the believer's not, like the religious person [151] A., latently sympathizing, and not being able to sympathize, with *every human being qua human being*, but essentially *only with the Christians*. For the believer it holds that outside that condition there is no happiness, and for him it holds, or it may come to hold for him, that he must hate father and mother. For is it not like hating them, to have one's happiness bound to a condition that he knows they do not accept? He can to the very last be willing to do everything for them, fulfill all a faithful son's duties with the greatest enthusiasm; in that way Christianity does not bid him hate, and yet when this condition separates them, separates them forever: is it not as if he hated them? And is this not a terrible sharpening of pathos in relation to an eternal happiness?

The specific determination of the Christian is thus⁸¹ *sin* and its opposite *faith*, and the way of faith is through / *despair* and through / *the possibility of offense*; its object is the *absolute paradox*, which is *believed by virtue of the absurd*.

With *the doctrine of sin* Christianity begins, and *the consciousness of sin becomes the tensile force*⁸² *in the individual that bears faith in the paradox and Christianity's ideal requirement*. The category of sin is the category of singularity; it cannot be thought speculatively, just as one cannot think the single human being, since singularity lies beneath the concept, but only the concept human being. But before God, in religion, the human being is always the *single* human being, alone over against God, alone in this enormous exertion and this enormous responsibility.

The definition of sin is: after having been enlightened by a revelation from God about what sin is, before God — or with the idea of God — in despair not to will to be oneself, [ed. 72.8] or in despair to will to be oneself. Sin is⁸³ *despair*, but the opposite of sin is not that despair is not and has not been, but that the possibility of being able to be in

⁸⁰ *The forgiveness of sins* is the paradoxical satisfaction by virtue of the absurd.

⁸¹ (with regard to the section 72.7–73.4, cf. the enclosed leaf.) [ed. note]

⁸² cf. Practice in Christianity p. 76. 166. [ed. SKS 12, p. 79f., p. 157f.]

⁸³ Sin is a position, not a negation cf. The Sickness unto Death. p. 97. [ed. SKS 11, p. 208.]

[152] despair⁸⁴ is annihilated and in every moment is being annihilated. The definition of the state in which despair no longer is, is this: in relating itself to itself, and in willing to be itself, the self is grounded transparently in the power that posited it. But this formula is the definition of⁸⁵ *faith*. In this formula, that is, *faith in the forgiveness of sins* is contained; for it is the condition for the individual's being able to relate himself to himself and to will to be himself before God. But in the forgiveness of sins there lies in turn the faith that God, also for the sake of this self, let himself be born, became man, suffered and died, the faith *that Christ was God*. But in faith in the forgiveness of sins and in the faith that this individual human being is God lies *the possibility of offense*; for *between human being and God the yawning abyss of quality is fixed by sin*; therefore offense is there when a human being would forgive sins, and when the qualities of God and of the human being are put together in this human being, in *unrecognizability*, and this lowly human being says that he is God, then the possibility of offense is there again. The words: *blessed is he who takes no offense at me*, belong to the proclamation about Christ. But he who does not take offense, he *worships*, believing.

The condition for believing in Christ is to⁸⁶ become *contemporary* with him, to see him in his true form and in the surroundings of actuality, as he walked on earth, in *the form of abasement*, for in glory no one has yet seen him, and no one can see him before his return in glory. The believer *believes* that [ed. 73.1] Christ is now in glory, but it was under the conditions of abasement⁸⁷ that he spoke of his return in glory; therefore this [153] can only be *believed*, but one cannot have become a believer without having come to him in his state of abasement; otherwise he does not exist, for *only thus has he existed*. That he will come in glory is *expected*, but it can only be expected and believed by the one who has held and holds to him as he has existed. What Christ has said and taught, every word he has spoken, becomes eo ipso untrue when we give it the appearance of its being Christ in glory who says it. No, *he* is silent; the *abased one* speaks.

From history one can come to *know* nothing about Christ; for about him one can

⁸⁴NB. Sin and grace.

⁸⁵This definition of faith is compared with the one given earlier, and it is shown how they lead to the same point.

⁸⁶"In relation to *the absolute* there is only one time: the *present*. For him who is not contemporary with the absolute, it does not exist at all. And since Christ is the absolute, it is easily seen that in relation to him there is only one situation, that of contemporaneity" [ed. SKS 12, p. 75.] — "Only the contemporary is actuality *for me*. And thus every human being can only become contemporary: with the time in which he lives, — and then with one thing more, with Christ's life on earth, for Christ's life on earth, the sacred history, stands here by itself, outside history." [ed. SKS 12, p. 76.]

⁸⁷"*Christ's life on earth is nothing past*, whence in each generation true Christians are contemporary with Christ, and have nothing to do with the Christians of the previous generation, but only with the contemporary Christ. His life on earth follows the race, and follows each generation in particular as *the eternal history*; his life on earth has eternal contemporaneity." [ed. SKS 12, p. 76.]

know nothing at all; he is *the paradox*, the object of faith, *there only for faith*. One cannot prove his divinity from the *consequences* of his life; this, which is incommensurable with all historical consequences, is reached only by faith.

Christ is thus the object only of faith, and the Christ who is the object of faith is *Christ in the state of abasement*, and from him *the possibility of offense* is inseparable. Offense relates essentially to *the composition of God and human being*, or to *the God-man*. The God-man is the unity of God and *an individual* human being. The relation to the God-man is impossible except as beginning with the situation of contemporaneity.

Offense has 2 forms: in the direction of *loftiness*; one takes offense at an individual human being's saying that he is God, acting and speaking in a way that betrays God; — or in the direction of *lowliness*: that he who is God is this lowly human being, suffering as a lowly human being. The God-man is the paradox, absolutely the paradox; therefore it is quite certain that the understanding must come to [ed. 73.2] a standstill at it. — (To the latter kind of offense, offense in the direction of lowliness, there then corresponds a possibility of offense: *that the Christian must come to suffer in the world*, that truly to be a Christian, since it is to be *Christ's follower*, becomes *likeness to him in suffering*. — The decisive thing in *Christian suffering* is the *voluntariness* and the *possibility of offense* for the sufferer. For the natural human being the *infinite* passion with which Christianity apprehends eternal⁸⁸ happiness is an offense. The *absolute* is an offense to the understanding.)

But the possibility of offense is *the inescapable*. The true God *cannot* / as *spirit* / [154] become *directly recognizable*; therefore he can only become the object of *faith*: only⁸⁹ as the object of faith is he *true* God, and only as true God can he *save the human being*. By his love he must therefore plunge the human being into the decision of offense. The annulment of offense was, now, *faith*,⁹⁰ but faith is a *choice*, by no means the direct reception, — and it is the receiver who becomes manifest, whether he will believe or take offense. If one abolishes the possibility of offense or faith, one abolishes the God-man as well; but if one abolishes the God-man, one abolishes Christianity as well.

The Christian's true relation to Christ was the relation of contemporaneity; his task is *to become Christ's*⁹¹ *follower*, but Christ's follower *in the state of abasement*;⁹² for only in this can he become the object of imitation. But Christ came into the world *in order*

⁸⁸NB. Christian compassion — the Christian idea of the misery of the human being (cf. Practice in Christianity I.)

⁸⁹Practice in Christianity. p. 145. 147. [ed. SKS 12, p. 139f., 141.]

⁹⁰NB. The self's choice of Christ (Practice in Christianity. p. 170ff. [ed. SKS 12, p. 161ff.])

⁹¹Cf. Practice in Christianity. p. 116, cf. p. 126. [ed. SKS 12, p. 114f., p. 123.]

⁹²Christ as "the prototype" [ed. cf. e.g. SKS 8, p. 332 and SKS 10, p. 133.]

to suffer; the imitation of him then becomes, since it is the transformation of our life into likeness with him, the *voluntary*⁹³ taking on of suffering. *To will truth absolutely and to give the truth actuality in one's life* is the Christian's task, but it belongs to truth just as essentially to suffer in *this* world as to triumph in another, in the world of *truth*. [ed. 73.3] Likeness to Christ *in love*, which as *love of the neighbor* embraces *all*, it being the love of *self-denial* in contrast to the egoism of preferential love; likeness to him in *unconditionally willing the true*; likeness in *deadness* to the world, in the giving up of the earthly, must bring *Christian suffering*: not only the *inward* suffering, which is given in the very annihilation of the selfish, of the ego's⁹⁴ immediacy, in the possibility of despair and of offense, which must be overcome every moment, in the uncertainty that in [155] temporality constantly follows the acquired certainty, / in the pain of the consciousness of sin, in spiritual trial, / and in the suffering of sympathy that suffers through the untruth and sin of others, in compassion for them, but also in suffering *from without*, in hatred, persecution and mockery, / in suffering for the sake of self-contempt. /⁹⁵

The last-named follows necessarily from *the relation of Christ and of the Christian to the world*, and from this relation there follow in turn the consequences that contain the judgment on *established Christendom*, — the judgment that was pronounced on it through Kierkegaard's last writings.⁹⁶

Decisive for Christ's relation to the world is the God-man's *essential heterogeneity* with every other human being and with the whole race. / (NB. Sinfulness) / Christianity relates itself essentially to *eternity*;⁹⁷ life here on earth is, for each individual in particular of the countless human beings who have lived, *the time of testing*. It is indeed Christianity's intention that it is to be proclaimed *to all*, but from this it does not follow that it should ever happen that all should⁹⁸ accept it and become true Christians. Christianity never becomes a development *within* the determination: the human race; it relates itself constantly in the same way to what Christianity calls *the world*: paganism and the natural human being in Christendom. *The world always remains essentially the same; like the sea, like the air, in short like an element; for it is, and is meant to be, the element* [ed.

⁹³cf. The Moment VI, 18f. VIII, 12. [ed. SKS 13, p. 268f., p. 351f.]

⁹⁴cf. The Moment V, 3f. 11. "to love God in hatred of humankind, in hatred of oneself and thereby of other human beings." [ed. SKS 13, p. 227f., p. 233f.]— cf. The Moment VI, 14 [ed. SKS 13, p. 266f.], The Moment VII. 31f. 36. 38. [ed. SKS 13, p. 303f., p. 307f., p. 309f.]

⁹⁵cf. The Moment VIII, 9. 12f. [ed. SKS 13, p. 349f., p. 351ff.] "What Christ Judges of Official Christianity" p. 11f. 13 [ed. SKS 13, p. 179f., p. 180f.] "the Christianity of the New Testament is: in the fear of God to suffer for the doctrine at the hands of men." cf. The Moment IX, 16. [ed. SKS 13, p. 383.]

⁹⁶cf. the enclosed leaf [ed. note]

⁹⁷cf. The Moment VI, 23, IX, 16. [ed. SKS 13, p. 273f., p. 383.]

⁹⁸cf. The Moment V, 16ff. [ed. SKS 13, p. 237.] (NB the defectiveness in the dialectic). — Practice in Christianity p. 234f. [ed. SKS 12, p. 216 ff.]

73.4] *that can furnish the test for that which lies in having to be a Christian, who in this world is always a member of the Church militant.* — “The concept Christian is a polemical concept; one can be a Christian only in opposition or oppositionally!” [ed. SKS 13, p. 187] — “To be a Christian is to live, to love God, in a relation of opposition.” [ed. SKS 13, p. 216] — Christ’s saying “my kingdom is not of this world” [ed. John 18:36] is an eternally valid saying, always at every time equally valid, about the relation between Christ’s kingdom and this world; as soon as Christ’s kingdom makes peace with this world and becomes a kingdom of this world, Christianity is abolished. When, on the other hand, [156] Christianity is in truth, it is indeed a kingdom *in* this world, but not *of* this world, that is: it is *militant*. When the Christian Church claims to have triumphed in this world, then it is not the Church that has triumphed; then the world has triumphed. Then the heterogeneity between Christianity and the world has vanished, the world has won, Christianity lost. Then Christ is no longer *the God-man*, but an *eminent human being*, whose life is homogeneous with the development of the race. Then *eternity is abolished* and the scene of the consummation of all things placed *within temporality*.

[ed. note]

[ed. 1] (Kierkegaard)

The Christian. I.) The relation to Religiousness A. — The paradox — The understanding’s relation to it. The fundamental determination of the Christian: *that an eternal happiness is decided in time by the relation to something historical.* — The *dialectical* contradictions in this. — The intensification of *pathos* lying in this (the consciousness of sin. — The possibility of offense. — The pain of sympathy.)

II.) The coherence of the fundamental Christian determinations. — Christianity’s relation to the world:

a) *The consciousness of sin* (the *single individual*). — The definition of sin (the relation to despair). — The opposite of sin is *faith*; definition of this. (Faith’s relation to God and human being with respect to its origin.).

b) *Faith* as faith in the forgiveness of sins, which, since the forgiveness of sins is only possible through God, becomes faith in *the God-man*.

c) The composition: *the God-man* — Closer determination of this.

d) The inescapability of *offense*. — Its forms.

e) The relation of *contemporaneity* to Christ (only contemporaneity gives the relation.). — The Christ to whom the believer relates himself is Christ *in abasement* (— further development).

[ed. 2] compare 72.8, 73.1.).

[157] f) *The task for the believing Christian: the imitation of Christ* (Christ is *the prototype*.)
i.e. imitation of the abased Christ — of Christ's suffering.

g*) The relation of the Christian to *the world*. — The world seen under the determination: sin. The necessary relation of opposition. — The heterogeneity between Christ and the world. The impossibility of Christianity's fusing with the worldly. — *Christian suffering*.

h) The consequence of this for the judgment on *the established order*.

*) Since the world is seen under the determination *sin* and the single individual as sinner (*hereditary sinner*), the relation of opposition becomes present; each individual who in faith relates himself to the Christian separates himself from the mass of sinfulness (*massa perditionis*), but this mass continues to form the opposition. The possibility that *all individuals*, cf. *The Moment* 5, 16ff. [ed. SKS 13, p. 237ff.], should become Christians is contradicted by Christianity's conception of time as the time of testing (NB. Christian self-denial, *The Moment* 3, p. 8. [ed. SKS 12, p. 191f.]) — Christianity's *naturalization* is therefore impossible (NB. becoming a Christian as a child). This follows also from *the essential heterogeneity of Christ and of Christ's history with the race and the history of the race*. It remains the eternally contemporary absolute, which is never assimilated.

[ed. 73.4 continued] Lecture 27.

Herein, then, lies *the judgment on the established order, on Christendom*. It can be summed up thus: "*Christendom*" is *the putrefaction of Christianity*; a "*Christian world*" is: *the falling away from*⁹⁹ *Christianity* [ed. SKS 14, p. 173, col. 1.]. The *established order* is the homogeneity between Christianity and the world; it is the direct commensurability in which being a Christian gets its corresponding expression in the external, through external recognition, through esteem, honor, wealth, power, / it is *naturalized Christianity*. / *The relation of opposition* is thus taken away, / and since it is taken away, this has happened in such a way *that the Christian has gone back to worldliness's world*. From this, in the first place, the consequence becomes / that of *Christian suffering* the
[158] one coming *from without* is taken away, the one that is given [ed. 73.5] by the relation of opposition, and thereby the *inner* one too, the one that is the reflex of the outer in sympathy. / But next, then, the consequence becomes that Christianity in this fusion has lost *its absoluteness*, and that the *suffering* that stands in relation to this must also disappear. Becoming a Christian becomes something one simply is, by being born into Christianity; the earnestness of decision disappears; *all are Christians*. / As the absoluteness of Christianity disappears, not only does the *ideal requirement* disappear: the

⁹⁹cf. Bladartikler p. 109 [ed. SKS 14, p. 193, col. 2].

proclamation of Christianity is toned down, the specifically Christian fades and is veiled, and this toned-down Christianity is then set up as the highest; the ideal is declared to be extravagance and fantasy; but since Christianity only is *as the absolute*, the fact that this is lost is *the cessation of Christianity*.¹⁰⁰

It is against this that *Kierkegaard's last writings* direct the decisive objection. The Christian had been the task of his life and of his authorship, not change¹⁰¹ in the external, but *the inward deepening of Christianity*. In all his writings his task had been: *to introduce the ideals*, to fight *against the illusions by means of the ideals*. Against the illusion of Christendom, against the concealment of the decisive, the *ideal* form of Christianity therefore had to be brought forth. This happened in “The Sickness unto Death”, still more definitely in “Practice in Christianity”. Here the requirement is forced up to the highest of ideality so that it could be heard, so that one, with the consciousness of it, might learn “not only to flee to grace; but to flee to it *also in relation*¹⁰² *to the use of grace*” [ed. SKS 12, p. 15.], that one “before God might sincerely humble oneself under the requirements of ideality.” [ed. SKS 12, p. 79.] The book was *a question* put indirectly to the established order: whether it would acknowledge the Christianity that the book professes, and in this acknowledgment make the admission concerning its own Christianity. It could thus at one and the same time become the only possible defense of the established order, and the judgment on the established order. [ed. 73.6] It became the latter through the established order’s own fault, and the polemic against the established order now became inescapable. It is superfluous to discuss the *external history* of this polemic; it is still so [159] fresh in memory. I will only point out that it does not begin at the moment *when the article on Mynster* was published in “Fædrelandet” [ed. cf. SKS 14, p. 151], but that, just as it had long been foreseen by Kierkegaard and hinted at in conversation, it is also hinted at in his writings. This holds not only of such *more general hints* as this one: “There are cases where an established order can be of such a character that the Christian ought not to put up with it, ought not to say that Christianity is precisely this indifference to the external” (Bladartikler. p. 53 [ed. SKS 14, p. 114, col. 2]), — but of the *most definite statements*, such as this one: “I have, after all, never in Christendom heard any discourse or sermon about which I, if it were before God that this question was put to me, would unconditionally dare to say that it was Christian” / (Practice in Christianity. p. 241 [ed. SKS 12, p. 222]) and of the whole portrayal in “For Self-Examination” p. 13ff. [ed. SKS 13, p. 46ff.], where Mynster is characterized without being named (cf. Bladartikler p. 69 [ed.

¹⁰⁰NB. “The Condition of Christendom.”

¹⁰¹cf. The Moment VIII.7 [ed. SKS 13, p. 348].

¹⁰²cf. Bladartikler p. 123. p. 59 note. [ed. SKS 14, p. 213, p. 124, the footnote.]

SKS 14, p. 132, col. 2 – p. 133, col. 2]) and Kierkegaard's own position designated. / — And for nearly every one of the articles in "The Moment" one will find the catchwords in Practice in Christianity, especially in its last part.

In the conflict itself only *the course of development*, leaving aside the personal, will occupy us. In what form the *first protest* was lodged had significance at the moment it was lodged; that it already no longer has now. The passions that were set in motion at the time by misunderstanding and distortion of Kierkegaard's action have subsided again; it is now not difficult to gain the calm to see that the protest was not directed at the individual personality, that it was not directed at the usage of the word *witness to the truth*, but that it was directed at the matter itself: over against the ideal truth of Christianity [ed. sic], which is truth only *as life*, as realized by the individual / in the imitation of Christ in suffering, / to set up something else as truth, something *lower*, and this only *as*¹⁰³ *an object of contemplation*, and then let the proclamation of this entitle one to the name witness to the truth. With that conception of truth, the concept of [160] the witness to the truth [ed. 73.7] had to become inseparable from *suffering*; for since Christianity is heterogeneous with the world, the witness to the truth must always be recognizable by heterogeneity with this world, by offense, by suffering. (cf. what was developed earlier.) In that protest against the use of the name witness to the truth for the most eminent representative of established Christendom in Denmark, the judgment was thus pronounced on this whole Christendom itself, and the judgment ran, as has already been said, that "Christendom" is the distortion of Christianity. It was pronounced *that official Christianity was a blasphemy*, that¹⁰⁴ the *pastor's* position was an impropriety / (cf. Bladartikler p. 111 [ed. SKS 14, p. 197, col. 2], The Moment II,7. III,7f. V, 30, VII, 12. 40) [ed. SKS 13, p. 149f., p. 191f., p. 249f., p. 289, p. 310f.], that *Christianity had vanished* in the illusion of a¹⁰⁵ *Christian world*, in which we all by birth are¹⁰⁶ Christians, that *indifferentism* had stepped into¹⁰⁷ the place of religion, that humanity was not even "*in a state of religion*" [ed. SKS 13, p. 315], and that the sorrowful question was raised: is *faith to be found on*¹⁰⁸ *earth*? it was raised by one who himself did not claim to be a Christian, but

¹⁰³Christianity is no doctrine but expresses an existence-contradiction and is an existence-communication" (i.e. a doctrine that is to be realized in existence). Concluding Unscientific Postscript. p. 289. [ed. SKS 7, p. 345f.]

¹⁰⁴cf. Bladartikler. p. 103 [ed. SKS 14, p. 180, col. 2 – p. 181]. The Moment. V, 32 [ed. SKS 13, p. 251.]

¹⁰⁵cf. Bladartikler. p. 85. 106. 130. [ed. SKS 14, p. 155, col. 2, p. 189 col. 2 – 190, col. 1, p. 220.] The Moment II,9. III,3. IV,16. VI,11 [ed. SKS 13, p. 151, p. 187, p. 216, p. 263f.].

¹⁰⁶cf. The Moment. 7, 19f. [ed. SKS 13, p. 297.]

¹⁰⁷The Moment. 6, p. 9. [ed. SKS 13, p. 262f.]

¹⁰⁸Christianity — does not exist at all" (Bladartikler. p. 89 [ed. SKS 14, p. 163, col. 1]). "The Christianity of the New Testament does not exist at all" (ibid. p. 93 [ed. SKS 14, p. 169 col. 1]). cf. The Moment. VI,16 [ed. SKS 13, p. 267.]

only to know what Christianity was, to strive after it, and to will honesty (cf. Bladartikler. p. 100-103. [ed. SKS 14, p. 177-81.])

/ In “What Christ Judges of Official Christianity” Kierkegaard himself describes the course of development in the conflict in the following way: / The beginning was made in *Practice in Christianity* with the pseudonymous poetic presentation of ideal Christianity. The aim was taken at official Christianity, which abolishes the imitation of Christ, so that one relates oneself to the prototype *only through the imagination*, oneself lives in quite other determinations, which is to relate oneself only *poetically* to Christianity, and finally throws the relation away altogether, and lets what one is, mediocrity, pass more or less for the ideal. Faced with this *poetic* presentation, those concerned were [161] secure, they noticed nothing; only the article on Mynster startled them, and now that presentation was made out to be exaggeration etc. Then the poet transformed [ed. 73.8] himself; he brought out the *New Testament*, reminded them of the pastor’s oath on it, and now there was silence. He now spoke, for the time being *in his own name*, but ever more and more decisively; he began by putting the matter as favorably as possible to the opposing party, by pointing to the gentlest reshaping of the established order, but as this was spurned, the polemic sharpened; the contradiction in official Christianity, and in the pastor’s position, the distortion of Christianity, was brought forward ever more sharply, and finally he took it upon himself to say in his own name: *that it is guilt, a great guilt, to take part in the public worship of God*. Then at last *Christ’s own judgment on official Christianity was brought forward*, and from this moment the character of the polemic took on the utmost severity; Christianity’s opposition to the world, its requirement of dying to the world and of suffering, was presented in its whole unconditionality. / Suffering *from without* was stressed ever more sharply. God’s love expressed through suffering. The Moment VI,14f. VIII,12. [ed. SKS 13, p. 265f., p. 351f.] / With the deepest pathos there mingled annihilating *satire*: “Laughter, employed in fear and trembling, became the scourge” [ed. SKS 13, p. 301], which struck the established order, in which the relation is now so reversed that Christianity, which came into the world as the truth one *dies for*, has now become the truth *off which one lives*, comfortably set up, living by depicting that Christ was sacrificed, — struck the self-contradiction that the pastor, who at ordination relates himself to a kingdom that is not of this world, at the same time takes an oath to the State, which surely is of this world, thus the opposite of that kingdom;¹⁰⁹ struck the secularization that came with this relation to the State and made the proclamation of strict Christianity by such pastors impossible. The judgment was pronounced: *the*

¹⁰⁹cf. The Moment III,8 [ed. SKS 13, p. 191.]

clerical estate is, Christianly,¹¹⁰ in and for itself of evil, is a corruption, a human selfishness that turns Christianity exactly the opposite way round from the way Christ turned it; [162] it was said: naturally, there is in the clergy not one single honest man; [ed. 74.1] pastor became synonymous with perjurer. The Moment VII [ed. SKS 13, p. 302]. In the whole deception of Christendom an immensely comprehensive *criminal history* was sought, the fundamental confusion, the source of the distortion, is placed *in the concept Church or Christendom*.¹¹¹ Therefore everything was condemned by which this deception was supported, everything by which the decision of Christianity became insignificant; protest was made against *becoming a Christian as a child*, against the taking of the vow at a childish age, against the untrue “*hidden inwardness*” [ed. cf. SKS 12, p. 214], which is only the hiding place of indifference (cf. remarks on Protestantism, Bladartikler p. 95f. [ed. SKS 14, p. 173, col. 1.]) And as / the race’s *perdition in sin* was sharply accentuated, marriage was condemned (cf. The Moment VII, 21, 28f. [ed. SKS 13, p. 296, p. 301ff.]), and the ideality of the task called the individual away from every direction toward the external back to himself, to the *infinite task in himself*, to the *God-relationship*. Christianity was seen so ideally that not only did our age not satisfy its requirement, but it was even declared: “*Christianity has actually not come*¹¹² *into the world*; it stopped with the prototype and at most the apostles, but even they already proclaimed it so strongly in the direction of propagation that here the irregularity already began” (The Moment V,7 [ed. SKS 13, p. 231]). [Therefore Kierkegaard did not give himself out to be a *true Christian* either, but laid claim only to stating truly *what*¹¹³ *Christianity is*. (cf. Bladartikler. p. 102f., 109 [ed. SKS 14, p. 180f., p. 193, col. 2]. The Moment VI,15. IX.5 [ed. SKS 13, p. 266f., p. 374f.]. Practice in Christianity p. 241 [ed. SKS 12, p. 222f.]. For Self-Examination. p. 13ff. [ed. SKS 13, p. 46ff.])]

Thus the struggle continued “in agonies such as a human being has rarely experienced them, in an exertion of spirit that would rob another of his understanding” [ed. SKS 13, p. 124], in such exertions and agonies “that often enough his wish was death, his longing the grave, his desire that this wish, this longing might soon be fulfilled.” [ed. SKS 13, p. 134] And yet he could say: “Yet your love [ed. 74.2] O God moves, the thought of daring to love you inspires me — under the possibility of being omnipotently compelled — gladly [163] and gratefully to will to be what is the consequence of being loved by you and of loving you: one sacrificed, sacrificed on a race for whom the ideals are a fool’s prank, a nothing,

¹¹⁰cf. The Moment V,30 [ed. SKS 13, p. 249f.]. The Moment VII,40 [ed. SKS 13, p. 310f.]. (compare earlier *milder* utterances).

¹¹¹cf. Bladartikler, p. 95 [ed. SKS 14, p. 173, col. 1].

¹¹²cf. The Moment V,7, VI,16 [ed. SKS 13, p. 203f., p. 267].

¹¹³cf. 73.7.

the earthly and temporal the earnest thing, a race which worldly shrewdness in the guise of teachers of Christianity has shamefully, in the Christian sense, demoralized.” [ed. SKS 13, p. 124.] His wish and longing were fulfilled. Only for a few months did the struggle last; then he died, but his thoughts did not die with him, nor did the memory of his personality.

By the account I have given in the foregoing of Kierkegaard’s conception of the Christian, I hope it will have become clear both *how strict a coherence* there is in it — how unjustified, therefore, the scornful rejection by speculative dogmatics of a “fragmentary, unsystematic thinking” was — unjustified to an even higher degree because it came from a quarter where there appeared a complete lack of clarity and sharpness of thought, an almost comic confusion; — and also *how many problems have been brought forward*, how many new *categories* have been drawn into the light, how many *concepts* have been more sharply and more deeply determined, how perspicuously the *spheres of existence* are ordered according to their inner relation, with how sharp a *dialectic* guard has been kept over *the claim of existence*, over the ethical’s and [ed. 74.3] the religious’ inescapable claim on the individual in existence.

With regard to this, what is needed will have been made clear by my account, but with more definite regard to the problems that were set up when I concluded the critique of *Feuerbach*, I will here point out the contributions Kierkegaard has made to their solution, so as, when that is done, to bring out the *difficulties* his theory seems to me to leave behind, whereupon the *final result* of all these lectures can then be drawn.

We then set up *first* the problem: *what becomes religion’s relation to reason?* does thought become religion’s enemy, or can it enter into an inner and serving relation to it? With regard to this problem Kierkegaard has maintained the essence of religion as an *existence-relation*, as *life*, in opposition to every conception of it as a merely *thought-relation*, as a stage of development in *cognition*; he has sought to determine *the domain of objective thinking*, to set the boundary, where the *paradox* emerges and where thought, [164] in discovering it, is used to guard it; — he has sought, in the finite consciousness — in the *consciousness of sin* — what can bring the human being to hold fast *what conflicts with* [ed. 74,4] thought — and in the consciousness of sin at the same time the possibility of a *relation to the divine as something qualitatively higher than the human being*. Dialectic is thus seen as serving the religious relation; the spheres of *thought* and of *faith* are separated.

We set up *secondly* the problem: *what becomes religion's relation to the moral?* can it assert an independent place beside this, or must it be absorbed by it, or must it stand in opposition to it? — With regard to this problem Kierkegaard has determined the relation of the *ethical sphere of life* to the religious one, he has demonstrated the *dialectic in the ethical* which prevents one from holding it fast in isolation, the necessity that the religious must come forth, and he has sought to maintain the concept of *an absolute relation to the absolute*, an *absolute duty toward the absolute*, which is not exhausted in the ethical duties.

We asked *thirdly*: *how, when religion's independence is maintained, are its essence and distinctiveness to be determined?* — This Kierkegaard has described with the analyses given in the foregoing of the religious and the specifically Christian. By these analyses the position of the religious among the spheres of existence, its relation to thought[*ed.* 74.5], to irony and humor, and to *poetic ideality* has at the same time been determined. *Religion's reconciliation* is, as the reconciliation of actuality, distinguished from poetry's illusory reconciliation in the sphere of possibility, of the impersonally ideal.

We asked *fourthly*: *what is the boundary between what truly issues from religion's principle and what only through a ready relapse from the religious to the lower stages of spirit is brought into connection with the religious and confused with it?* — Here the norm for the separation is given in the analysis of religion's¹¹⁴ essence, in the categorical distinction of the aesthetic and the religious, and this distinction keeps out of the religious not only everything that has not gone through the *dialectic of infinity* [165] and *absolute resignation*, hence all *immediate existence*, everything *egoistic* that does not itself pretend to be the religious, but also, of what appears with the claim to be the religious, even the religious in a higher sense, everything that has a remnant of the aesthetic's immediacy in it, hence everything that seeks rest in an *unshakable, undialectical objectivity*, or relates itself *poetically* to the infinite, so that *the personality itself* has not made the movement of infinity, or that relates [*ed.* 74.6] itself to the absolute without the *possibility of offense* becoming at every moment the annihilated passageway of the relation and without the fear and trembling of *uncertainty* becoming the ground on which the certainty of faith rests. That separation thus gives the norm for judging / many of the "religious" phenomena Feuerbach has attacked, and / such expressions as: Christian world, Christian¹¹⁵ state, Christian art, etc.

¹¹⁴NB. The development in Works of Love. — The indirect polemic against Feuerbach's development of the relation between faith and love. (NB. The inward-turnedness in faith; the cessation of comparison — the conception of predestination.)

¹¹⁵NB. religious awakening. (The critique of Grundtvigianism, with and without mention of names, in Concluding Unscientific Postscript).

We asked *finally*: *what form of religion will be able to assert itself, either beside the moral and rational or in unity with it?* To this Kierkegaard answers decisively: *the Christian religion is the absolute*, which eternally asserts itself as the highest form of existence, which, as heterogeneous with history, is never absorbed by it in such a way that a new and higher form of religion could develop; which never at any time comes to stand in such a relation to the race's development that it needs accommodation, reasons, defense, since it is the unconditioned, which contains the judgment on the race, and before which the race has to defend itself. Another, higher form of religion is the impossible; every attempt at it is rebellion against Christianity, a *sin against the Holy Spirit*, is the intensified form of *despair*.

[ed. 74.7] Thus the problems set up have been partly solved, partly at least brought considerably nearer their solution by the penetrating analyses and the sharp determinations of concepts. I shall now attempt to point out the *difficulties* that still remain in Kierkegaard's theory, difficulties which at least prevent me from following him to the last point. I present these difficulties as *doubts*, for there is in Kierkegaard's theory one point that bears the contradictions and the difficulties, at least the essential ones, but to reach this point there is required a movement I cannot make. As such doubts, — and [166] as doubts that are not to tear down but only to clarify, I ask that what I develop in the following be regarded; I put them forward with caution before a thinker whom I admire, with modesty before a man who has been dear to me as few have.

[ed. note]

Kierkegaard (Lecture 27.)

The judgment on Christendom, as it is contained in what has been developed. — The consequences of homogeneity.

The character of "Christendom."

Kierkegaard's last writings. — The ideal Christianity. — "Practice in Christianity." — Intimations of the polemic earlier than the article against Mynster.

The course of development in the polemic: "witness to the truth" — the judgment on the established order: official Christianity — the pastor's position — the Christian world, — indifferentism. — "Will faith be found on earth?" [ed. SKS 12, p. 17.]

Kierkegaard's account of the course of the struggle in "What Christ Judges etc. of Official Christianity" Sharpening of the problem. — The satire ("Laughter in the service of fear and trembling." [ed. SKS 13, p. 301]!) — Emphasis on suffering from without. — Unconditional condemnation of the clerical estate. — Childhood Christian faith and confirmation. — Condemnation of marriage. — The exclusivity of the God-relationship.

– Doubt whether Christianity has ever existed.

Retrospect: The coherence in Kierkegaard's theory. — New problems and categories.
 — Sharper determinations of concepts — The ordering of the spheres of existence. — The How of existence.

Problems that were posed in the critique of Feuerbach.

I. Religion as existence-relation, as life. — The domain of objective thinking. — The paradox. — The consciousness of sin as bearing the paradox, and as maintaining God's qualitative difference from the human being. — Dialectic — The sphere of faith and of thought.

[167] II. The ethical and the religious.

III. The essence of religion. — its place in the spheres of existence. — Humor — Poetic ideality.

IV. The aesthetic and the religious. — Separating out the immediate.

V. The eternity of Christianity.

[ed. 74.7 continued]. Lecture 28

In order not to let the critique lose itself in scattered detail, I will keep to *two* main points at which the essential difficulties come forth; namely the determination of subjectivity's relation to objectivity and the determination of the religious.

a) *Subjectivity and objectivity.* — As the existence-relation was maintained against speculation, and as, in the determination of the human being as a [ed. 74.8] synthesis of the temporal and the eternal, the starting point was taken for a polemic against speculation's illusory eternity, the result was reached that *the existing individual* had to *choose* between the objective and the subjective relation to the truth, that they *could not be mediated*, and that, since the objective relation ended in a contradiction, the *subjective* became the only possible one. And in this subjective relation *the truth* / (i.e., the essential truth) / was for the subject only in the form of *faith*; its definition became to be *the objective uncertainty, held fast in the appropriation of the most passionate¹¹⁶ inwardness*; the *infinite passion* became its own content; the *negative infinity* became the one true expression in existence for the infinite,¹¹⁷ the infinite negative resolution became the individuality's

¹¹⁶NB. *God as postulate* (Concluding Unscientific Postscript p. 147 [ed. SKS 7, p. 182f.]).

¹¹⁷"In the infinite passionate interest in his eternal happiness the individual is in his utmost exertion — where God is *negatively* in the subjectivity, which in this interest is the form of eternal happiness". (Concluding Unscientific Postscript p. 36. [ed. SKS 7, p. 57.])

form for God's being in it. And subjectivity's highest form became *faith in the paradox*, in which passion, precisely through¹¹⁸ the repulsion of the absurd, is potentiated to the highest. — *Objective thinking* got its own limited domain, a domain that did not comprise [168] the personality's deepest interest, and whose truth, since the decisive conclusion was not possible, was always only an *approximation*, hence really a *hypothesis*. But in this domain thought gets its validity, and its warrant extends right to the point where the sphere of faith [ed. 75.1] begins; that far the use of it is warranted, and *within* the sphere of faith it gets the significance: *to guard the paradox*. But here essential *difficulties* arise. It must be asked: must not the subjective¹¹⁹ relation, *as a relation of consciousness*, translate itself into an expression in *thought*, and must not then, when this has happened, the contradiction in the thought-expression for *the absolute truth* react back upon the rest of consciousness's thought-content and *annihilate its truth*? In other words: *can the paradox's contradiction in thought be isolated?* and, if it cannot, does not all distinction between truth and meaninglessness vanish, does not *precisely the use of the understanding as a guard for the paradox become impossible?* When the paradox states the *unthinkable*: the union of God and the single human being in the person of the God-man; the coming into existence and becoming of the eternal / NB. The divergence in the development of this point in "Philosophical Fragments" and in "The Sickness unto Death". — (The becoming of the *necessary*) / within¹²⁰ finitude, when by the determination sin it states the transformation of human nature, the individual's paradoxical transformation, the loss of eternity, / the eternal which the human being nevertheless cannot get rid of (cf. The Sickness unto Death, p. 11 [ed. SKS 11, p. 132f.] / , which in the forgiveness of sins, in faith, is won again, and won in such a way that it in the same moment eternally presupposes itself, do not all these determinations then contain what, translated into an expression in thought, comes into conflict with all the *laws and forms of thinking*, and, in expressing *the truth*, makes what conflicts with it the untrue. Or [ed. 75.2] is logical thinking not to be touched by the contradiction because it belongs in the sphere of *abstraction*, and not in that of *actuality*? But whether Kierkegaard defines abstraction [169] as the abstract *prototype* for or the abstract *reproduction* of concrete actuality, there nevertheless remains such a relation between it and actuality that the transformation of the latter changes the former. Or is actuality to be capable of being split in such a way

¹¹⁸NB. the paradoxical (the relatively paradoxical) prior to the sphere of the Christian. (the Socratic ignorance.)

¹¹⁹NB. the insufficient developments in Nielsen's Propædeutik pp. 74–80. By his separation of subjectivity and objectivity, subjectivity becomes the thoughtless, the irrational, the life of consciousness irreconcilably split. — (NB. The subject is surely also a member in the objective order of things.) (NB. the ethical resolution. Thought's share in it.)

¹²⁰The coming into existence of the eternal (NB. Religiousness A and the Christian).

that one domain becomes thought's, another that of the unthinkable but absolutely true? Are we not thus led to the unthinkable representation of a *divided whole of existence*, two defective universes, of which the untrue *grounds* the true and makes it *finite*. And if we let this representation stand as belonging *under the paradox itself*, the consequence nevertheless remains that in the disrupted human nature, which has become another with sin, thought, which surely is *the expression of the essence*, has remained the same and remains so when nature is again transformed. There remains the difficulty: *how the reception of revelation, which presupposes a re-creation of the individual, can let the individual's ideality in its self-consciousness persist*. The paradox is *the miracle in the world of thought*, but just as the miracle in the world of nature annulled the concept of nature, and of natural law[ed. 75.3], so the miracle in the world of thought must overturn the laws of thought, bring *skepsis* in, and make doubtful the thinking that is to distinguish the paradox from nonsense and guard the former in order to hold it fast as paradox, as the absolutely unthinkable. Life seems, under this presupposition, to dissolve into *confusion*, / the life of consciousness to be effaced, the highest forms of individual existence to fall into unconditional discord / , and the task to become *also in the sphere of thought to cast the world away in order to be only in the paradoxical God-relationship*. — Whether the *consciousness of sin* has the tensile force to bear these difficulties, to keep the spheres apart, I do not decide; I only point out the difficulties.

In the account of Kierkegaard's development of the subjectivity-relation I have conducted myself only historically, as a reporter. Here is the place to call attention to what applies both to the difficulties I have already pointed out and to those I will point out in what follows: that the *philosophical presupposition* from which his polemical development proceeds is *the conception of speculative philosophy as philosophy's highest form*, and of the *Hegelian* as speculation's most consistent execution. Against speculation's volatilization of existence the polemic is directed which maintains existence; but when thought's relation to existence is determined, the starting point becomes *speculation's conception* [170] *of the eternal*, the very determination of the human being [ed. 75.4] as a synthesis of the temporal and the eternal shows through there, and the conception of *actuality* becomes the *idealist* one; it is presupposed everywhere that *the sensuous is the deceptive*, the sensuous world is illusion, / sensuous actuality is seen everywhere as something secondary, an *inexplicable* addition to the eternal. / From this presupposition it follows, when the determination of finitude is accentuated in opposition to speculation / (and for this speculation itself gives the warrant) / , that eternity — which must after all always be present in order to give continuity — determines itself for the existing individual

as *something to come*, / which is always grasped only in *uncertainty* and in the form of *abstraction*, that it therefore only in *passion* gets momentary concretion, and that *the individual's own ethical actuality* / (which again is conceived as something *inner*) / remains as the only actuality for the individual besides the paradoxical actuality of the *object of faith*. In these consequences lie the difficulties: that the eternal¹²¹ gets momentary existence and becoming, *without*¹²² *yet being determined for thought by this*¹²³ *becoming*. This eternity becomes *the abstract eternity of speculative philosophy*, only¹²⁴ in such a way that it first gets the reality of being *when becoming is annulled*. But the fact that becoming *is to be annulled* posits becoming as something transient, *something that is not to be*, that eternity as what is properly true — for the beings existing in eternity's one true existence.

If — and to this the development of philosophy points — *another philosophical starting point* is taken, the matter seems to present itself differently, and that determination of the subjectivity-relation and of thought's relation to existence to receive a [ed. 75.5] different conception. If the *one, all-embracing* absolute moving itself in an *eternal* process, *as it was determined by the speculative philosophy that volatilizes actuality*, does not become the definitive truth, then the *single*, the individual, must get essential original significance, existence and thought must get a different position toward each other. / — Thought gets an *essential* hold, a real fullness in the individual consciousness, whose foundation is not [171] something merely vanishing; it / *becomes immediately concrete through consciousness*, / (thus it becomes an activity that is not merely the activity of “the eternal”) / *and the abstract universal* (thought's *negative*) becomes *what is identical in the concretion*, the *a priori, negative* foundation; / The *a priori* — (in its abstraction and negativity) — becomes in the single existence, precisely when this is seen as a member of a comprehensive total organism, the abstract but only possible thought-expression for the all-embracing ideal-real. (NB. its real existence in feeling, in passion, in love.) / *The single existence* is seen here as *the concretion of “the eternal”*, the single *sensuous-spiritual* existence as something true that has content precisely through its individuality and its unity with the other individualities in the *a priori*, which is present *whole* in every moment, precisely because it *does not become*. That¹²⁵ *which is to come* is then no more than *that which is present* something eternal: *the eternal is the individual that in the a priori has the form*

¹²¹cf. the enclosed leaf. [ed. note]

¹²²NB: to *become* infinite.

¹²³(we get the unthinkable before the paradox proper.)

¹²⁴We get no starting point for such a concrete knowledge, on which the ethical resolution must rest.

¹²⁵NB. to become *consciousness*.

of infinity and of isolation's¹²⁶ annulment (NB. the always identical a priori's relation to reality. — The problems of logic and of ethics meet here.). (In *passion* the individual is in its highest *self-affirmation* while at the same time it *affirms the universal*: only in passion is it therefore¹²⁷ productive, *creative* — both spiritually and bodily.) — [The concept *guilt, reconciliation* and the like is not annulled by that starting point, but reconciliation is sought *within the human* in the *supplementing* individuals who in love *communicate* their essence.]

[ed. 75.6] b) *The determination of the religious*. — In the foregoing the dialectic has been demonstrated by which Kierkegaard lets the *ethical* standpoint point beyond itself to the *religious*, the necessity of a *higher assistance for the individual* in order to regain himself, and the determination of the relation to this higher as *an absolute relation to the absolute*. In the *God-relationship* there is therefore a *particular* relation given, which [172] *does not exhaust itself or become concrete* in the particular ethical relations, and, as the *absolute duty*, can require the renunciation of them *all*. With this distinction essential difficulties arise once again. When the requirement is set that the human being *shall at one and the same time relate himself absolutely to the absolute τελοος and relatively to the relative ones*, then it must be asked: / since to relate oneself to an absolute τελοος is *always* to relate oneself to it, for to relate oneself to it *now and then* is to relate oneself to it *relatively*, but to relate oneself to it relatively is to relate oneself to a *relative τελοος*, / with what power does the human being then relate himself to the relative ones? If it is a power *different* from the one with which he relates himself to the absolute, then the latter surely becomes limited, *relative*; but if it is a part of the latter power, then he surely relates himself, *in the relation to the relative ends*, to the absolute. — Can the human being, it must *further* be asked, renounce *all* the relative ends? He can do so in one moment, in which, in the resolution, he gathers up existence *in an abstraction* over against *the abstraction of the eternal*; but *in actuality*, in which he exists in this determinate concretion, he renounces only the one “finitude” / (the one relation) / *with the power by which he exists in the other*. And even the power by which the *resolution* is taken, with which one abstracted [ed. 75.7] from the determinateness of existence, is a determinate,¹²⁸ *limited*, finite power, *in the direction of the abstract*. — But when it thus seems,¹²⁹ that the religious does not come to be distinguished from the ethical, but that

¹²⁶The individual that becomes conscious of itself as concrete and in its concretion becomes conscious of the a priori gets in this consciousness a guarantee of an objective truth. What cannot be left unthought without the individual's consciousness being disturbed, without its falling into discord with itself, is for the individual *the objectively true*, but the true *by virtue of the subjective consciousness*.

¹²⁷Consciousness gets for its object an actuality outside the ethical actuality.

¹²⁸cf. Concluding Unscientific Postscript p. 361 [ed. SKS 7, p. 428.].

¹²⁹NB. The expression: the ethical-religious.

it becomes *the soul in the ethical*, which latter cannot be thought through without the former, then this also finds its confirmation when it is held fast *that the ethical comes forth only as the movement of infinity is made*. The *eternal*, to which the relation is in the religious, thus does not come forth *first* on the domain of the religious; it first comes forth there as *the all-embracing eternal* (in that it is not sought merely in the individual, which *asserts itself by itself*), but precisely *through the abstraction, in which it remains (as the infinite negative), it is not to be distinguished from the eternal of ethics*, and it seems one-sided to hold fast the single ethical duty as *merely single*, finite, without the eternal and the relation to it coming forth in each single one. Should the eternal, on the domain of religion, have the closer determination of *personality*, then¹³⁰ determinations [173] would be required here that are *not* given (— it is only said: God is *subject*, and as such exists only for subjectivity in inwardness), and his compatibility with the absolute cannot be demonstrated for thought. — And *finally* it must be asked: does not precisely the dialectic by which Kierkegaard arrives at giving the ethical subject *content* again presuppose a different[ed. 75.8] fundamental philosophical view from the one from which Kierkegaard takes his point of departure, and *precisely the one that was intimated above* and that led to other possibilities both in the solution of the problems touched on earlier and in this one? When difficulties thus arise in the determination of *the relation of the ethical to the religious*, no fewer arise in the determination of *the relation of the Christian to the preceding spheres*. What Kierkegaard calls *Religiousness A*, and which, without corresponding to a determinate *historically manifested* form of religion, is to comprise the actual religiousness that is not yet the Christian (thus presumably also the *Jewish*, although e.g. in “Fear and Trembling” *Abraham* is depicted as the father of “faith”), and which presumably most nearly recalls *the conception of God in Greek thinking* — contains a *relation to the eternal*, and it is conceded that it at least *could* take place in paganism, since it had only *human nature as such* as its presupposition. But when the determination of Christianity comes forth: the determination *hereditary sin*, the loss of eternal being, the ignorance of this loss, then the question becomes: *in what sense, then, can the human being, from this point of view, have related himself to the eternal?* and if he has related himself to the eternal, *what difference then remains between the eternal to which pagans related themselves, and the eternal that becomes the determination of the Christian God!?* On this point there seems[ed. 76.1] also to be an *uncertainty* in Kierkegaard, for while

¹³⁰That the individual, which in the consciousness of guilt collapses before the ideal requirement of the ethical, must seek a higher assistance in order to regain itself, Kierkegaard at once determines more closely thus: that the higher, to which the individual comes into relation, becomes a higher *outside* individuals, so that the relation to the higher thus becomes a *particular* relation, an absolute relation to the absolute, which constitutes an absolute duty toward the absolute.

on the one hand the concession touched on above is made, *there is missing* on the other hand *that the pagan had representations of God* (The Sickness unto Death, p. 119 [ed. SKS 11, p. 228]), and when the consequences of the determinations of the Christian are [174] rigorously carried through, we arrive not only at the result *that Christianity has never come into the world*, but also *that Religiousness A becomes only a possibility* in uncorrupted human nature, and so, under the presupposition of hereditary sin, has never become actual either; and finally, *that neither has the ethical ever been able to exist*, / not merely understood in the sense that it has not been able to exist *justifiably as ethical*, / *since* the ethical is only a sphere of transition, which cannot be thought through without reaching the¹³¹ religious, and which, held fast as the ethical in its isolation, would become sin, despair; — but in the sense that it has not been able to exist at all, since it presupposes a relation to the eternal. This leads us on to a *new difficulty*. When we proceed from the Christian conception of existence, from the *relation of opposition* between Christianity and the world, from the requirement¹³² to *die away*, to hate one's natural life, *does it not then become impossible to get*¹³³ *an ethical content to subsist together*¹³⁴ *with the Christian*? Is not the incompatibility conceded in essentials by the polemic against marriage? / cf. The Moment VII,32 [ed. SKS 13, p. 304f.].¹³⁵ Practice in Christianity p. 267. [ed. SKS 12, p. 244f.] / Can what is touched on in Concluding Unscientific Postscript p. 374 [ed. SKS 7, p. 442f.] lead to an opposite result? Does it become possible to let the ethical keep a place, just as the understanding was to keep its place in spite of the paradox? [ed. 76.2] But if it does not become possible, *will not the ethical then constantly remain standing as a justified protest against the Christian*? will not the one who sees something divine in the ethical precisely thereby find an insurmountable obstacle to making the leap into the¹³⁶ domain of the Christian?

[175] These difficulties in the determination of the relation of the ethical to the religious, and of the relation of the Christian to the preceding spheres of life, seem to me to be the essential ones alongside those developed under a). Yet alongside them stand *others*, which are not of slight weight; *thus* when God is determined as the qualitatively higher than the human being and yet the determination of the divine is kept in the form of

¹³¹therein lies the consequence that the one possible existence in actuality becomes the one that recognizes the ground of concrete individuality as something essential.

¹³²Must not the content of existence vanish in the *absolute opposition* to the eternal truth?

¹³³cf. the abstract character of the historically manifested "Christian ethics".

¹³⁴(NB. the abstraction of eternal happiness. Concluding Unscientific Postscript pp. 300–06 [ed. SKS 7, pp. 356–65.]).

¹³⁵cf. the consequences of Kierkegaard's polemic against the established order demonstrated in previous lectures.

¹³⁶NB. Comparison of this critique's results with the earlier set-forth determination of the Christian view of life as *abstract-spiritualistic*.

ignorance and of negation; — *when* the relation of the human and the divine in faith is to be determined, where on the one hand faith becomes a *requirement*, a “You shall,” and yet faith can be given only by God, so that what is left over for the human being becomes only this: by himself to become nothing, self-annihilation (NB. its possibility), his only capability this: to become conscious that he is capable of nothing (NB. Freedom and grace — predestination. The remark about Socrates in Kierkegaard’s last writing [ed. cf. SKS 13, p. 405, The Moment 10]. Faith in the absurd in the direction of redemption); — *when* the Christian dogmatic determinations are rendered in a form in which they seem to acquire another content, e.g. when an *eternal consciousness* is posited as [ed. 76.3] a synonym for *eternal happiness*; and *finally* when the dialectic employed, by which the determination of guilt is posited in its totality,¹³⁷ seems to throw the guilt from the individual over onto existence or the author of existence, and¹³⁸ to make guilt a *metaphysical* concept, which becomes = *finitude* (cf. Concluding Unscientific Postscript p. 405f. [ed. SKS 7, p. 479ff.]) (NB. Kierkegaard’s relation to *Protestantism*. — Faith¹³⁹ — imitation, suffering.)

The difficulties developed seem to me to remain in Kierkegaard, and they prevent me from following him to the final goal where he found rest. I do not, however, present them as *definitive* objections to his theory, but have on the contrary pointed to the point in the theory itself in which the theory’s tensile force lies, and it is perhaps — I do not decide that — for the one who can make the movement by which he reaches this point, [176] great enough to bear all these difficulties. For him the demonstration of them will then only give the relation to the paradoxical a new intensity; for others they must help to make the *choice* with clearer consciousness.¹⁴⁰

From these developments, which I do not want regarded as a critique properly carried through, least of all as a rejecting one, I can now pass on to concluding these lectures, in that for this purpose I first briefly recapitulate their course, *and the* [ed. 76.4] *partial results gained*, in order *then to gather the final result* from these. —

¹³⁷NB. The determination of the essence of the human being, the self’s relation to God. (The Sickness unto Death — Either/Or II.)

¹³⁸NB. the “losing the condition for the truth” (Philosophical Fragments [ed. SKS 4, p. 223f.]) The concept: *eternal truth*. — the extent in which it is used by Kierkegaard.

¹³⁹Bladartikler p. 95 [ed. SKS 14, p. 173.]

¹⁴⁰But that point: the consciousness of sin presupposes faith: the theory thus closes itself in a circle into which only a leap leads.

[ed. note]

[ed. 1] *Kierkegaard*: (Lecture 28.)

1) *Subjectivity and objectivity*. — can the contradiction for thought in the paradox be isolated? — NB. Abstraction and actuality — the splitting of actuality — the relation of thought to essence — receptivity to revelation. The identity of the individual. — The paradox as “the miracle in the world of thought” — Only the God-relationship seems to have to remain.

Kierkegaard’s philosophical presupposition. — The conception of the eternal. — Actuality. The sensuous. — Consequences. — The difficulties: the becoming of eternity, its abstraction. — The untruth of becoming.

Intimation of another philosophical point of departure (see opposite page).

2) *Determination of the religious*. Kierkegaard’s determination of the relation between the ethical and the religious. — Difficulties: at one and the same time to relate oneself absolutely to the absolute *τελος* and relatively to the relative ones. — Can the human being renounce *all* the relative ends? — The eternal *in* the ethical in relation to the eternal in the religious. — the single duty. — God’s personality — The dialectic by which, in Kierkegaard, the ethical gets content.

[177] *The relation of the Christian to the preceding spheres*. — Religiousness A. — has it existed? (NB. The relation in it to the eternal). — Uncertainty in Kierkegaard — The consistent result.

Christianity’s relation to the ethical.

Other difficulties. 1) God as something qualitatively higher than the human being. 2) The relation of God and the human being to faith. 3) The rendering of the Christian dogmatic determinations. 4) The dialectic of guilt.

Transition to what follows.

[ed. 2] Intimations of another point of departure (see opposite page) What is to be *avoided* by them is: the contradiction that the eternal acquires *momentary* existence, and a *becoming that does not determine it*. What is to be *gained* is: 1) that eternity becomes just as fully something *present* as something to come, — 2) that thought in individual existence gets a ground that gives it *content*, and that this content, since the ground is something *essential*, acquires *efficacy*, so that the certainty of the abstract eternal does not become the only certainty, the ideal ethical actuality not the only *actuality*. 3) that in this knowledge of an essential ground, in which a knowledge of the a priori is contained,

there is given a guarantee of an *objective* knowledge, a *real knowledge* by virtue of the subjective consciousness.

Determination of “*the eternal*” (cf. 75.5)

The relation of subjectivity. — The certainty that is necessary in the ethical domain in order to be able to begin to act. — The certainty in the God-relationship. —

Life and thinking.

[ed. 76.4 continued] Lecture 29.

1. *Recapitulation of the content of the lectures.*

(With regard to the part of the lectures that falls in the *previous semester*), the draft for Lecture 1 of this semester is used. — The *relation of divergence*, which already then showed itself between the principle of Christianity and that of modern philosophy and [178] of the modern age in general, now finds its closer determination through what has been developed in *this semester*, especially through *Feuerbach’s* and *Kierkegaard’s* theories. — Both agree in conceiving the relation as a *relation of opposition*, in wanting to keep the two spheres apart from each other; although the interest is different in them, and the individual analyses essentially divergent, they nevertheless agree in — what also became our *provisional* result — *that Christianity is not the ruling spiritual power of the modern age*. By the intimations given in the critique of Kierkegaard’s theory it has also been confirmed that what, — in opposition to Christianity — governs the spiritual life of the modern age is a *positive* principle of life, which is able to unfold itself into a coherent view of existence which lacks neither the distinctive character of the *ethical* nor that of the *religious*.) [ed. 76.5] With regard to what has been developed in *this semester*, the presentation and critique of the *attempts at restoration* are first recalled. It is first pointed out in general how this critique on the whole led to the same result as the critique of the similar attempts discussed in the previous semester, namely: *that* they were unsuccessful, and *that* what prevented them from succeeding was precisely the influence of the tendency heterogeneous with Christianity and characteristic of the modern age.

In particulars, then, with regard to *Fr. Baader*, the result gained by the critique of him is recalled: that all *theosophy is fantasy*, and all *immediate theosophical cognition of nature*

fantastical, — *the deviation from the Christian* in him is recalled. With regard to Schelling's philosophy of revelation, the critique of the concepts is recalled: "*the individual being that is all*", and "*free cognition*" — the determination of the philosophy of revelation as *fantastical theosophy*; the demonstration of the influence of the representation of God's *personality*, and of the reason for the *deviations from the Christian*. With regard to *speculative dogmatics*, the critique of the determination of *the essence of religion*, of *the science of faith*, of the *general conception of existence* is recalled, and the critique of the development of the *individual dogmas*.

With regard to the *negative tendency*, which [ed. 76.6] was discussed as the opposite of speculative dogmatics, the *problems* brought forward with it are recalled: the relation of reason as an inwardly moving power in the religious, and: the relation of philosophy and religion to the individual.

[179] Passing then to the last section of the lectures: *the separation of religion and philosophy*, Feuerbach's and Kierkegaard's views are first provisionally juxtaposed. Then, with regard to *Feuerbach*, the most characteristic *results* at which he arrives are brought out: "The absolute essence is the human being's¹⁴¹ own essence";— "The infinity of the object is the expression of the organ's own infinity"; — "Ignorance of the divine is the negation of the divine", — "Religion is the human being's first and indirect self-knowledge." — Religion's systole and diastole; — the subjective and practical character of religion; — the contradiction in the religious representations; their necessary dissolution into the anthropological; — the opposition between faith and love, the consequences¹⁴² of this; — the development in Feuerbach's later writings (*Wesen der Religion* — *Theogonie*.) — (Reference to the critique of Feuerbach.).

As regards *Kierkegaard*, reference is made only to what was developed in the previous lectures, and [ed. 76.7] since this returns to what was set forth at the beginning of the hour, it proves to be the task still remaining to set the two opposites, which show themselves historically to stand over against each other, against each other, so that the final choice can then be made. This becomes the task for the concluding lecture.

[ed. note]

[ed. 1] *Lecture 30.*

Connection with the preceding lecture.

¹⁴¹"It is impossible for human thought to think something qualitatively higher than the essence of the human being."—

¹⁴²The necessity of "atheism".

Of what character will the ethical-religious view of life that is different from Christianity be? The answer negative — positive.

Results of the critique of the realistic series of development — of the idealistic.

The task of philosophy. — Feuerbach's attempt at a solution of it. — The difficulty at [180] which he stopped (compare Herbart.)

Outline of a conception of existence: individual existence — the whole of existence. — Unity of nature and spirit — The ideal-real. — The natural ground of the ethical. — How the ethical comes forth. — The definition of ethics. — — The a priori in the ethical. — The relation to time — Avoidance of the egoistic. — Resignation. — Guilt, repentance — reconciliation, higher assistance.

Relation to the modern age's conception of nature — relation to Feuerbach.

The religious moment in this ethical view of life. — The relation of faith — The absolute. Its determination. (Ignorance). — The pantheistic. — God's personality. — In what the personal relation to the absolute consists. — The persistence of personality after death.

(verte)

[ed. 2] Elements for this view of life in the modern age. — The one-sidedness and superficiality in the various theories. Their ground. — The possibility of avoiding them.

Relation to the view of life of Greek antiquity. — Influence of the Christian — The conception of the ethical — of the natural.

The Christian and the humane. — The determination of both — The mixed forms. — The essential element in them. — The necessity of a distinction and a choice.

Conclusion.

[ed. 76.7 continued] Lecture 30

2) *Final result*. — Since the *provisional* result gained earlier with regard to the relation of Christianity and the modern age's view of life has been confirmed by the theories last presented; since in particular the Kierkegaardian analysis of the Christian,¹⁴³ which with strict consistency attaches itself to its most concentrated expression, and only develops [181] what is given in it, has led to seeing the divergence in its sharpest form; and since at the

¹⁴³(Through Kierkegaard's analysis of the Christian a double result has been gained: 1) the disagreement between Christianity and philosophy, 2) that our age does not live in the Christian determinations. But since, as earlier, the tendency of the modern age has been shown to agree with the principles of modern philosophy, that double result is gathered into one.)

same time the critique of the Kierkegaardian determination of the relation between the ethical and the religious has intimated the possibility of a *unity* of these that is *different from the Christian*, then, in conclusion, this view of life is accordingly to be worked out more definitely in its relation to the Christian, so that the choice between them can then be made.

The question is then asked: *of what character will the ethical view of life / be, for which the elements are given in the tendency of the modern age and which, as it combines these elements into a thoroughgoing whole, comes to/ stand over against the Christian?* Negatively [ed. 76.8] the answer to this question is given with the historical presentation and critique of the two main tendencies of modern philosophy; for a *positive* answer the elements lie / in the earlier analyses of the principles of modern philosophy, and / in the intimations that are given in the critique of Kierkegaard's view.

The *negative* result that was gained by that presentation was this: *that neither one-sided realism nor one-sided idealism was able to form the foundation for an ethical outlook on life that could be carried through.* It became evident in the critique of the *realistic* series of systems that it negatively had to end in *skepticism*, positively in a *materialism*, in whose fundamental concepts the dualism of medieval thinking asserted itself, so that it could not be carried through without falling into the contradiction with itself of having to take up concepts which it could not deduce but could not do without either, and, by taking up what is inexplicable by its principle, itself admitted its one-sidedness, which was given by the fact that this tendency's fundamental concept, *matter*, which was posited as *all*, was determined as it had to be determined *within the dualistic opposition to spirit*, and therefore constantly had to be supplemented unconsciously by the opposite. — At this tendency's terminal point every ethical foundation was lacking, *everything became physics*, and the first concepts of physics [ed. 77.1] stood unexplained and inexplicable.

In the critique of the terminal point of the *idealistic* series, the *Hegelian* system, it [182] likewise became evident that neither could this tendency, in its full execution, constitute an ethical view of life. It became apparent that a one-sidedness similar to the one that had made materialism end in a self-examination made the idealist tendency end in a *volatilization of actuality*, whereas precisely the requirement was made that it be taken up into thinking. The unity of being and thought became merely the unity of monistic thinking with itself, actuality became merely a vanishing phenomenon in the eternal process of the absolute, nature came to be only for human thought, while it was eternally sublated in the absolute idea's closing together with itself; the foundation of the concrete ethical disappeared, as the eternity of thought — and the eternity of *abstract* thought

— became the one thing that is, in which nature and existence in time became merely something vanishing, which did not make the idea richer in content. Ethics was here transformed into *metaphysics*, and all the problems of *existence* remained unanswered.

The one-sidedness of the two tendencies pointed toward another form of philosophy, whose *task* could be expressed negatively and quite abstractly thus: *to recognize the distinctiveness of spirit and of nature without dualism*. An attempt at this task's [ed. 77.2] solution was made by *Feuerbach*, in that he asserted the significance of the *sensuous*, the *natural*, the *material*, the essentiality of *individual existence* as the ground of the abstract universal, and sought in nature not merely dead matter but *life and spirit*. But however far his *sensualism* departed from the materialism of the preceding century, reawakened in the natural sciences of our time, the critique of his system nonetheless showed how he, in developing the consequences, ran aground on difficulties he could not remove, how his very premises pointed beyond *that* at which he stopped; the dissolution of existence into atomistic individuals — a dissolution that is also characteristic of another, richer system, which makes the concept of individual being its fundamental concept: the *Herbartian* system.

From the point at which Feuerbach stopped, we are thus directed, / when the results of the historical critique are recalled, / toward a view of existence in which the *essentiality of individual existence* is asserted, but *not atomistically*; for the independence and eternity of the atomistic contain a contradiction for thought; but in such a way that the thought of a *unity and wholeness of existence*, an *organic order of existence*, without which thought loses its hold in itself and dissolves into skepticism, is joined with it. And as the individual [183] existence is seen as an *inseparable unity of nature and spirit*, as the being of spirit is *indissolubly* bound to the being of nature, [ed. 77.3] *the ideal that unites existence becomes at the same time something real*, something actual, something *natural*. Human existence then acquires a *natural foundation*, determined not as that which is to be given up, but as *that which is to be taken up into consciousness, to be permeated by it*. The *ethical* emerges as the single individual in his¹⁴⁴ individual distinctiveness knows himself *as a member of that comprehensive whole*, has himself *as a task as such*, and thereby makes *the movement of infinity*. / Ethics becomes *the doctrine of the realization of the human essence through free human action*, but the human essence is realized as its natural foundation is permeated by the life of consciousness and consciously ordered into a higher whole. / This ethical then acquires a *content*, precisely through *the individual's natural determinateness*, and it acquires *its regulative in the a priori*, which in the domain of ethics acquires the same

¹⁴⁴NB. Kierkegaard's dialectic with regard to the ethical.

validity as in that of logic. It has *time* and *actuality* as its stage, not the abstract eternity of speculation; it does not lose itself, as materialism does, in the egoistic, *for the individual knows himself only as a member of a higher whole*. It does not attempt to hold itself fast in an isolation, it rejects / not *resignation*, / not the determination of *guilt* and *repentance*, not the need for a *reconciliation*¹⁴⁵ and a *higher assistance*. But resignation remains when it is given an ethical *content by virtue of the ethical itself*; as each single form of the ethical is seen as an expression of a relation to the absolute, there is no absolute relation *outside* the ethical, but it becomes *omnipresent in the ethical*. The whole compass of the ethical cannot then be given up for an “absolute[ed. 77.4] duty” that does not express itself in it, but the ethical *from a lower sphere* can with justification be given up for the ethical *in a higher, more comprehensive one*. The ethical individual who recognizes the ethical’s *infinite requirement* bows under the feeling of *guilt*, recognizes the justification of *repentance*, and the need for help *from outside*; but as *the whole of existence* is seen as borne by the all-embracing, *its harmony as a whole therefore cannot be thought of* [184] *as disturbed* / and therefore the individual existence’s *essence* cannot be thought of as transformed either, / then the help is sought not outside existence, but the reconciling powers are sought *in* existence, in the *other, supplementing individual beings* with whom the individual joins *in love* / in *mutual communication of essence*. / In love for the human being as human being *reconciliation* is then sought, and in it is seen not merely a relation to the single individual but *a relation to that which binds together, an expression of the unity*.

This view thus appropriates *the modern age’s conception of nature, divergent from Christianity*. It recognizes the *essentiality of the natural*, its *positive* significance for spirit, its significance as the *foundation* of a *concrete ethical life*. Nature becomes not merely that which *gives thought fullness*, that without which thought loses itself in the abstract or the fantastic, but it becomes *that which bears the whole of human life* and gives it fullness and content. *To master nature* through the cognition of nature’s laws can become an *ethical task*; *in all ethical relations nature becomes the foundation*.

Likewise this view appropriates [ed. 77.5] what is true in *Feuerbach’s* theory. *Ethical relations are seen as religious*, precisely because the relation to the absolute is expressed *only* through them; *in the relation of human being to human being* the human being realizes *the highest*; this relation has *absolute* worth in and for itself.

When the *religious* moment in this ethical is to be determined more precisely, it becomes that by which the human being sees every relation as resting in the absolute,

¹⁴⁵NB. can philosophy recognize a disturbance in the whole of existence? If it cannot, what then becomes the consequence with regard to the concepts freedom, guilt, etc.? (cf. *The Sickness unto Death*).

sees the all-embracing eternal at every point of existence as bearing it. There comes to be room for a relation of *faith*; for this absolute, eternal, which holds existence together, is not *immediately* visible to the single consciousness; it becomes *a postulate* of the individual consciousness, which without it would become confused in itself, would lose its hold in itself. Faith then rests *on the human essence's very consciousness of itself*; it does not come into conflict with this, but *confirms* it. It becomes a faith in that which is *higher than the individual*, in that it embraces *all* individuals and *the whole of* existence. But thought has no determinations for it higher than those that express its own essence as *human* thought; it cannot negate itself by thinking something that is *qualitatively*¹⁴⁶ *higher* than the human; it therefore has only *abstract* determinations for [185] the all-embracing absolute; *to that extent ignorance* becomes¹⁴⁷ the form of the relation to the absolute, and the abstraction of "ignorance" first acquires [ed. 77.6] *determinations* through *the cognition of the real universe*, which is seen as revelation of the absolute, and through *the ethical*¹⁴⁸ *relations* that include a relation to the absolute.

If one objects against this religiousness that it is *pantheistic*, I shall not attempt to repel this objection. *All consistent philosophy must become pantheistic*; for as an attempt to bring about a unity and wholeness of cognition, it can posit no break in the world of thought; but the highest thought must be linked with the whole series of thoughts, and becomes that which bears the others within itself; but *this highest thought becomes philosophy's expression for the divine*. The determination *personality* philosophy will therefore not be able to apply to it; every attempt to prove God's personality by way of thought must, as has already been developed at an earlier point of these lectures, fail; for in these attempts determinations must be left out without which we could not conceive of personality or see it given in actuality, / and precisely the distinguishing of the divine as something personal leads to all the contradictions in the religious representations that *Feuerbach* has demonstrated, and that we earlier found already brought out by *Spinoza*. /

The *personal relation to the absolute* then becomes *the personal relation, permeated by faith in the all-embracing absolute, to other personalities, the communication of the essence of one's personality to them in love. The appropriation of their personality in reconciling love*; and this communication and this [ed. 77.7] appropriation give the single personality life and duration in *the form of personality even after the dissolution of personality* by

¹⁴⁶NB. Feuerbach's developments.

¹⁴⁷(In this way contradictions in the common religious representations are avoided.)

¹⁴⁸This religiousness becomes *a religiousness without dogmas*, — (different from the dogma-less religiousness of the philosophy of faith in that it takes seriously the unity of the divine with the human and the natural; — different from the Schleiermacherian in that the absolute is in the actuality of the world itself); — its *cultus* becomes *action*, ethical action; its ideal is that *the whole of life* becomes cultus.

death.

In the *fundamental view* on which modern philosophy and the whole life of modern times rest, and to which we have traced back the various nuances of its forms of appearance, we find the *traces* of such an ethical-religious view of life, different from the Christian. They emerge in *the faith in the human*, in the undisturbable good in the human essence, in *the recognition of nature's* essential significance for human thought and human life, in *rational faith*, / in *moralism*, / in *humanitarianism*, in *the philanthropic*, in the fundamental thought from which the more significant *socialist* systems have proceeded. They have been present everywhere, more recognizably or less recognizably, and everywhere in connection with one-sidedness or superficiality. Their *one-sidedness* has been grounded in the opposite one-sidednesses of realism and idealism; their superficiality in the fact that the ethical problems were not grasped more deeply, that the faith in the human, that humanitarianism and philanthropy did not have / *resignation* and / *the consciousness of guilt* as their background, that therefore ethical earnestness was lacking and the problems of will and freedom did not stand out sharply, the need for reconciliation and the religious conception[ed. 77.8] of ethical relations were lacking. But, as has been shown above: *these defects and one-sidednesses can be supplemented and have in part been supplemented without the ground of the view of life being given up*, without the significance of nature and of the human, of human thinking and of human ethical relations being distorted or disappearing.

In this view of life the humane and natural view of life of *Greek antiquity* is preserved, but it has *through the Christian* not merely acquired the *universal* character that antiquity lacked, but antiquity's aesthetic-metaphysical conception of the ethical has been replaced by a *really ethical* conception, in which all the determinations that antiquity hurried past, the determinations of *will*, *freedom* and *guilt*, are more sharply specified, and *the end point of the ethical* is no longer the *political relation to the state* but the *ethical-religious relation to humanity*¹⁴⁹ and to the absolute revealing itself in it. The conception of the *universe* has become a different one, as antiquity's *metaphysical* conception of the physical has been replaced by a *physical* one, for which the natural *as such* becomes something *real*, and as something real acquires the possibility of becoming *a content-rich material for thought*, a *foundation for an ethical relation*, both of which acquire with it the fullness of *actuality*.

Two powers thus stand opposed to each other in the modern [ed. 78.1] age, two different views of life assert themselves in the new age. We can name the opposites: the *Christian* and the *humane*. What the *Christian* is, Kierkegaard in particular has stated

¹⁴⁹NB. Works of Love.

sharply and clearly; through his analysis it has become plain what lies in Christianity's fundamental determination; it has been shown that the Christian so determined decisively distinguishes itself from all the phenomena that I have earlier brought forward, / which is what its relation to *thought* and to the whole of *natural* existence becomes, — (NB. abstract spiritualism — dualism.) — / and that, if the Christian is *not* what he states it to be, then it cannot be distinguished categorically from what historically precedes it, that it would thus have no specific distinctiveness.

What it is that I call the *humane*, I have sought to demonstrate throughout the whole lecture course by bringing out moments in the distinctive view of life of the new age, and now in what immediately precedes by sketching the outline of the ethical-religious view of life that expresses it. With the help of this it will be easy, in all the *mixed forms* in which the Christian and the humane seem to have entered into a *unity* / (“Christian world”, “Christian state”, “Christian ethics”, “Christian science”, “Christian art”, etc.) /, to carry out the separation. It will show itself everywhere *that the Christian here is only a name, a reminiscence, a remnant for the imagination, but that the content belongs to the humane*. It will prove to be *an illusion* to believe that in these forms one dwells in the Christian, which is only *an aesthetic admixture*, an *indeterminate, featureless* something[ed. 78.2], which nowhere has validity / and by which no *actual* relation to Christianity is constituted. / *And yet the admixture of it is enough to rule out that a wholly human life is lived, that one lives really ethically in the ethical*.

So there remains then only *one choice*, and when the opposites have been sharply and clearly distinguished from each other, then let each make the choice honestly and self-consciously!

With this I close these lectures. What I have wanted is consciousness, honesty, clarity. Against illusions and confusion I have fought; I have striven to distinguish for thought what was mixed together, unconsciously or deliberately, and in this mixing was distorted. In order to be able to do this, I have used the freedom of science, which this [188] university possesses perhaps in a higher degree than any other university in Europe at this moment; I have let thought have its say, and presented the attacks on the established order with the same thoroughness and sharpness as the defense. But in making full use of this freedom, I have been conscious of the obligation that it laid upon me. I have spoken earnestly about what is earnest, I have spoken the strict language of science and of personal conviction; only against the frivolous and the thoughtless have I used the weapon of mockery, and only then when, by calm scientific consideration, it had

proved to have fallen forfeit to it. Perhaps [*ed.* 78.3] at the decisive point my way parts from that of most of you; but even if that is so, it is my hope that those whose way is a different one from mine will also now be able to walk it undisturbed by doubt and less exposed to delusion, and that those who can follow the way I go will be able to do so with consciousness and clarity, without discord in the mind, without dispersion in the spirit.

For the interest with which you have followed these lectures right to the end, I offer you my sincere thanks. It has not only been personally dear and encouraging to me, but it has been a sign to me that interest in the science that I have the honor to lecture on has not died out, that the studies too which do not belong to the official circle of the bread-and-butter studies have their devotees. What I have only been able to intimate in these lectures, which were essentially of a historical-critical kind, I hope one day, if time and strength are left me, to find occasion to present in detailed connection. Until then I ask you to be content with what I have been able to give here, and to keep a friendly memory of these hours, and of the spiritual fellowship that we have lived with one another in them: a fellowship during which I feel that I myself have developed.

Receive, then, in parting, a friendly farewell!

(Last lecture, given on 31 May.)

25 May 1859.